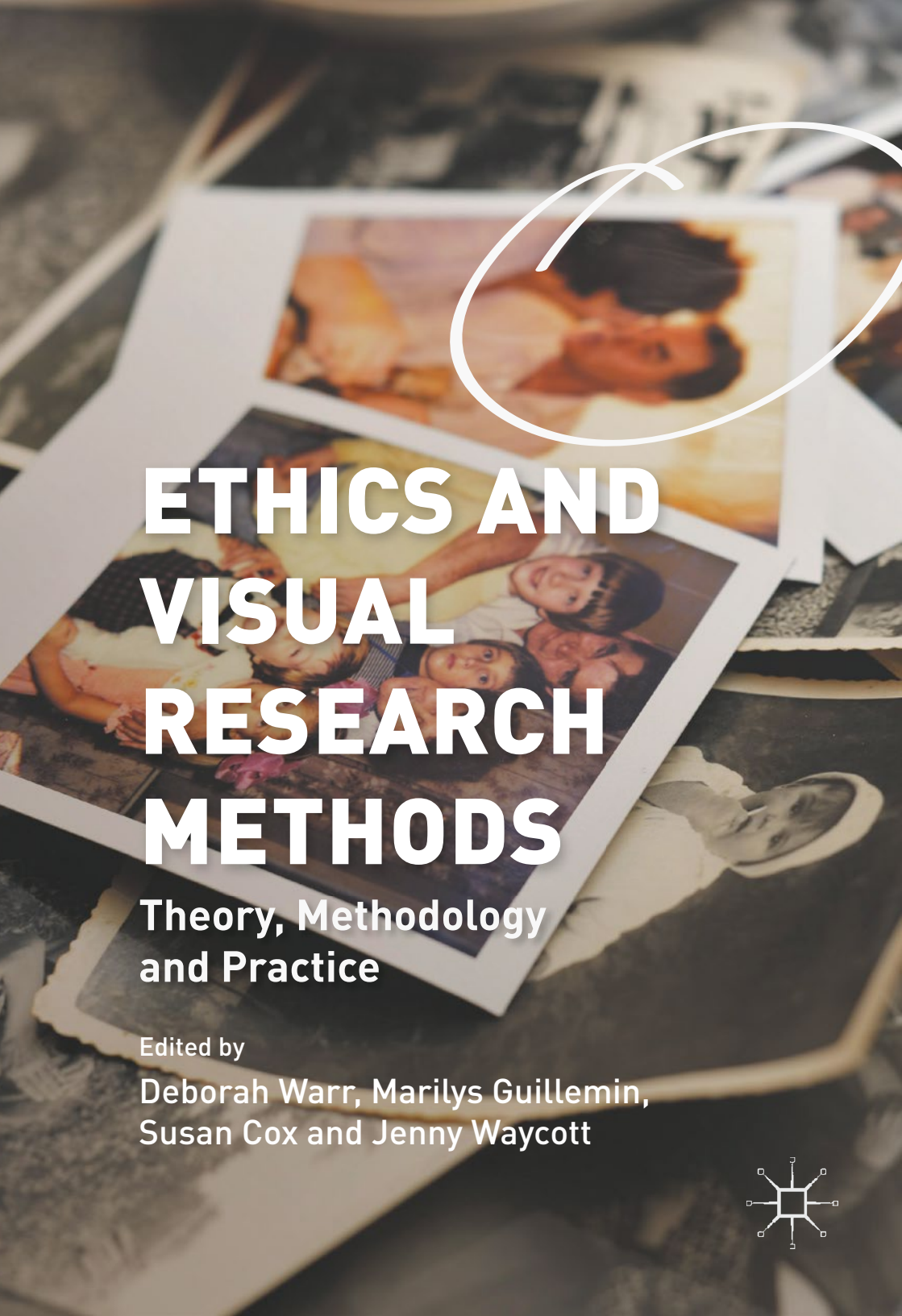


ETHICS AND VISUAL RESEARCH METHODS

Theory, Methodology and Practice

Edited by
Deborah Warr, Marilys Guillemin, Susan Cox and Jenny Waycott

Ethics and Visual Research Methods

Deborah Warr • Susan Cox • Marilys Guillemin • Jenny Waycott
Editors

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Theory, Methodology, and Practice

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In memory of
Dr. Sarah Drew

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CHAPTER 1

Ethical Issues in Visual Research and the Value of Stories from the Field

Deborah Warr, Jenny Waycott, Marilys Guillemin, and Susan Cox

Introduction

Visual research has been gaining prominence since the 1940s. One of the best known and earliest uses of visual methods in research is Bateson and Mead's 1942 study, *Balinese Character*, documenting ethnographic analyses using photographs of Balinese village life (Bateson and Mead 1942). Visual research in anthropology continued to dominate, until the rise of visual methods in sociology in the 1960s and 1970s. Prosser (1998) and Harper (1989) documented the move toward visual research in sociology during this period, highlighting the use of photographic representations of social life and social inequalities. Visual sociology is indebted to Howard Becker (1974a, b) who sought to develop the rigor of visual methodologies, including the role of theory, reliability and validity in the field of visual research. Since these early beginnings in anthropology and sociology, visual research has since been incorporated into the methodological toolboxes of many other academic disciplines including geography, cultural studies, health studies, psychology, urban studies, design, art research and performance studies. Expansion into these varied disciplines

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has occurred in parallel with a proliferation of approaches for conducting visual projects and visual media that can be analyzed. Visual data analyzed by contemporary researchers includes photographs, video stories, video diaries, drawings, portraits, cartoons and 'found' images that are generated or gathered by participants and researchers in 'stand alone' and mixed methods studies.

Research involving human participants is inevitably laced with issues of ethics, and social science research that probes individuals' experiences of personal and social worlds poses particular kinds of ethical obligations. In a foreword to his collaborative book that explored situations of social and economic disenfranchisement, *The Weight of the World* (1999, 1), sociologist Pierre Bourdieu asks, 'How can we not feel anxious about making **private** worlds **public**' (emphasis in the original). For Bourdieu, social research is grounded in tacit (and therefore potentially problematic) conditions of trust between researchers and participants. Researchers bear responsibility to protect participants from the dangers of exposure and misrepresentation (Bourdieu 1999). Visual research methods that offer new modes of private expression should elicit, if not anxiety, then conscientious attention to risks that are arguably heightened by the descriptive and explicatory potential of images. It is only relatively recently, however, that attention has focussed on specific ethical dilemmas and challenges that are associated with the evolving possibilities of visual methods (e.g., see Gubrium and Harper 2013; Clark 2012; Pink 2011a; Prosser et al. 2008; Rose 2012; Wiles et al. 2008).

These discussions grapple with the ways in which visual methods are reworking familiar ethical principles and introducing new kinds of ethical risks. Following other discussions of research ethics, there is consensus that ethical issues cannot be boiled down to a set of instructions, and necessitates careful and open reflection on the practice of research, including the contexts in which it is conducted. There is also broad agreement that some ethical issues encountered by visual researchers are familiar to all social researchers. Such issues are typically framed by ethical principles that require researchers to prevent or minimize potential harms associated with participation in research, protect participants' anonymity and confidentiality and ensure participants are able to give informed consent to participate. Other ethical issues become more prominent in visual research than they might be for other methods. They are associated with authorship and ownership of data, the circumstances of projects that have multiple and disparate aims and issues of representation and audience reception

(Waycott et al. 2015). This summary of key ethical issues does not cover the gamut of ethical issues that may arise, but encapsulates sets of issues that are particularly relevant to visual research.

Ethical research builds on a professional culture that has a shared understanding of the aims and risks of research, and which generates grounded precepts that can guide its everyday practice (Kendig 1996, 143). These precepts are grounded because they crystallize insights gleaned through sharing stories from the field in ways that seek to identify common issues and effective strategies for promoting ethical research. This collection contributes to efforts to generate grounded understanding of methodological and ethical dilemmas that are encountered by visual researchers, and the practices they develop to address them. Researchers consider real-world ethical issues, explain the strategies that were used to address these issues and note those that remain unresolved. The breadth of settings and methodological approaches that are discussed reflect our conviction that visual researchers should aspire to transcend disciplinary differences and establish common understanding of what constitutes ethical practice when using visual research methods.

Ethical Regulations and Guidelines: Where Are the Gaps?

Ethical challenges arise at all stages of the visual research process: from research design, recruitment of individuals or collectives, data collection, analysis and presentation and dissemination of research findings. Guillemin and Gillam (2004) provide a helpful framework that identifies two dimensions of research ethics. The first dimension, conceptualized as 'procedural ethics', refers to the ways in which researchers must abide by the formal regulatory systems that guide institutionally based research. Most developed countries have research ethics boards or human research ethics committee (REBs or RECs, depending on the national or institutional context), and protocols and systems of governance that operate to review, approve and monitor the processes of procedural ethics for human research. Researchers must be able to demonstrate that they have satisfactorily addressed a number of requirements, including providing a detailed plan covering such things as how research participants will be recruited and how meaningful informed consent will be obtained, in order to gain approval to commence data collection. This process of 'procedural ethics' requires researchers to identify in advance, and be prepared for, ethical

issues that are likely to arise. In some instances, procedural ethics requires researchers to justify why the research is needed and that it is methodologically sound.

The other dimension of research ethics is conceptualized as 'ethics in practice' and refers to the unanticipated and contingent ethical issues that arise in the process of conducting research in real-world settings (Guillemin and Gillam 2004). 'Ethics in practice' requires researchers to uphold key ethical principles while responding to ethical issues that may present in unexpected ways. Ethics in practice can be particularly fraught for researchers working at methodological frontiers where experimental research practices generate emerging and unanticipated ethical issues. As visual methodologies become established and continue to expand, both researchers and REB/REC members must learn to recognize the spectrum of potential risks and assess the adequacy of ethical responses.

The failure for REB/REC members to grasp the potential and risks of methodological innovations results in two sorts of problems in relation to procedural ethics. First, projects may gain approval to proceed although there are outstanding ethical issues that have not been considered. Conversely, worthy and rigorous studies may fail to gain approval to proceed because visual methodologies are not well understood by review board members (Daly and McDonald 1996). The latter is perceived as a widespread problem that discourages researchers from pursuing methodological innovation (Nind et al. 2012) and can foster antipathy between researchers and ethics review boards (see Cox, Chap. 19). Ethics review boards therefore need to be reassured of the value of visual methods so that they can assess relevant projects fairly. Once projects have gained ethics approval, researchers are likely to encounter issues of ethics in practice because they are operating in complex and dynamic settings. Responding appropriately to emerging ethical issues when conducting and disseminating research is enhanced through shared understanding of ethical issues among researchers using visual method sacross diverse disciplinary and research contexts, and engaging with those charged with overseeing the processes of procedural ethics.

Codes of practice and disciplinary guidelines are important resources for visual researchers, although they do not all address the specific circumstances of visual methods (see, e.g., the *National Statement of Ethical Conduct in Human Research in Australia*, 2007, and the *Canadian Tri-Council Policy Statement*, 2nd Edition). The International Visual Sociology Association (IVSA) has produced a helpful Code of Research

Ethics and Guidelines (2009) which sets out general principles followed by ten statements of ethical standards that the IVSA expects of its members. Wiles et al. (2008) have also provided a review outlining key ethical issues for researchers using visual methods. These guidelines tend to be disciplinary specific. Within contexts of advancing methodological innovation and increasingly hybridized disciplinary fields of research, inclusive discussions of ethical issues are invaluable for navigating uncharted waters and cross-fertilizing good ideas. It is also useful to understand the methodological potential of visual research because this is strongly related to the ethical issues that may be encountered.

Why Use Visual Methods?

Drawn by the potential for research participants to reflect on and describe experiences in new ways, social researchers are collecting and analyzing an expanding range of visual data. Gillian Rose (2014) identifies three key claims that are made about the methodological appeal of visual methods. These are capacities to generate rich data, often in combination with other modes of data collection such as oral, textual and sensory experience; explore 'taken-for-granted' experience and tacit forms of knowledge; and foster participatory and support collaborative processes of knowledge creation. While it should not be assumed that these varied capacities are to be achieved simply by using visual methods, they may be realized through the skill, imagination and thoughtfulness of researchers and the involvement of interested and committed research participants.

In addition to now well-established visual methods, such as photovoice and photo-elicitation, the possibilities for visual research are flourishing through developments in, and the growing availability of, digital technologies. These technologies offer capacities for research participants to produce images and videos, sometimes independent of researchers, while geospatial mapping techniques and 'wearable' cameras create new forms of visual data enabling researchers to systematically collect volumes of visual data in ways that research participants may be scarcely aware of. The contemporary proliferation of visual culture is also demanding the attention of researchers who are analyzing content posted on social media, gaming sites, video blogs, online memorials and other online platforms to gain insights into transforming social worlds.

Researchers have recognized the potential of visual methods to engage populations who have been marginalized from processes of research. They

can also supplement or even supplant 'standard' research techniques that use discursive methods, such as interviews, questionnaires and focus groups. Visual methods are increasingly being used in combination with other novel methodologies, such as mobile methods (Hall 2009; Ross et al. 2009), to generate 'multi-sensory and multi-model' data in the form of images, sounds and movement (Pink 2008, 2011b). This expanded expressive potential has led to visual methods being considered useful for researching experiences that participants may not be able to readily formulate and communicate in words, and for research involving participants, such as children and people with cognitive and physical disabilities, who may not always be able to articulate their thoughts and experiences in words.

The participatory possibilities of visual research methods are also of considerable interest to researchers. Participants can have active roles in visual research by creating drawings, photographs, videos and other artifacts that communicate ideas in ways that make subjective sense. Giving presence to experiential accounts of social life that have otherwise been overlooked imbues research with potentially significant epistemological and political effects. Visual methods can reframe what counts as valid forms of knowledge, and compelling visual representations of social issues can be used to foster public interest and galvanize social action (Pink 2008).

Visual research methods are also being adapted to explore and reflect on the significance of arts-based, performative and aesthetic practices. In these fields, visual researchers study art works and installations, theater and dance performances, relationships between art and social and political practices, representational effects and the personal and social outcomes of involvement in creative processes.

With expanding applications for visual research methods, it is not surprising that they present new ethical dilemmas and challenges and there is much to be learned from researchers working at these methodological frontiers. To facilitate this learning from practice we developed an international project that comprised a series of interactive forums involving visual researchers and members of REBs/RECs. The structure for the project demonstrated our conviction that formulating ethical tenets requires processes that serve to build consensus within communities of practitioners. The project also stimulated the reflections that are collected here so we briefly explain how we went about it, and the six key sets of procedural and ethics in practice issues that were identified as particularly relevant to visual research methods (Waycott et al. 2015; Cox et al. 2014).

Engaging Visual Researchers in Discussions of Ethical Issues

We describe our approach as an *in vivo* (within the living) method that refers to research conducted in natural environments. It is a description that conceivably applies to many social research projects, and particularly ethnographic projects, but they are rarely explicitly described as such. A vivid exception is found in Loic Wacquant's book *Body & Soul* (Wacquant 2004, 16) where he describes an extended participant observation study that he conducted in a boxing gym in South Chicago as an *in vivo* approach. We invoke the notion of an *in vivo* method for an enquiry that draws on research stories from the field to answer a series of questions: Were visual research methods generating new kinds of ethical issues? What strategies had researchers developed to respond to these ethical issues? What are the unresolved ethical issues?

We asked researchers working in universities from around the world who are using visual methods for social research to prepare discussion papers that responded to these questions, and invited researchers and REB/REC members to participate in facilitated discussions, workshops and consultations (Howell et al. 2015). Some workshops were standalone events and others were included in the programs of international conferences. Discussion papers and notes were analyzed for content and themes, and the preliminary findings were tested at subsequent workshops and obtaining written feedback from key informants. This iterative process crystallized six categories of ethical issues: consent; confidentiality; minimizing harm; fuzzy boundaries; authorship and ownership; and representation and reception. These categories informed the development of ethical guidelines for visual researchers that have been widely disseminated (Cox et al. 2014). Notably, the guidelines address separately both visual researchers and REB/REC members; and they are not intended to be prescriptive but rather to identify critical questions for researchers and REB/REC members to consider. An overview of the six categories rehearses key issues that are explored in the following chapters.

Consent

Respect is a key ethical principle that is upheld by enabling individuals to make informed decisions about whether they want to participate in research. Consent must be voluntary and based on having access to sufficient information that clearly explains the purpose and aims of research, what is required from participants and any risks that are posed to them. The conditions for obtaining informed consent are now well established

in research practices, and include thoughtful understanding of the circumstances in which participants may lack capacity to give informed consent. The exigencies of visual methods, however, are likely to require standard processes for gaining informed consent from participants to be reconsidered. For instance, it may be preferable to negotiate consent in stages (e.g., to collect data, to analyze data and for dissemination and public engagement). This is because visual research projects are more likely to involve discrete, but interlinked, creative and research components. Participants may also need opportunities to consider plans for how visual data will be used in reports or exhibitions before giving their consent. Researchers may also need to consider issues of consent in relation to the depiction of third parties who may appear in visual data generated in the processes of research, and which can involve legal considerations. Cultural protocols and sensitivities may also apply to the dissemination of photographs of deceased persons.

User-generated content posted onto social media sites are potentially rich veins of data that are also being mined by researchers. Research involving 'found' images, videos and other visual artifacts can present barriers to obtaining informed consent from the subjects and/or owners of images that are used as forms of data. Social media has notable tendencies to dissolve distinctions between public and private with effects of complicating issues of consent. Researchers therefore need to consider the intended audiences of material found on social media sites, the feasibility of seeking consent to analyze visual data or devise alternative ethical strategies that uphold the principle of respect for individuals who may not be aware that they are the subjects of research.

Confidentiality

Researchers should protect participants' privacy and confidentiality. Confidentiality is an obligation not to use private information for purposes other than those for which it was given. Participants must trust researchers to maintain their anonymity and confidentiality even though they usually will not know them. The implications of camera-based methods for visual research are particularly important to consider here because photographs and videos are capable of creating highly detailed and intimate portraits of individuals.

Among qualitative researchers, preserving research participants' privacy and confidentiality typically involves tactics such as assigning pseudonyms to participants or using numbers or personas when quoting data. These

strategies are less effective when referring to visual, rather than textual, data. Blurring or pixelating faces or other image content to de-identify participants or their associates, either directly or indirectly, is sometimes used; however, it may be impossible to completely de-identity participants without diminishing the richness of the data (Prosser et al. 2008). Further, such tactics can be in tension with expectations for research integrity that obliges researchers to be accurate and honest when presenting their data (Jordan 2014). Jordan (2014) also argues that although image management can be justified in some circumstances, researchers should avoid manipulating images in ways that can be construed as deceptive, misleading to the expectations of participants or causing harm. She offers succinct and useful guidelines for altering identifiable images when reporting the findings from visual methods studies (Jordan 2014, 451).

Complicating these issues is the ease with which digital images can be replicated and shared, and this means that researchers may have limited control over images that are generated for research purposes. Technological advances, including automated facial recognition and Global Information System/Global Positioning Systems technologies, can also subvert the efforts of researchers to promote the confidentiality of research participants. Automated cameras such as the SenseCams, small portable cameras that are usually worn around participants' necks, are also increasingly used for the purposes of research (Kelly et al. 2013). The cameras capture an image every five seconds and thousands of images over the course of a day, potentially intruding into the private spheres of participants' lives and those of others they encounter. Preserving confidentiality in visual research projects is becoming increasingly complex with the use of these visual technologies.

Some researchers suggest that ethical norms for maintaining confidentiality can be in tension with other aims for visual research, including objectives of promoting participant empowerment by dispersing autonomy and ownership in research relationships, and enabling socially and politically marginalized participants to have visual presence and voice (Tilley and Woodthorpe 2011). This can introduce thorny ethical dilemmas when multiple objectives involve diverging rationales. Nespor (2000) has explored tensions that arise when ethical obligations to anonymize research sites can limit the local usefulness of research findings; and may be ineffective if key words typed into search engines easily circumvent researchers' efforts to obfuscate the distinctive features of towns and suburbs. These issues are also relevant to funding contexts that increasingly

emphasize accountability to funders and expectations to engage in knowledge dissemination in ways that further erode the capacities of researcher to anonymize research settings (Tilley and Woodthorpe 2011). If confidentiality cannot be assured, researchers must consider other strategies for protecting participants' privacy and confidentiality or which minimize the risks if participants and research settings are identified through their involvement in research.

Minimizing Harm

It is incumbent on researchers to prevent or minimize harm to participants through their involvement in research, while maximizing potential benefits. Harms associated with social science research range from provoking discomfort, distress, regret, embarrassment, shame and other negative emotions, to representing participants in ways that provoke unfavorable public perceptions, including being subjected to ridicule or hostility. In some circumstances, participants can be placed at risk of experiencing physical harm, for example, projects exploring women's experiences of family violence (Gubrium et al. 2014). Depending on research topics, opportunities for participants to have intense and creative involvement in visual research projects may trigger traumatic memories (Mori et al. 2013). These potential harms mean that participants may come to regret sharing personal information with researchers. In research projects using visual methods, involvement in creative activities can mean participants are exposed or vulnerable to criticism, particularly when visual artifacts are shared with audiences. These risks are heightened when the research involves social groups that are marginalized and susceptible to being misrepresented and stereotyped.

In research addressing emotionally painful or sensitive topics that explore 'intimate, discreditable, or incriminating' behaviors (Liamputtong 2007, 2, from Renetti and Lee 1993), the differing effects for participants, researchers, artists and audiences should be carefully considered. The emotional impacts of involvement in research can also intensify when research data are generated through collaborative engagement over extended periods of time (Warr 2004).

Fuzzy Boundaries

Characteristics associated with visual research methods, such as affinities with participatory methods, inclusive possibilities for generating knowledge, contact between researchers and participants extending over periods

of time, and combined research and other activities, involve heightened potential for research-related activities to be less clearly evident to participants than for other methods. Research might span aims of generating new knowledge, advocacy, community engagement and creating visual artifacts or performances where clear distinctions in the roles of researchers, participants, artists and other social actors are dissolved in some projects. Researchers need to manage and integrate these multiple aims in visual research projects. When participants are involved in producing or co-producing visual artifacts, they are required to commit levels of personal investment and creative energy in excess of the usual expectations of participation in research. Photographs, artworks and other artifacts created by participants during their involvement in a research project may simultaneously possess personal meaningfulness, aesthetic significance and represent forms of research data.

Projects involving artists (musicians, dancers, painters and others) are also blurring boundaries around research purposes and roles, and frequently taken-for-granted distinctions between what constitutes research and artistic practice. Researchers are increasingly collaborating with artists, and artists are conducting their own research projects. These exciting possibilities for visual research methods are nonetheless introducing new tensions in managing competing objectives and possibilities of research.

Authorship and Ownership

Research participants may be involved in generating visual data by working alone or in groups, and in collaboration with researchers or artists. These varied processes complicate issues of authorship and ownership of visual data and artifacts. Sustaining respectful relationships with participants mean that researchers need to consider and acknowledge participants' authorship and ownership of material and ideas as appropriate. This includes seeking permission and input when exhibiting artifacts in dissemination activities. Authorship and ownership are also important considerations in relation to the storage and long-term display of visual products that are generated in the course of research projects. These issues must be negotiated when artifacts have been co-created. Gaining group consensus in deciding what to do with larger pieces of work, for example, mosaics, large paintings, sculptures, may also be required to resolve questions of how to display and store work.

Photographs and videos can be easily replicated for participants to have their own copies and participants and researchers could use these

materials for their own purposes. Researchers may also need to consider issues of copyright over 'found' images. Research participants, who may be unfamiliar with procedural ethics and potential legal obligations, may need some guidance from researchers in managing these processes once researchers have exited the field.

Representation and Reception

In his essay, *Understanding*, the sociologist, Pierre Bourdieu (1996) argued that research can inflict 'symbolic violence' when it misunderstands or misrepresents research participants. For Bourdieu, the potential for misrepresentation is intensified when researchers and research participants occupy different positions within social structures. Socially disempowered and marginalized participants are highly vulnerable to being subjected to symbolic violence through research. These concerns are inevitably heightened when participants are portrayed using words and images. These kinds of risks point to the obligations of visual researchers to protect the dignity of participants. Langmann and Pick (2014) conceptualize dignity in research as a context-dependent construct that involves related notions of dignity-in-process and dignity-in-outcome. To promote dignity-in-process, researchers should include participants in decision-making processes on how they are to be portrayed and to carefully consider how audiences might receive and interpret visual data. Dignity-in-outcome requires researchers to provide some benefits for participants, offer faithful portrayals of their situations and avoid portrayals that invite derision or mockery (Langmann and Pick 2014: 713).

These considerations are important because visual artifacts generated through research can take on a life of their own once they are shared publicly. Audience members can engage and interact with research products in positive and respectful, but also unintended and disagreeable, ways. The potential to inflict symbolic violence is closely linked to what are described as 'reality effects' of research. These occur when research contributes to reproducing conditions that researchers set out to merely describe (Champagne 1999). Reality effects are particularly potent when research is focusing on populations that are vulnerable to being stereotyped and stigmatized because representations (images, words and numbers) that are generated through research may operate to confirm, rather than challenge, the assumptions and possible prejudices of different audiences. These issues should be central concerns when displaying the outcomes of visual research projects, including for exhibitions, and particularly, printed, digital or web-based formats

that are likely to have diverse audiences. If visual data can be readily replicated and shared by participants and audiences, researchers may need to provide some guidance on how to safely share these materials.

Stories from the Field

This overview of key ethical issues suggests they are complex, overlapping and intersecting, and that methodological and ethical issues are closely intertwined. Ethical issues are evolving in response to new kinds of research questions, settings, populations and contexts. The following chapters offer reflexive insights into the ways in which these and other ethical issues emerged in diverse research projects, and how researchers responded to unfolding situations. In emphasizing the value of research stories, we are acknowledging the oft-noted importance of sharing stories about research practice as a means of enhancing ethical reflection and accountability (Hallowell et al. 2005; Plummer 2001). Importantly, engaging with each others' stories assists us, as researchers and those who have responsibilities to grant ethical approval to research projects, to navigate the anxiousness that Bourdieu noted is incumbent to endeavors, such as research, that make private things public. The aim is not to arrive at definitive instructions for being ethical visual researchers, but rather to learn from others and promote shared understanding of ethical practice.

The remainder of the book has three parts. While there is considerable flow of ideas across these sections and chapters, they have been arranged to highlight the diversity of research settings and methodological approaches for visual research. Part I, 'Intersections: Methods and Ethics', features discussions of key visual methods, and attendant ethical issues, in research projects involving a range of populations and topics. Part II, 'Ethical Issues in Contexts', focuses on projects involving sensitive and complex research questions and settings, and particularly vulnerable populations. Part III, 'The Ethics of Researching Art and Artful Research', shifts to a field of research that tends to be overlooked in many discussions of visual methods, that is, research into the visual arts and projects that use arts-based practices for disseminating research findings. These chapters highlight critical tensions at the intersection of art and research. The final chapter in the collection takes a broad vantage point on the expanding fields of visual research and proposes a new paradigm to guide the ethical practice of visual research. This would result in researchers and members of ethics boards and committees viewing each other, not as adversaries,

but as allies in a common quest; this endeavor acknowledges the mutual importance of both methodological innovation in a complex and ever-transforming world and robust ethical practice that seeks to maximize the benefits of research. This is an encouraging note on which to conclude.

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PART I

Intersections: Methods and Ethics

The chapters in this section offer discussions of methodological approaches for visual research methods and the ethical issues that were raised. The ethical issues that are explored are related to procedural ethics and, more frequently, 'ethics in practice', that is, issues that were not anticipated, and therefore required direct responses from researchers. These situations arise because of the complex settings in which the research was conducted and circumstances that were generated through the possibilities of visual methods. We benefit from the experience of our authors as they discuss the ethical issues encountered and how they addressed them.

In Chap. 2 Cathy Vaughan takes us to the Highlands of Papua New Guinea and presents a Photovoice project she conducted there. This was a participatory research project with young people, involving formally trained researchers and community members from diverse backgrounds. During the course of the project, ethical tensions arose regarding the use of particular photographs. Embedded in this were issues of differing ethical norms and values held by the parties involved.

Hyunjoo Jung presents a research project in Chap. 3 that employs mental mapping. This method is used to explore the experiences of women immigrants who had moved to South Korea through commercially arranged marriages. The benefits of this method are presented, in particular when dealing with socially vulnerable participants. Jung's aim in the research was to ensure participants were co-producers of knowledge in the research. However, ethical issues around anonymity and authorship were encountered and Jung discusses how these were addressed.

In Chap. 4, Bjorn Nansen and colleagues provide a reflection on the use of an ethnographic software application used in a digital ethnography project conducted in domestic households. This chapter considers both the methodological and ethical issues that arise during the project. The intersection between these two realms reveals both beneficial and disruptive effects for both researchers and participants.

The use of digital visual research methods is expanding exponentially. In Chap. 5, Anna Harris discusses the ethical dilemmas she and her collaborators faced when undertaking a study of YouTube videos made by users of online genetic testing services. Although some of the ethical issues they encountered were anticipated, there were other concerns that arose. The chapter discusses the challenges of borderless research, ownership of data, confidentiality and obtaining consent.

Chapter 6 also presents stories from the field; Carly Guest explores the intersecting methodological and ethical issues encountered during a study that explored the development of a feminist consciousness among participants. In this project, participants shared photographs that were significant to them in relation to their feminist becoming. This chapter focuses on issues that arose during analysis and interpretation of the images, and points to the need for reflexive research practice to address these issues.

The final chapter in this section, Chap. 7, moves the focus to the effects of visual research methodologies, not on participants, but on researchers. Kim McLeod and Marilys Guillemin discuss a research project where participants generated photographs to share their experiences of antidepressant use and wellbeing. Much of the focus on ethics emphasizes the prevention of harm to participants. In this chapter, we are reminded that visual research methods can also have serious impact on researchers. The impact of photographs on researchers is discussed, together with potential strategies to mitigate this impact.

CHAPTER 2

Different Lenses: Navigating Ethics in Cross-Cultural Research Using Photovoice

Cathy Vaughan

Introduction

> [Mike's[1] photograph] *With his weathered and grimy face he looks in his thirties, but cannot be much more than twelve years old. Barefoot, wearing dirty and torn clothes, he is holding what I presume to be a joint in one hand and is drinking out of what used to be a bleach bottle in the other. I guess it holds stim* [potent and illegally distilled alcohol]. It is night and he is somewhere with a dirt floor and a wall made from bush materials. A hut or market stall perhaps? He is looking straight at the camera, clearly knows he is being photographed, and his eyes squint through the haze of smoke. There is an element of bravado, posing for the photo—but then, this is a real kid. Who is he? Where is he? What can we do about him? Should we? What on earth do I do with this picture? [Author's field journal, February 2007, Papua New Guinea]

In this chapter, I reflect on some of the ethical challenges I have encountered during participatory research projects using visual methods. In particular, I reflect on issues that arose during *Tok Piksa*, a Photovoice project undertaken with young people in the Highlands of Papua New

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Guinea, which I use as a case study to explore the different lenses through which researchers and participants view what is 'ethical' in research. By way of background to these reflections, I first provide a brief overview of participatory approaches to research, Photovoice as a particular tool used by participatory researchers, and then discuss the case study project.

Participatory Research

Participatory research can be broadly defined as 'systematic inquiry, with the collaboration of those affected by the issue being studied, for the purposes of education and taking action or effecting change' (Green et al. 2003, p.419). Cornwall and Jewkes (1995) describe participatory research as being an approach in which research participants define research problems and generate, analyse, own and act on the information that is being sought, in collaboration with external researchers. However, they also highlight that research approaches can be viewed as a continuum with an ideal of participatory research at one end and an ideal of conventional research approaches at the other. Most research endeavours will be positioned at different locations along this continuum, at different stages over the life of a research project. Rarely are research projects entirely located at one, or the other, end of this continuum. Participatory approaches to research draw on diverse theoretical underpinnings, including those of action research (Lewin 1946/1948), feminism (Frisby et al. 2009), rural development (Chambers and Guijt 2011) and critical pedagogy (Freire 1974/2005). Because of these varied origins, participatory research should be seen as an umbrella term for a group of approaches with a shared orientation towards collaborative inquiry (Bradbury and Reason 2003).

Researchers using a participatory approach generate findings that are relevant to the practical concerns of the communities in which they work. Findings are oriented towards action and can be used by participants to make changes in relation to the day-to-day challenges they face (Reason and Bradbury 2006). Often researchers using conventional methods expend considerable effort after a research project trying to ensure 'translation' of the knowledge they have produced into a form useful for government, communities and other stakeholders. However, in a participatory research process, the knowledge that is generated may be co-produced by those who can use it to change a given situation, increasing the likelihood it will 'translate' to timely and relevant changes in policy and practice (Vaughan 2014a).

Participatory researchers also aim to build the capacities of research participants by ensuring they are meaningfully involved in research design, development of instruments for collecting information, data collection and analysis (Israel et al. 2010). Participatory researchers value the lived expertise and local knowledge participants bring to the research endeavour and, in so doing, aim to build participants' confidence that they have valuable ideas and skills to contribute to a research project (Wallerstein and Duran 2010).

Various methods and tools are used to enable the participation of people with different levels of education, and different amounts of experience engaging with external parties, including professional researchers. Visual methods are often central to a participatory approach as they support the participation of community members with limited literacy and numeracy or who may not have confidence to articulate their views and perspectives. Visual methods support participants to communicate the 'un-sayable', to express things that are difficult to put into words (Haaken and O'Neill 2014). The artefacts produced by participants using visual research methods—such as participant-generated photographs, drawings, sculpture and videos—can act as a mediator of communication between participants, between participants and the researcher and between the research project and power brokers in communities (Foster-Fishman et al. 2005). Photovoice is one such method that has been used in a wide range of settings.

Photovoice

Photovoice is a participatory visual research method that was developed by Caroline Wang, Mary Anne Burris and colleagues in southern China in the early 1990s (Wang and Burris 1997). They trained rural women to use basic cameras to document their daily lives, including what they perceived to be important influences on their health, well-being and work. The participants were encouraged to visually record their community's strengths, as well as their concerns. The women were then brought together to discuss and debate their photographs, often finding that photographs taken to illustrate individual concerns were linked to struggles shared across the group. Drawing on Paulo Freire's (1974/2005) approach to education for critical consciousness, the researchers supported the women to critically reflect on, and engage in group dialogue about, the social and structural underpinnings of the issues illustrated through their photographs. Wang

and Burris (1997) worked with the village women to hold an exhibition of their photographs and invited politicians, bureaucrats and other decision makers, as well as journalists and national Party organisations. The aim of the exhibition was to communicate to policy makers the women's perspectives through photography, something the women felt unable to do otherwise, in order to inspire changed decisions from those responsible for governing these rural areas. As such, Wang and Burris describe Photovoice as a 'method by which people can identify, represent, and enhance their community' (Wang and Burris 1997: 369).

Over the last 20 years, Photovoice has been used in a wide range of settings to explore, in particular, health issues with diverse population groups (Catalani and Minkler 2010). As a method that does not require complex recording or editing equipment, and with community members increasingly having access to cameras in a range of devices, Photovoice has been used to conduct research in low-, middle- and high-income countries. Across diverse projects, a number of key elements remain relatively consistent, including training participants as co-researchers and photographers; participants taking photographs, selecting illustrative images and drafting textual explanations of their photographs; groups of participants discussing themes that they can see recurring in the images; and public exhibitions aimed at local power brokers.

The *Tok Piksa* Project

After a number of years working on youth-focused health and HIV projects in Papua New Guinea, I began to question whether these interventions, funded by international development assistance, were actually addressing the needs and priorities of the young people they were seeking to engage. There was limited empirical evidence available to inform programmes about what young Papua New Guineans thought were the most important influences on their health, whether they thought change was needed in order to live healthier lives, and if so, what that change might be. In order to explore these questions, I facilitated a Photovoice project with 38 young people living in the Highlands.

The *Tok Piksa* project was established through a process of discussion and negotiation with three pre-existing groups of young people who were all volunteers working to promote health in their communities and in particular prevent HIV. At the beginning of the project, I facilitated a one-week workshop with each of these youth groups to discuss and adapt the

focus of the research project, provide training in basic photography but also to discuss safety (for participants and people that they might photograph), ethics and issues of power associated with photography. Over the following weeks, the young people took photographs to illustrate things that they thought had a positive influence on their health, as well as things they thought undermined the health of young people. I then facilitated a follow up workshop where participants discussed their photographs in small and large groups, and wrote short pieces of text to accompany their images, producing photo-stories combining images and words (Vaughan 2014b). This cycle of workshop, photo-taking and follow up workshop was repeated over a five-month period, culminating in local exhibitions of participants' photo-stories selected by the young people. Some months later, the three youth groups were all brought together for a combined exhibition of their work at an annual cultural show that attracts visitors from all over the country and beyond.

In the initial training workshop that I facilitated with the youth groups, we discussed a range of behaviours or situations that had been identified as 'ethical issues' associated with the use of participatory methods (Minkler 2004) and Photovoice in particular (Wang and Redwood-Jones 2001). These included issues such as confidentiality, anonymity, informed consent, privacy and intrusion, depiction of sensitive or illegal acts, misrepresentation of people or places through photography, ownership of images, safe storage of data and managing expectations.

Ethics in Practice

Having worked in Papua New Guinea prior to the *Tok Piksa* project, I was able to identify a number of other potential ethical issues that might arise beforehand. I knew that if people had their photo taken without the young people getting permission first, or if people felt they were poorly represented in images shown publicly, that there might be demands for 'compensation' (customary payment of goods or money required to settle disputes) from the person depicted in the image. I knew that the participants would not be in a position to pay compensation (and nor was I), and that this could have serious consequences for our safety. I therefore reinforced the importance of getting permission to the young people and urged them to think carefully about how other people were represented in images. I also knew that previously in some communities, individuals in possession of a camera would take photographs of people or events and

then charge money for the images as an informal small business. This may have caused suspicion in the community that the young people were going to ask for money from subjects in their photographs, or led to jealousy if participants were perceived to be making money when others in the community were not.

These types of locally specific ethical issues, along with those traditionally considered in visual research—such as those covered in the initial training—could be addressed pre-emptively in an ethics application, and discussed with participants, prior to data collection. A range of resources is available to support consideration and management of these more predictable ethical issues. However, in a participatory research project, tensions arise in practice between researchers' and participants' values and beliefs about what is the 'ethical' thing to do. These encounters are less easy to predict and prepare for and in many ways are more 'thorny'; here, I reflect upon this, drawing on one particular episode.

In the initial week-long training, we discussed at length the need for seeking permission prior to taking a person's photo, and that if a photo was of a child that it was necessary to also get the permission of that child's parent or guardian. However, at one of the workshops, one of the young men, Mike, chose to discuss a photograph he had taken of a child. It was an image that he wanted to include in our exhibitions. It was the photograph I describe at the start of this chapter.

Mike had taken a photograph of a boy who was living at the local market, sleeping there overnight. He was a boy who was known to use marijuana and alcohol and to be disconnected from immediate and extended family. His situation was known in the local community, and the boy sounded very vulnerable. Mike had taken the photograph to highlight the consequences of child neglect and wrote accompanying text questioning what this meant about the state of the *wantok* system if children like this could be so ignored (the *wantok* system, literally 'one talk', here refers to the responsibilities one has towards those from the same clan or language group).

This boy had given permission for his photograph to be taken and had in fact posed for the camera saying he 'wanted the whole world to see it'. When I asked Mike whether he had received the boy's parents' permission, he replied that their whereabouts were unknown and there was no guardian. I asked whether the boy might have been affected by drugs and alcohol when he posed for the photograph, and was reassured 'not too much' (which I did not find so reassuring). I stated that we could not use

the image in the exhibition. This triggered an unexpectedly heated reaction from the group of participants who strongly disagreed.

> *I was being quite firm about the ethics of showing this particular photo, and very set that we couldn't, when I was interrupted by Lobo. He just looked at me and said "but isn't it unethical not to talk about this?" Ah. He has a point. My pause left a silence that was quickly filled with comments from Florence and Mike—they came back at me, disagreeing with my position on what was and was not ethical. So we have agreed to keep talking about it next time I am up. Thinking about it now I am still quite unsure…* [Field journal, March 2007]
>
> [At the next workshop] *We are still in very different places on this one. Lobo ended up getting a bit angry really "you are trying to shut us down. It is unethical not to include this photo. This* [child neglect] *is something we must have in the exhibition"* [Field journal, April 2007]

In the following workshops, we would keep returning to the discussion of Mike's photograph. I would talk about issues of informed consent and about the potential harms associated with including this particular image in the exhibition. The participants would talk about the fact that everyone in town knew about this boy; that he 'hung out' at the central market, and that community members would essentially step over him on their way in to the market to buy produce. His identity and situation was not going to be revealed by including the photograph—it was already well known. Our discussions led to the participants asking the national NGO staff where they volunteered for their perspectives on what to do with the image; in addition, they asked programme staff what could be done to connect this boy with services (limited as they were in this particular town).

Navigating our different beliefs about what was the ethical thing to do in this situation took time. It was not a clash that could have been easily resolved had we been subject to tight external deadlines and time pressures. At repeated intervals over a period of weeks, we would revisit the issue, with the young people and I outlining the rationale for our position to each other. In seeking the opinions of (local and expatriate) NGO staff, we were also able to draw on their experience in thinking through the possible consequences of showing the image in different contexts, the potential for misunderstandings, and to discuss as a group the role of images in cross-cultural communication.

The ongoing and two-way communication between members of the youth group and myself over this photograph was a clear example of

dialogue, a central tenet of Freire's theory of how critical consciousness and social change occur (Freire 1974/2005). We recognised each other's knowledge as legitimate and made efforts to take the perspective of the other (Jovchelovitch 2007). Our discussions about what would and would not be the ethical thing to do in this instance were challenging but thoughtful, and both parties were changed by the process. As a result, new knowledge was co-created (by me, the youth and members of the NGO staff) about what might be considered ethical in this context. The new knowledge—which in part jarred with the public health-oriented 'expertise' I brought to the discussion—was put into critical action by the young people seeking to link this boy with support and services immediately. We jointly decided to include the photo-story in the local exhibition (where the situation should already have been known to the local audience), but not to include the image in the combined exhibition or any subsequent publications (so as not to reinforce negative stereotypes about the local town, a concern strongly held by the photographer, Mike, and to prevent identifying the boy to strangers).

Ethical Practice, in Whose Eyes?

Participatory researchers have suggested that the approach in and of itself is 'ethical', highlighting the belief that a participatory approach could rectify historical power imbalances between researchers and 'the researched' (Minkler 2004; Buchanan et al. 2007). Researchers using Photovoice have described the method as contributing to a more 'equal' power relationship between academics and participants (Wang et al. 1998). However, much less has been written about how researchers and participants negotiate differences in values and priorities, about how encounters between differing beliefs about the *right thing to do* are resolved. In reflecting on ethical practice in visual research, I am left asking 'ethical, in whose eyes'?

Analysis of my *Tok Piksa* experiences, including the encounter precipitated by Mike's photograph, suggests that the training and worldview I brought to the project prioritised doing the right thing by the individual. However, the participants' worldview, shaped by their upbringing in cultures where the very notion of personhood is produced by family and clan, prioritised doing the right thing by the collective. In the case of Mike's photograph, the collective was both all neglected children and the collective of participants. In this instance, recognition of the legitimacy of the Other's knowledge, a key principle of a participatory

research approach, enabled the co-construction of new knowledge about child neglect and the impact of extremely rapid social change on traditional Papua New Guinean structures of social protection. Adherence to idealised guidelines for ethical practice, based on external value systems, would have foreclosed the dialogue needed for new knowledge to emerge.

In this case, the visual artefact, the photograph, supported communication between me and the young participants, and the youth and NGO staff. The photograph gave credibility to the young people's knowledge, providing evidence that their concerns were real and forcing the audience (me, the NGO staff and later the leaders invited to their exhibition) to *look* and to see. The photograph acted as a tool for the young people's advocacy, enabling them to cut across a range of barriers associated with social power to communicate their message.

At different times during the process, the young people and I reflected on the 'power' of photographs. The participants, as well as members of the community who attended the *Tok Piksa* exhibitions, would frequently describe some of the images as 'moving'. Having been emotionally moved by an image, community leaders, for example, appeared more willing to engage with young people about the issue that the photograph raised. In settings of structured inequality, where power brokers may have little interest in engaging with participants, the communicative depth and affective impact of images make them potentially powerful tools, motivating interlocutors to engage in dialogue. Similarly, in their Photovoice work with low-income African American communities, Carlson, Engebretson et al. (2006) observed that "the opportunity to tell their stories to a listening audience provided an *emotional impetus* for participants to engage at an intrapersonal and interpersonal level" (2006, p.843, my emphasis). It should be noted, however, that it is because visual methods can generate such an emotional impetus that their use may also increase possibilities for misunderstanding and disappointment.

The young participants in this study hoped for, but did not necessarily expect, change to eventuate because of their dialogue and engagement with community leaders during the *Tok Piksa* exhibitions. In the case of one group of participants, their engagement did result in efforts by the local government to address some of the concerns and priorities raised by participants through their photo-stories. For the other two groups, the project outcomes were less apparent, with limited concrete changes in the day-to-day existence of the participants. The young people described their disappointment, but did not regret their participation, noting the

value of individual psycho-social benefits they associated with the project (Vaughan 2014b). However, other researchers have noted that the ethical dilemmas raised by participatory visual methods such as Photovoice can lead to regret, and that this requires serious consideration before such a project commences (Joanou 2009; Prins 2010).

Conclusion

Cross-cultural communication about abstract concepts such as health and well-being is a difficult and complex process. Participatory visual research methods such as Photovoice have the potential to support this process by enabling access to an expanded 'vocabulary' and rich 'language' that includes images and words.

Participatory visual research methods can also give rise to a range of ethical issues that may not be immediately apparent to researchers or participants. However, images, and the affective engagement that they can engender, may open the dialogical space that is required for all concerned to navigate unfamiliar ethical terrain and to be able to see the world through different lenses. Analysis of the *Tok Piksa* project, and the process of deciding what to do with Mike's photograph in particular, suggests that ethical practice in participatory research requires negotiated and dialogical decision making that is grounded in the particular locale of the research. It also suggests that ethical practice is contextually specific, and that the 'right thing to do' locally may be different to what is appropriate in other settings or during wider dissemination of research findings. Participatory research aims to reduce power imbalances between researchers and community members through co-production of knowledge and shared control over research processes. This sharing of control extends to decision making about what constitutes ethical behaviour in research and requires researchers to recognise the legitimacy of participants' values and ethical principles even when these do not align with their own.

Note

1. At the beginning of the project, I gave the young participants the opportunity to adopt nicknames and be made anonymous in all publications arising from this study. The young people provided nicknames to me at this time. However, by the completion of the project, the participants asked me not to use them—they felt strongly

that they would like their stories and photographs to be acknowledged as their own, an issue that has been faced by other researchers using visual methods (see, e.g., Guillemin and Drew 2010). They were proud of the work that they did in the Tok Piksa project (and undoubtedly I am proud of, and grateful to, them) and want to be 'in' what was written about them. Therefore, I have used participants' real first names here.

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CHAPTER 3

Fuzzy Boundaries When Using "Mental Mapping" Methods to Trace the Experiences of Immigrant Women in South Korea

Hyunjoo Jung

Introduction

This chapter explores methodological and ethical issues that arise when there are 'fuzzy boundaries' between researchers and research participants (Cox et al. 2014). The concept of fuzzy boundaries refers to the blurring of research aims and roles. Fuzzy boundaries are arguably more likely to be evident in research using visual methods because researchers and participants can have multiple and overlapping roles and the research serves multiple purposes, such as generating knowledge, producing creative outcomes, and engaging public audiences in social issues. The blurring of roles of researcher and research participants can have empowering effects by facilitating diverse participation in processes of knowledge production. This potential, however, generates new kinds of ethical dilemmas. Fuzzy boundaries in research roles complicate issues of authorship and ownership in regards to research products and are difficult to accommodate in the formal structures of academic institutions. In academic

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contexts, authorship is valued and an important way of acknowledging a person's role in knowledge production; however, it may not be empowering or ethical in some contexts.

In this chapter, I consider the ethical issues arising in processes of knowledge co-production and authorship in visual research. I illustrate these issues by drawing on a research project that used a 'mental mapping' method to explore the experiences of immigrant women who had moved to live in rural villages in South Korea from other parts of Asia after entering into commercially arranged marriages. The women are widely referred to as 'foreign brides' and likely to be subjected to stigmatization and racism. Fieldwork for the research was conducted in two rural areas between 2006 and 2010 (see Jung 2007, 2012, 2014). Research data were generated through participant observation, interviews, and participants' drawings of mental maps that visualized psycho-geographical impressions of neighborhoods. Data were collected while the women were participating in Korean language classes. The mental maps were originally intended as a visual complement to the interviews since I encountered many difficulties in communicating with the women in Korean. Over the course of conducting the fieldwork, the women's roles in the research expanded. This was because they identified new possibilities in the mental maps to express their responses to experiences of migration and resettlement in ways that I had not anticipated. This led to increased focus on using the mental maps for data collection.

This methodological revision reflected the potential for research participants to enact agency in research processes and blurred the roles of the researcher and participants. I discuss these methodological shifts, their significance for the data that were generated, the potential for participant empowerment through research, and ethical issues that were raised. Before doing so, I briefly discuss the potential of mental mapping as a critical visual methodology.

Mental Mapping as a Critical Visual Method

As my research proceeded, I aimed to reconstruct mental mapping as a critical visual method responsive to feminist critiques of research methodology that argue the research itself is power laden, and commit to empowering participants through alternative methodologies. With this purpose, I explored methodological approaches that offered possibilities for gaining insight into the inner worlds of these immigrant women living in South

Korea who, due to their marginalized situations, have limited opportunities for self-representation. With language barriers and occasional cultural misunderstandings, the immigrant women were likely to struggle to fully express their feelings and intentions in interviews. These issues would heighten the women's dependence on the researcher to convey their experiences, and risks distorting the meanings they intended to convey. Amidst potential for miscommunication and misrepresentation, it was important to facilitate increased opportunities for the women to speak for themselves. Mental maps presented promising possibility. They offered a way of generating non-verbal information that would complement the interview data. In order to ensure empowering potential, however, I needed to move beyond conventional approaches to mental mapping methods and adapt them to better realize the aims of feminist research.

Mental maps, also known as 'cognitive' maps, have been long and widely used to visualize individuals' geographical perceptions of particular places. Since American urban planner Kevin Lynch (1960) first introduced the idea to retrieve people's images of particular cities, it has been adapted by geographers interested in exploring psychological experiences of place and space (Ley 1972), associations between perceptions of place and spatialized behavior (see essays in Downs and Stea 1973), processes of spatial knowledge acquisition (Kitchin and Freundschuh 2000), and building a general model of spatial preference (Gould and White 1974). More recently, researchers have found mental maps useful in reducing dependence on verbal communication in research and have adapted the method to conduct research involving children, people with disabilities, and other social groups who may experience difficulties in expressing themselves using words (e.g. Fuller and Chapman 1974; Ungar 2000; Uttal and Tan 2000). In these different ways, and with the guidance of researchers who are orientated to address particular research questions, mental maps are used to visualize people's geographical imaginations.

In a previous work (Jung 2014), I pointed to some epistemological, analytical, and ethical problems associated with conventional approaches to mental mapping and attempted to devise strategies that primarily focused on resolving epistemological and analytical issues. Some critical ethical issues, however, remain unresolved. This chapter attempts to shed light on these ethical aspects that warrant discussion in the context of critical visual methodologies.

The conventional approaches to mental mapping generally fail to interrogate the significance of unequal power between the researcher and

research participants. Researchers tend to be positioned as experts, while research participants are positioned as 'information givers' or research objects. As experts, researchers have authority to produce 'proper' knowledge by interpreting the significance of imaginative expression represented in the mental maps. This unequal power relation raises two related ethical concerns. First, mental mapping can be exploitative when it is conducted in a way that 'takes' from research participants without contributing to their empowerment. This concern leads to the discussion of positionality in research relations, once a hot topic among feminist scholars. In the following section, I will address how this issue was deployed in my case study. Second, conventional approaches to mental mapping tend to treat the maps only as data for academic analysis rather than also being the property of participants. Within processes of research, there is limited scope for the map producers to engage in interpretation, display, and dissemination. These circumstances raise the issue of authorship and ownership of the maps created by research participants. The lack of authorship and ownership, or the limited engagement of the map producers in processes of interpretation, display, and dissemination, also increases concerns toward the disempowerment of participants.

These ethical concerns lead to questions of how research can be an empowering experience for participants, particularly those experiencing marginalization. The case study I discuss, however, shows that authorship and ownership do not always directly facilitate empowerment. They need to be promoted with complex and comprehensive consideration of other elements required in ethical visual methodologies. The proposed study addresses a case where authorship can conflict with the commitment to anonymity. In academic settings, authorship is highly prized and, accordingly, I was keen to acknowledge the ways in which the participants co-authored artifacts and findings generated through the research. During the fieldwork, research participants actively used the processes of mental mapping to communicate experiences in excess of the ways in which the original research questions were framed. In doing this, they shifted the research process toward being a process of co-production as the participants became co-authors of their experiences. Participants, however, felt that being anonymous was a potentially more empowering position. I tease out these tensions to consider the different ways in which empowerment may be conceived and recognized by researchers and participants, and how these differences can be reconciled to promote ethical research.

Empowerment Through Knowledge Co-production

Feminist scholars, among others, have eagerly promoted commitment to empowering participants through reflexive and critical methodologies (Miraftab 2004; Nazneen et al. 2014; Tsikata and Darkwah 2014; Rose 1997; Valentine 2003). Scholars argue that researchers' social positions *vis-à-vis* those of research participants' affects research outcomes and, therefore, critical reflection on power relations is a necessary starting point in methodological considerations (Hyams 2004; Nagar 2002; Nencel 2014; Stapele 2014). A key concept used to explore these issues is that of positionality, which grapples with the ways in which knowledge generated through research inevitably reflects the unequal social positions of researchers and research participants (Haraway 1988; McKay 2002; Rose 1997). Feminist geographer Gill Valentine (2003) argues that simply being aware of existing power relations and issues of positionality is insufficient to counter their effects, and thus meaningful steps should be implemented to empower research participants. The participatory and collaborative potential of visual research methods have influenced its appeal to researchers seeking to enhance the involvement of research participants in processes of knowledge production. For example, a number of researchers have reflected on the potential of methods such as 'photovoice' to empower research participants by offering scope to explore research topics using images and words in ways that are personally meaningful (McIntyre 2003; Wang 1999).

In my own research, my initial decision to incorporate mental mapping techniques into a mixed methods study was not to empower immigrant women whose experiences I was planning to research. Rather, it was intended to complement the interview data. In early interviews, I asked the participants to draw maps of their neighborhoods as everyday spaces with aims of exploring their mobility across geographic spaces in the villages where they lived. Reflecting on the maps that were being produced by the women, however, it became evident that they were using the mapping exercise as a means to express feelings, desires, identity, and nostalgia in both conscious and unconscious ways. Realizing that the maps contained much more information that I had envisaged, coupled with the difficulties I was experiencing through the language barriers we had, I elected to redesign the research to make mental mapping a central component of data collection (see Jung 2014 for a critical reflection on this decision and the process of redesigning the research). A second round of

fieldwork, therefore, included interactive discussions with the participants about the maps they produced. These discussions were conducted with friendship groups so that the women could talk with each other in their mother tongues and share their interpretations of each other's works. This shift from one on one interviews to group discussions put the women in a more empowered positions *vis-à-vis* the researcher. A key aim of the group discussion session was to foster self-reflection (why did I draw such a map in the first place? What did it mean?), and to reinterpret one's own map by incorporating the views of others, including those of the researcher. In these conversations, I tried to allow the participants to speak for themselves, although sometimes it was necessary for me to interject to suggest words so that they could develop their own thinking on the meaning of their maps. This interpretive phase blended the participants' understanding with concepts from the researcher.

For an example of this process, I draw on the experience of Lana (a pseudonym), who was from Uzbekistan. She produced four maps (two each drawn in 2007 and 2010 and reproduced in Fig. 3.1). Figure 3.1a is her representation of her current neighborhood in Korea, and (b) is her hometown in Uzbekistan. (c, d) were produced in the second round interviews in 2010. During the that time, I showed Lana her previous maps and we talked about what the differences in the maps might mean in relation to her evolving identity as an immigrant woman. In her first map of her Korean village (a), she placed only the name of her rural village in the upper right corner without a detailed description. This was an unusual arrangement of content, since most participants had placed their current neighborhoods at the center of their maps (Jung 2007). In contrast, the central feature of Lana's map was an intersection depicting roads to nearby cities. Discussing this with her, I suggested that this reflected a desire to transcend the boundary of her rural locality and identify with urban alternatives. By doing so, she could assert a translocal identity and disassociate herself from her rural neighbors, and the racism and sexism that she experienced from them (Jung 2014). This was her strategy for defying the imposed identity of being a 'foreign bride' (Jung 2007).

My interpretation concretized Lana's subconscious expression of her identity and desires, and provided her with a language to utilize in her storytelling. In Fig. 3.1c, drawn three years after her first map of her Korean village, Lana depicts it in a different style that emphasizes local elements at a smaller geographical scope. According to my initial assumptions of the function of mental maps, this reduced range would indicate

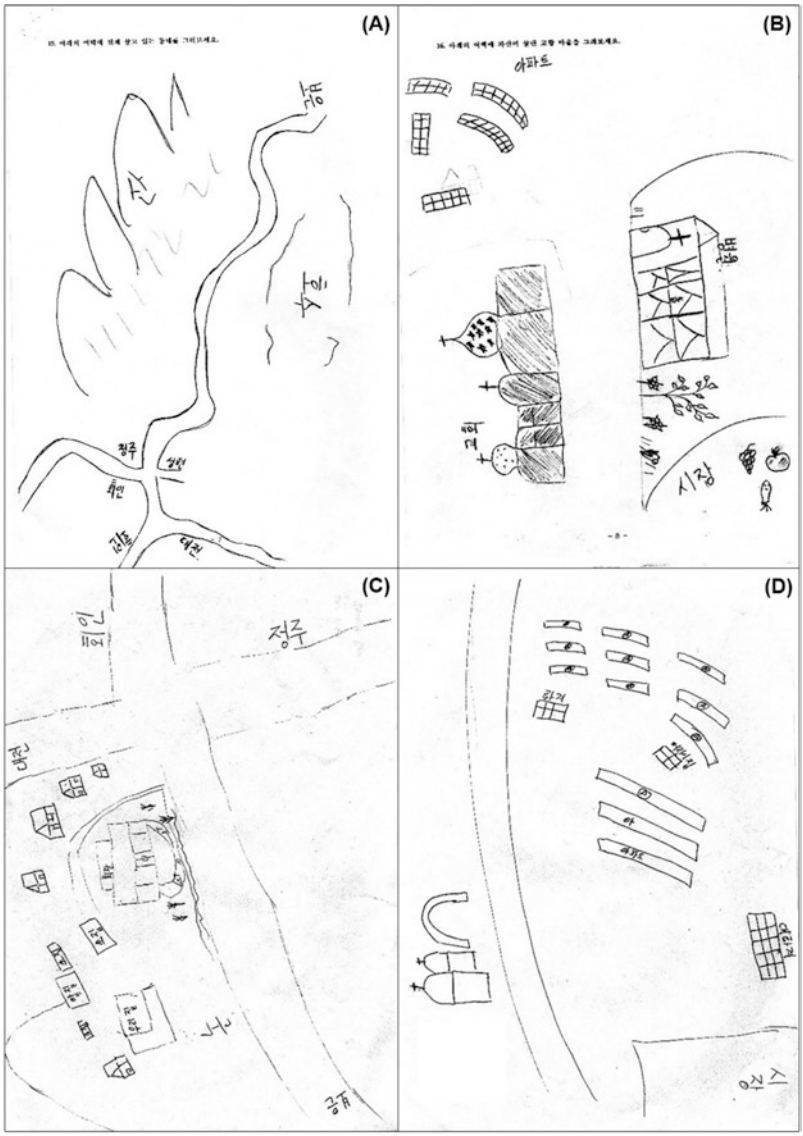


Fig. 3.1 Lana's mental maps of her neighborhoods. (**a**) Current neighborhood in South Korea (2007)*. (**b**) Previous neighborhood in Uzbekistan (2007). (**c**) Redrawn map of current neighborhood in South Korea (2010). (**d**) Redrawn map of previous neighborhood in Uzbekistan (2010) (*Map (**a**) was published in *Journal of the Korean Urban Geographical Society* (2007), Vol. 10(2), p. 62. It is reproduced here under permission of the publisher)

her decreased mobility (Jung 2007). This, however, would have misinterpreted what Lana tried to communicate through her maps. Lana explained that, rather than representing limited mobility within the local area, the detailed description of her neighborhood represented her growing sense of belonging and affection toward the neighborhood. Her depiction of detailed elements such as rice fields, neighbors' houses, barns, and the community center depicted her shifting relationships within the neighborhood. She reflected on the changes in her life during the last three years; how she had become a mother and, gradually, a member of the local community. She even compared Fig. 3.1a, b (her Korean neighborhood) with (b, d) (her hometown in Uzbekistan), concluding that she considered both sites as 'home' now. This is evident in increased stylistic similarity in the ways the Uzbekistan and Korean neighborhoods are rendered in the latter maps. Confirming her growing sense of community in her second home of Korea, she noted that the community center in her Korean neighborhood had an equivalent meaning to the church in her hometown.

This example illustrates the ways in which, through map drawing and co-interpretation, the research process facilitated participants' self-reflection and insight into the changes they were experiencing. As a researcher, I contributed to processes of story building by providing vocabularies and key concepts, and by offering my own interpretations of the participants' maps. Through these processes, knowledge was co-produced illuminating the ways in which power relations and identity politics were represented through the geographical imagination.

This example from my research illustrates two important aspects of the mental mapping method with regard to debates over ethical issues in visual methodologies. First, it can promote the empowerment of research participants, even though I did not fully anticipate this potential. There was scope for the women to adapt the maps and use them to explore issues arising out of their experiences as immigrants. Secondly, as a consequence of their initiative, the processes of interpreting the data no longer rested solely with the 'expert' researcher—it became a mutual and iterative process that generated new insights into their experiences for both the researcher and the participants.

Authorship Versus Anonymity

Enhanced potential for participants to contribute to conceptualizing research issues and generating research products, and particularly visual artifacts serves to raise questions about what constitutes authorship of

research, and whether participants should be acknowledged as co-authors (Cox et al. 2014). Although there is merit in considering authorship as an ethical issue, the implications can be complex.

Authorship involves questions of what products can be said to be 'authored' and then how to acknowledge authorship across community and academic contexts. Regarding questions of products, some research outcomes such as paintings and sculptures are easily classified as visual products originated through the efforts of individuals. The products of photovoice methods (McIntyre 2003; Wang 1999) are another example of easily identifiable outcomes as personal properties; in this case, photographs are created, and therefore authored, by research participants. These kinds of research products have significant meaning as private and public documents and, depending on their qualities, could even be considered as artwork.

Issues of quality and the effort involved in production can involve fuzzy boundaries. For example, can 'scribbles' be considered to be authored? Visual products such as mental maps can be classified in between personal artwork/documentaries and scribbles, depending on their quality, interpretation or applications. If they are aggregated and coded in the manner of statistical data, does this nullify rights to claim authorship for individual pieces of work? In the case of mental maps, they are usually improvised and produced quite quickly by participants during research encounters using sheets of paper and pencils. In many contexts, such as geography lessons, they are routinely produced as a classroom activity. The maps are ephemeral and students are unlikely to want to claim authorship. If maps are published as illustrations of research data in journals and books, however, they are both personal scribbles and public artifacts. It is the shift into the public domain that necessitates consideration of issues of authorship or other strategies that acknowledge the contributions of the producers of research artifacts.

There are other factors to consider, too. In academic contexts, authorship is endowed with copyright. If participants have copyright over artifacts, what kinds of procedures and protocols need to be followed? Contemporary academic practices and conventions give copyright to the writer and publisher. Currently, researchers who publish visual data jointly produced by participants are only required to acknowledge these contributions in captions accompanying representations or in an 'Acknowledgements' section. If participants have authorship rights, they may be able to withdraw permission for reproducing representations of visual work. Facilitating authorship for participants where appropriate

would do much to equalize relationships between researchers and research participants, and between research participants and academic institutions. Current guidelines recommend, rather than compel, researchers to consider these issues. Authorship can be difficult to establish and uphold when research participants are unfamiliar with academic vocabulary and contexts, and under conventional guidelines participants must rely on researchers to represent their interests. Without considerable changes in current academic systems, especially in the area of publication conventions, claims to authorship by research participants are a long way from being realized.

The ethics of authorship lead to another set of dilemmas that involve a fundamental ethical principle to preserve participants' anonymity. When informants live in oppressive circumstances, they want the security of anonymity rather than claiming authorship or ownership in ways that increase risks of being identified as participants in research. In the case of my fieldwork, immigrant women feared being identified by their husbands, in-laws, and neighbors. While appreciative of the opportunity through their involvement in research for mainstream society to hear about their responses to being identified in sexist and racist ways as 'foreign brides', most women vehemently rejected offers of authorship and insisted that they be guaranteed anonymity, even to the extent that their maps only be published in English. A few women, including Lana, did not mind if their family and acquaintances recognized their maps. For the majority of women participating in the research, concerns for their safety meant that keeping anonymity was of foremost importance. For those women who were less concerned with their anonymity, it was still important to use a pseudonym. In these circumstances, finding feasible ways to acknowledge authorship remained unclear.

Although most participants wanted to warrant anonymity in order to create a safe space to share their experiences, they were also keen for their maps to have wider audiences (academic and the general public). Publication of maps would help the wider society better understand their experiences and reduce the stigma that women who immigrated through commercially arranged marriage are subjected to. This was a strong motivation for the women who participated in the project, and they gave permission for me to use their mental maps as research data.

The tension between anonymity and identification also has been addressed in other research. Many researchers emphasize the potential risks of being identified particularly in visual research that deals with vul-

nerable groups and participants' rights for safety must outweigh researchers' desires for publishing their voices widely (Ponic and Jategaokar 2011; Phelan and Kinsella 2013; Robson 2011; Wiles et al. 2010). In a different vein, others question the universal endorsement of anonymity in qualitative research, arguing that anonymity can conflict with demands for effective dissemination to wider society (Tilley and Woodthorpe 2011). In the case of my research, the arguments of both sides can be applied: there is a foremost responsibility to protect participants on the one hand, and a commitment to empower them by delivering their voices to wider audiences, on the other. Acknowledging participants as authors would contribute to this latter goal, yet present possibilities of risking the former.

My suggestion in steering through these dilemmas is not to discard the idea of authorship, but rather, to be flexible with the ways in which authorship is acknowledged and to make it sensitive to the situations of participants, particularly those in vulnerable positions. For instance, while remaining anonymous, participants could be involved in decisions about how visual artifacts generated through research are presented, displayed, and disseminated. It could also be important to consider how pseudonyms can be more effectively used to acknowledge and empower participants as co-producers of knowledge and perhaps even to attribute copyright, where feasible. Opportunities for participants to choose pseudonyms or research avatars offer another strategy for upholding rights to authorship and protecting anonymity.

Conclusion

In this chapter, I have explored two related sets of ethical issues that are associated with fuzzy boundaries in research processes. One set of issues revolved around a commitment to empowering of research participants. This enabled the participants to influence key aspects of the research, including the decision to feature the mental mapping method more prominently in a research when it became evident that the women found them to be helpful in expressing a range of experiences. They introduced themes beyond those I had initially identified as relevant for understanding their experiences as immigrant women in South Korea. Knowledge was co-produced as the visual data from the women's maps were then interpreted through dialogue between the participants (individually and collectively) and drawing on conceptual and theoretical perspectives that I contributed as a researcher and social geographer. This approach facilitated increased

agency for research participants and produced findings that more accurately represent the women's circumstances and the changes they experienced over time.

A second set of issues explored tensions between the obligations of acknowledging authorship and providing the safety of anonymity. While anonymity has long been a key ethical principle upheld in academic research, notions that participants should be acknowledged as co-authors of research products is a relatively new idea and is difficult to accommodate in current academic institutional arrangements. Nevertheless, the issue is particularly relevant for researchers using visual methods that generate artifacts that are personally meaningful or have aesthetic significance. Mental maps are a form of visual data that are positioned in a fuzzy area between being scribbles and personal records that warrant public attention. My experience in this project suggests that co-authorship would present many risks to the participants who largely remain in oppressive and power-laden relations and with limited geographical mobility. Many of their social interactions are mediated by their Korean husbands, in-laws, and NGO staff. Public acknowledgments of authorship that likely brought public attention could endanger participants. Consequently, I argue for sensitive and flexible approaches to authorship.

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CHAPTER 4

Methodological and Ethical Concerns Associated with Digital Ethnography in Domestic Environments: Participant Burden and Burdensome Technologies

Bjorn Nansen, Rowan Wilken, Jenny Kennedy, Michael Arnold, and Martin Gibbs

Introduction

This chapter reflects on some anticipated and unanticipated methodological and ethical issues that emerged during the initial waves of data collection for a project deploying mobile digital ethnographic tools and software applications within domestic environments. These issues and concerns arose in the context of a participatory approach that sought to encourage and empower participants to actively produce and interpret visual data that were used to explore the ways in which households adapted digital technologies in domestic environments. The production of participant-generated data was facilitated through the provision of tablets loaded with ethnographic software and prompts for visual tasks for

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capturing, storing and communicating data about their household's use of broadband Internet. After describing the digital ethnographic methods employed, we go on to identify and discuss the ethical concerns emerging from this process, and how these issues have been addressed.

Background

This research builds upon an established tradition in media studies of studying the 'domestication' of technologies (e.g. Haddon 2011; Silverstone and Hirsch 1992; Spigel 2001). Historically, this area of research has examined processes of acquisition and accommodation, in which technologies are physically and symbolically located in the home. Anthropological research notes that domestication remains an ongoing process that also involves processes of dwelling and divestment (McCracken 1988; Miller 2012). Further, while domestication research has predominantly focused on particular technologies, such as the television (Spigel 1992), or the computer (Lally 2002), more recent research highlights the importance of studying domestic communications ecologies that increasingly involve dense interrelations of multiple technologies configuring home media environments (Nansen et al. 2009; Nansen et al. 2011; Shepherd et al. 2007; Wilken et al. 2014).

This is because over the past decade or so, Australian households have undergone drastic transformations in the number, variety and amount of time spent with digital media and communications technologies (ACMA 2015; Wilken et al. 2014). This study is situated within this changing household media ecology and examines high-speed broadband adoption and domestication. How this ongoing process of media domestication transforms the aggregated ecology of household media and unfolds through household members interacting with particular technologies is, however, difficult to access and capture using traditional research methods. This complex sociotechnical environment calls out for sustained and close observation, yet homes are familial, intimate and physically bounded spaces, which prove difficult for researchers to explore using in-depth qualitative ethnographic methods.

Methodology, Method and Rationale

Unable to observe participants in their homes for extended periods of time, researchers have opted instead to use structured interviews, surveys and focus group methods to gain insights into household technology use

(e.g. OfCom 2013). Such tools are useful for gaining general insights, but less so for developing in-depth understanding of household practices. Methods that have been used to penetrate private spheres such as the home, and that might be regarded as the antecedents of the participative methods described here, have included requests for householders to descriptively diarise their daily life over time (e.g. Bolger et al. 2003), to mark off activities on a daily time-grid or calendar (e.g. Bickman and Rog 2009), or to reconstruct their day (e.g. Kahneman et al. 2004). Each of these methods invites research 'informants' to become research 'participants' who in effect observe themselves and reflect upon the significance of these observations.

In recent times, more experimental, visual and novel applications of these forms of informant-participant data collection have been developed, the most prominent being a range of analogue media that function as 'cultural probes' to enable participants to collect, share and negotiate data in the absence of researchers (Gaver et al. 1999). These probes involve participants taking photographs, drawing maps, keeping diaries, collecting and storing relevant materials and so on and have previously been used as a participatory methodology in domestic settings (e.g. Arnold 2004; Shepherd et al. 2007). Rather than relying on the presence and intervention of the researcher, analogue cultural probes and domestic probes are designed to encourage and empower participants to collect and interpret data themselves (Horst et al. 2004; Mackay and Ivey 2004).

In our study, we extended this participatory approach through the use of digital media by deploying iPad minis pre-loaded with a data collection software tool, *EthnoCorder* (http://ethnocorder.com). Using these technologies, our participants were asked to collect situated visual representations of domestic technology use. In particular, we asked participants to periodically generate visual data framed around a number of playful televisual tasks. The tasks were designed to capture the household's technology use using familiar genres of a 'nature documentary', 'news report', 'paparazzi shot', 'diary room entry' and 'chat show interview'. *EthnoCorder* software loaded onto iPads was used to record images, video, sound and text, and to store and share the recordings with the researchers.

Methodologically, this approach was designed to include participants as collaborators in our research work. They were able to make decisions about what they thought was significant to record and share, represent their experiences and reflections using whatever medium (text, image, video) they thought appropriate, contribute to analysis of their data in

subsequent interview discussions and suggest modifications to the research design. Briefly stated, our ambitions for this method were to: (1) create a means by which households might represent the technology-related practices that occur in these intimate environments; (2) do so in a way that was open-ended, interpretive and overtly called upon the household participants to be reflective and active; (3) create rich televisual resources that the households might use to reflect on their technology-related practices when in conversation with us; and (4) involve participants in tasks that would be playful, fun and relatively quick to complete and represented familiar televisual tropes. It was anticipated that this approach would heighten participants' interest and engagement in the study and diminish the burdens of involvement for participants.

This participatory method was situated within a longitudinal study also involving annual 'technology' tours and discussions with members of participating households over a period of three years. During these visits, the completed tasks, previously uploaded via the app, served as the basis for detailed discussion on participants' experiences and relationships with technologies in their homes. This paper draws on data collected during 2013–2014, the first 12 months of the study examining how high-speed broadband changes or affects the way households interact with media devices and digital technologies in the home. The sample consists of 22 households connected to the Australia Government's National Broadband Network (NBN) and represented domestic media ecologies of varying complexities, ranging from the simple (few devices with basic network setups) to the highly complex 'bleeding-edge' (pushing the limits of the capabilities of technologies within their household). Households were recruited through a data sharing agreement with NBN Co who provided details of households interested in participating in research. Findings from the study analysing household media activities are available elsewhere (e.g. Arnold et al. 2014; Kennedy et al. 2015; Nansen et al. 2009, 2011; Wilken et al. 2014).

Ethics of Selecting Appropriate Ethnographic Software and Designing Participant Tasks

There were two stages to the development of the digital ethnographic methods used in this study: identification of a suitable device and application and the development of participant data collection tasks. *EthnoCorder* was selected because it offered greatest flexibility in structuring the digital

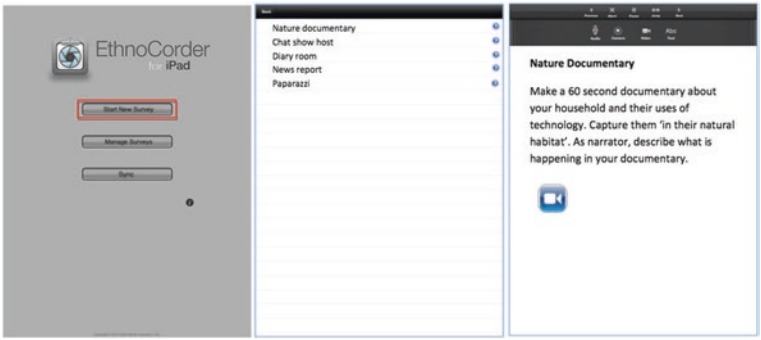


Fig. 4.1 Screengrabs of EthnoCorder interface for iPhone/iPod Touch

tasks (see Fig. 4.1). Like other tools, *EthnoCorder* users capture text, image, video and sound in response to tasks set by the research team and synch their entries to a web-based browser. A desktop application allows researchers to design and manage their own tasks for deployment on iOS devices. The desktop application allows for the specification of page layout, instructional text and multimedia formats of responses—for example, text, audio, image and video. Users also have the option of adding further multimedia content to any response. Researchers are able to manage participants and data collection through an online platform, accessible only to the research team.

The features of *EthnoCorder* which informed our selection of the tool included the following features: relatively simple to navigate in order to complete tasks (see Fig. 3.1); multiple users could have separate accounts on the same device enabling household members to generate and upload content independently; data are exportable as .csv spreadsheet files facilitating straightforward data management; and potential to create multiple tasks within the same application. Limitations of the *EthnoCorder* software include: at the time of writing, it is only available on the Apple mobile operating system (iOS); it requires user action to synch data, which creates a potential barrier for researchers in accessing data if users forget this stage of the process; tasks cannot be altered remotely, which means that modifications to the research design mid-wave are problematic; and there are unlikely but potential compromises of data security as data are not encrypted when uploaded for researchers to access and *EthnoCorder*'s cloud storage is hosted on a third-party server.

Decisions about ethnographic hardware and software are largely practical, yet they do present ethical considerations. For example, the chosen system required participants to deliberately synchronise data, rather than the system synching by default. In instrumental terms, this is potentially a significant shortcoming because householders could overlook the need to synch or may not remember how to synch. At the same time, and perhaps more interesting from methodological and ethical perspectives, this affordance provides opportunities for householders to reconsider their responses and self-edit or self-censor in ways that may compromise the value of the content as research data. The need for deliberate synching, however, means that participants must actively choose to share their data with the research team and this has ethical advantages of giving participants additional layers of control and opportunities to reconsider issues of privacy and self-presentation. The paradox is evident. Our aims in empowering participants to represent and share their experiences were to enhance their agency and control in the research process, as well as improving the quality of the data produced. Empowering participants, however, does not necessarily achieve each of these objectives. A decision about the simple affordance of manual or automated synching casts into sharp relief ethical questions raised in the negotiation of researcher-participant power differentials, where the interests of the research (in quality data) and the interests of the researched (in their own agency) may diverge.

The tasks were devised and refined through piloting and iteration over a number of research design meetings. We asked that tasks be conducted on four designated days per year at roughly three-month intervals and participating households were informed via text or email when these dates were approaching. For a 'paparazzi shot', participants were asked to take a surprise photo of a member of their household while using technology and then, having shown the photo to the featured household member, decide on a caption together. For the 'chat show host', we asked participants to interview a household member on their technology use, inquiring about their habits, routines and rituals. A 'diary room entry' required participants to speak direct to the camera explaining what they think other householders' favourite pieces of technology are and why. For a 'news report', participants were asked to create a short report about a piece of technology in their household (e.g. most loved, most frustrating, oldest, newest). For a 'nature documentary', participants were asked to make a short documentary about their household's use of technology and to capture household members 'in their natural habitat'. As with the ethnographic software, the participant data

collection had ethical implications. Some tasks, either explicitly or implicitly, involved activities that meant one household member might capture footage of another householder at times when they were not aware or willing to be recorded for research purposes. Potential breaches of participants' privacy were partly addressed by building into the data collection activities the need for participants to consult with other household members about the footage captured, for example, deciding on a caption to go with an image. This gave relevant household members opportunities to review recordings and potentially veto footage being uploaded for researchers to access and use as research data.

Findings and Reflections on Ethics of Using Digital Ethnography Tools

On the first household visit, we set aside some time with the household to set up their new iPad mini, register the app to the user and go through the televisual tasks. Only a few of the participants indicated unfamiliarity with the features of the iPad mini device, though many were not sure of how to set up the device and install gifted applications. Participants were generally enthusiastic about completing the research tasks and some expressed initial thoughts about what they might capture when it came time to complete them at set intervals over the longitudinal study. Over the course of 2013–2014, the first cohort of participants were asked to choose and complete four of the six preinstalled tasks and then upload their recordings using the *EthnoCorder* application. Around half of the participating households completed the four tasks in the initial wave of data collection. Although households could choose any of the tasks, the 'paparazzi shot' and 'news story' tasks proved to be the most popular. Only a few participants opted to complete a 'nature documentary', 'diary room entry', or 'chat show host' tasks in these initial stages of data collection.

Prior to the second wave of interviews with household members, we speculated that these preferences might have been due to some scenarios being perceived as being more time consuming than others, requiring additional creative input from participants, more challenging to complete to participants' satisfaction, or a combination of these factors. In discussions with participants in the second household visits, interviews and technology tours, we asked about perceptions of the iPad device, the usability of the *EthnoCorder* programme and the tasks, in an effort to identify potential obstacles to completing the tasks, or not selecting particular

kinds of tasks. These discussions revealed a range of reasons for participants not completing tasks and their responses; these are divided into categories of household priorities or technical issues and are described below. This discussion is followed by some reflections on the methodological and ethical implications of the perceived obstacles that were associated with the tasks.

Household Priorities

In making our requests, we were asking for the expenditure of what for many are scarce resources—time and energy. As might be expected, many participants spoke about the research tasks conflicting with household circumstances, such as lifestyle and work commitments, busy family routines and demanding work schedules and holidays. In particular, such everyday constraints and pressures meant that requests to complete tasks were easily overlooked and forgotten, or were always on the "to-do" list but pushed back to a point where they never came to the top of the list. On occasion, they were perceived as relatively unrewarding chores or work-tasks that could be dispensed with to make time to attend to other demands.

In addition to these readily anticipated obstacles, we also found issues to do with the personal, self-imposed demands of completing a creative task. In one sense, the open-ended tasks, such as those we set for participants to complete, presented no particular hurdles. We were keen to affirm that there were no entry barriers, that nothing was too short, that there were no right or wrong responses and that all representations of experience and attitude were of value so far as we are concerned. However, these assurances did not necessarily dispel the self-imposed expectations of some participants to be creative, reflective and expressive, nor did they ensure that participants felt comfortable about how they would be perceived while being audio-recorded or videoed, and trying to anticipate and meet the imagined expectations of researchers.

We anticipated the time-scarcity experienced by many households, but underestimated the 'tyranny of the blank page' experienced by many authors, including some of our participants. Our attempts to alleviate potential burdens of involvement in the research, by designing research activities that were oriented towards familiar media forms and which were intended to be quick and amusing to produce, proved to be only partially

successful. This raises some questions about the assumptions of participatory approaches in qualitative and ethnographic research, which may be seen as more inclusive and empowering than more structured methods, but which can place increased demands on the ways in which participants are obliged to 'participate' in research. In some circumstances, opportunities for creative contributions may not necessarily be welcomed or valued in relation to standard research methods, such as interviews and surveys. Clearly, there is a balance to be struck with methodological familiarity and convenience—one that we have found is often resolved in early and clear discussions with participants about the objectives and approach of the research.

Technical Obstacles

In addition to the range of personal issues moderating participants' capacity to undertake the televisual tasks, we also found that our participating households encountered a range of technical 'reverse salients' (Hughes 1983). In the language of science and technology studies, this refers to weak links in the chains of networked hardware and software that significantly compromise the capacity of the technology as a whole to function as intended. Primarily, these reverse salients centred on complications experienced with the ethnographic software application rather than the iPad hardware. In particular, during the time period since the initial visit, explanation and hand-over of the tablet and software, a number of updates were made to the app, initiated by Apple's changes to its operating system. This left us relying on participants themselves to update the app. In many devices, a failure to update caused errors in the app and led it to crash. In second-wave interviews, these technical difficulties were reported by participants as frustrating and disappointing. More common, however, were frustrations arising from some participants' limited digital media competency or confidence in using the tablet, operating system or app. This meant that, for some participants, the research-related technologies proved difficult to use and were not easily integrated into their established domestic media ecology and routines.

The personal and technical difficulties encountered by research participants are of methodological concern in so far as they undermine the quality and quantity of data produced. Of further concern were the ethical implications that are associated with the difficulties that were experienced.

Ethical Implications of Household Priorities

Participant burden in terms of demands on time in an age where many individuals perceive themselves to be time poor is itself an ethical concern. In effect we were asking individuals to make a personal sacrifice for the collective good, and the ethics of that trade-off needs careful consideration. This is partly addressed in the mandated processes of acquiring ethical approval to conduct research where, among many other things, university, and other institutional, ethics approval processes require researchers to argue to the satisfaction of the committee that the research outcomes generated through the proposed research outweigh the burden of involvement in research for participants.

A number of arguments might be made to support the judgement that in our case the participant burden is outweighed by the benefits of the research. The outputs have been published in peer-reviewed journals and have been assessed as significant. The participants gave informed consent to volunteer in the study and benefited in receiving iPads as a gift. Some participants acquired improved digital media skills, and some households and participants benefited from the opportunity to reflect on their technology use. Some participants responded to suggestions to complete the tasks communally, and experienced these activities as enjoyable. In these circumstances, the time expenditure contributed to the study could be regarded as contributing to the convivial sociality of the household. However, those who are not researchers may well come to a different conclusion when balancing the value of research outputs against the sacrifices of time and effort made to obtain research inputs.

Similarly, the frustration some participants experienced in meeting the challenge implicit in the creative nature of the task raised both methodological and ethical concerns. The tasks were intended to be open-ended rather than prescriptive, and inclusive rather than exclusionary. Some participants, however, interpreted the tasks as requiring a degree of creative professionalism and polish that they did not feel they possessed, or a degree of reflective thoughtfulness and profundity that they could not deliver. In short, they felt that they were not up to the creative and communicative challenges, and this raises ethical concerns that some participants might be left feeling inadequate or even as having ‘failed’.

Ethical Implications of Technical Obstacles

As noted, the technical obstacles we observed may have had the unintended consequence of excluding those without the requisite expertise to participate. This outcome raises methodological and ethical concerns. The key reverse salient occurred as a consequence of operating system updates, posing a particular problem for Apple app developers, but which raises a more generally applicable ethical concern. In particular, the deployment by the researchers of the *EthnoCorder* app, the iOS operating system, the iPad and other actors in the network constitutes the intervention of third parties standing between the researcher and the participants. Operating system updates were out of the control of the participants and the researchers. In effect the researchers were outsourcing important aspects of the relationship between themselves and the participants to others, and were beholden to third parties for the conduct of important aspects of the research.

A further ethical consideration associated with the technology emerged through the implications of our intervention in the household's domestic media ecology. Providing the household with an iPad is problematic, particularly in the context of social research directly related to technology appropriation and practices. In the data collected through these early stages of the longitudinal study, there is an indication that the disruptive qualities of the technology, particularly the tools used to deliver the tasks—the iPad minis—intervened in and disrupted the very thing we were studying, the established household media ecology and routines of technology use.

This technological intervention raised other ethical issues. In requiring participants to spend more time engaging with electronic devices, it may be exacerbating the potential risks associated with this. For example, it has been argued that over-use of technologies such as iPads can cause significant neurological harms (Greenfield 2014). While such claims are far from proven, the iPad may not be without social or psychological harm, and it may be admitted that we have no specific mechanisms in place to trace or respond to any harms that might arise from the iPad's presence.

In summary, a number of ethical concerns emerged from both the research design and data collection process. These related to the relatively high participant burden, issues of perceived capacity and confidence

required to complete the tasks, and the disruptive qualities of the device. This research shows that visual methods and video data are not unproblematic, though they have sometimes been represented as such in discussions of household technology methods elsewhere (Blythe et al. 2002; Petersen 2002).

Many of the household and technical ethical concerns that were identified were subsequently addressed through modifications to the research design, and in collaboration with the research participants. These modifications included simplifying the data collection activities and burden of choice by setting specific tasks from the available list for each period of data collection. While these strategies in some ways undermined the aims of the participatory methodology by giving more structure to the activities, they also served to make the process more inclusive in enabling more participants to feel able to contribute to the study. Rather than relying only on the iPad minis and the *EthnoCorder* app, participants were able to use their own digital devices or software to complete tasks. Participants were also able to use email to communicate with researchers and send data.

Conclusion

In summary, digital ethnography tools offer opportunities for visual ethnographic research and participatory studies. Yet these tools may become obstacles to data collection and introduce new, and unanticipated, methodological and ethical concerns. The tasks invited people to actively participate in the research in a meaningful way, but this also imposes upon the daily lives of participants. The open-ended and expressive tasks also resulted in self-imposed standards that potentially constrained the ways in which some participants felt they could contribute to the project. A lack of familiarity with new technologies asks for patience from the participants and researchers, and may add to the burdens of participation. Important aspects of the research process may not be in the control of the researchers. Finally, the methodology entails the introduction of a technology into domestic environments, and harms that might be associated with this warrant consideration.

Using digital ethnography tools can add further layers of methodological and ethical complexity to data collection processes. There is, however, potential for such tools to provide opportunities to engage with participants in a situated manner over extended periods of time in

ways that would otherwise be difficult to achieve. Moreover, the digital ethnography approach offers important opportunities for realising the methodological ambitions of cultural probe approaches by intervening in and disrupting the daily flow of life in order to prompt reflective engagement with familiar, everyday environments. Our research to date in this longitudinal project suggests that, if carefully and thoughtfully managed—in consultative, flexible and iterative ways—these kinds of ethnographic tools can strengthen participant engagement and commitment to the research, as well as build participant-researcher relationships, and yield rich, and otherwise hard to obtain, participant insight and self-reflection.

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CHAPTER 5

The Ethics of Researching Images Found Online

Anna Harris

Introduction

The sheer quantity of qualitative data that researchers can find online increases every day. Photographs, videos, links, text and numerous other online material are not only uploaded and created voluntarily but also generated as part of everyday life as we buy things online, visit websites and engage with social media. As a consequence of this new scale of production, some social theorists suggest that an increasing proportion of data that were formally generated by social researchers, using surveys, questionnaires and interviews, is now accessed and downloaded, in one form or another, from the internet (Savage and Burrows 2007; Thrift 2011). Thrift (2011) posits that the volume of this data poses an analytical challenge for social scientists who want to find meaning in this material. In this chapter I address important and related challenges regarding the ubiquity of online material, principally images, highlighting the ethical issues that arise in engaging with this content in social science research. In doing so I problematise what it means to "find" images, and what it means to consider images as "data".

There have been several public controversies in recent years that have highlighted the ethically contentious nature of researchers using material

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found online, as well as the consequences of unintended use of online images. In 2006, social scientists at Harvard University used the access that research assistants had to their friends' Facebook accounts to download data for an analysis of students' social lives. These researchers were heavily criticised for the unethical nature of this project in regard to consent and privacy, and questions were raised about the ethics of online research more broadly. Zimmer (2010), for example, pointed out that despite measures taken to protect the anonymity of the students, it did not take long to identify the university and even individual students, based on analysis of the course offerings and other demographic data. Zimmer questioned whether users of social media fully understand the trade-offs that they are making when posting personal information online.

Almost 10 years later, in 2015, an Irish couple posed with their newborn son for photographs, taken by a friend who wanted to build their photographic portfolio. The couple agreed to the use of the images in the friend's stock library, which would be posted online. What they did not foresee was that these images would be plastered on large billboards by a political party to promote heterosexual family values in the build up to the Irish gay marriage vote (Murtagh 2015). While not an example of images being (mis)used in research, this story nonetheless highlights how hard it is to predict what will happen to images when they are shared online. The internet is used by third parties to find visual material which is often seen to be "there for the taking", something which those who uploaded the images may be unaware or disapprove of.

These two cases highlight the ongoing ethical complexities of "finding" material, such as images, online. In this chapter I will explore these complexities further, offering an overview of using found images in research, before discussing an empirical study of YouTube videos I conducted with Sally Wyatt and Susan Kelly. This YouTube material, collected as part of our larger study on online genetic testing (a commercial industry where consumers can purchase genetic health and ancestry tests via the internet, read their results and engage with other genetic testing users), highlights the multimedia, multisensory, hyperlinked nature of much online visual data these days. We approached the YouTube videos from the perspective of anthropology, science and technology studies and internet studies. We were interested in videos uploaded by individuals who had filmed themselves using the genetic tests or reading their genetic testing results, and had then posted these videos online. In analysing this material, we needed to address an important question: Were these "found" texts, similar to

television broadcasts, for public viewing, or were they more like interview material, in a readymade form, created by the users? There were ethical consequences of the approach we took, in regard to how we framed our "participants".

In this chapter I discuss our solution to questions that arose from our work with these videos and the issues that still remain unsolved. In doing so I explore the ambiguous and ethically complicated use of images online more generally, examining in particular the ambiguities of: the borderless nature of research material and the bordered nature of ethics committees; ownership of data; confidentiality; and obtaining consent. I suggest that while internet-based research is on the rise, especially given tighter research budgets as well as the pervasiveness of online encounters in everyday life, researchers and ethics committees are still not yet fully prepared for the complexities of online research.

Using Found Images

What does it mean to "find" something? Finding is commonly defined as discovering something by chance or effort. It also means collecting something in its natural state and presenting it in a new context. A typical example used in dictionaries is an object "found" in an archaeological dig that is then presented in a museum. A more everyday example might be finding an interesting looking photograph or scrap of paper on the footpath. The popular magazine *Found* is filled with such quirky examples. While the research that social scientists do online often has a great element of discovery and surprise, it is not entirely by chance that researchers come across the material that they do. There is often a research question, a conceptual puzzle they are trying to solve or existing engagements with communities underlying the searches they make for such material. The definition of finding as collecting and using in a different context seems more appropriate here. Social scientists are collecting something (an image) in one state (online) and presenting it in another (a research context).

Using found images in social research can be traced across a number of different disciplines. Historians, for example, often use photographs to illustrate their research. Cultural studies scholars theorise about visual culture, whether film, video, photographs or other images. Anthropologists have a long history of using found images in the field, often as a form of elicitation (Vokes 2007) to establish meanings of social connections, objects and rituals, for example, while cultural geographers have also been

using found images in the form of photos, maps and diagrams (Rose 2012). Sociologists have been the most active in developing visual methods, delineating the use of images into researcher-generated, participant-generated and found images (Guillemin and Drew 2010). The first two methods are discussed in more detail elsewhere in this collection, and here I focus on the third, found images.

As Rose (2012: xvii) points out in her updated introduction to *Visual Methodologies*, the internet has led to a blossoming of possibilities for using found images, from YouTube and video games, online archives and smartphone images, to numerous photo-sharing websites. In her book, she attempts to bring into dialogue the work of social scientists using visual research methods and visual cultural scholars who use found images. Despite such literature, which explores the complexities of visual methodologies, it can still be tempting for researchers to consider found images as relatively "easy data". In a guidebook to good research, Dunscombe (2014: 237) outlines the temptations of this approach:

> As a source of data, 'found' images sidestep a number of problems associated with the data gathering process for 'created' images. Technical issues about equipment and practical issues of access to locations, for instance, no longer arise since the image already exists. Immediately, this suggests that the use of found images is an attractive proposition for the social researcher because it requires less skill to produce and may well prove less expensive if it saves fieldwork, travel and production costs. Equally attractive, it overcomes the ethical concerns of getting informed consent in those cases where the image involves living people. Added to this, the Internet offers a huge stock of downloadable images that social researchers can potentially use. No fieldwork or travel are required.

The seduction of using found images highlights the need for greater attention to be paid to the ethical dimensions of this research. To date the literature on the ethics of visual research methods has tended to focus on participant-generated and researcher-generated images, while visual cultural studies and historical scholars rarely discuss the ethical aspects of their research, tending to focus on copyright. In this chapter I attempt to address the gaps in the visual ethics discussion through an exploration of an empirical use of online images, as outlined in the next section, and afterwards, the ethical issues this raised.

The YouTube Study

Fuelled by hopes and promises, the emerging field of direct-to-consumer genetic testing provides access to tests outside of clinical settings. The tests offer information about individuals' risks for particular diseases, character traits such as curly hair or tongue curling, as well as ancestry details. We began studying online genetic testing by looking at company websites, and how they represented, for example, genetic counselling (Harris et al. 2013) and scientific controversies (Wyatt et al. 2016). After some time we became increasingly interested in those who were using these online services. Gaining access to these users was difficult though, not only because their numbers were relatively small but also because their contact details were owned by the genetic testing companies. We therefore decided to examine videos posted by users of online genetic testing services in order to understand more about how people were engaging with this technology.

For our study we queried the YouTube database for English-language videos uploaded by users of genetic testing services. Because of our research interest in health genetics, we focused only on videos which dealt with disease testing (rather than ancestry) and found 20 in total, all users of one genetic-testing company called *23andMe*. We divided these 20 videos into three types: "spitting" videos where users filmed themselves collecting saliva samples and sending off their tests; "logging into the results" videos, where users filmed themselves reading their genetic testing results; and retrospective descriptive accounts, which offered retellings of these processes. We took the posted videos as the unit of analysis (i.e. visual moving image, speech and other sounds) as well as the surrounding online content (e.g. comments, hyperlinks and other videos). In doing so, we decided to treat the videos as texts, an ethical decision I explore in more detail below.

We analysed the material using narrative analysis (Gubrium and Holstein 2009), paying particular attention to the conditions of storytelling and its effects, considering the story process within the circumstances in which it unfolds, rather than viewing storytelling as an unmediated account of experience. We were interested in the materiality and embodied nature of testing and storytelling, the editing and intertextuality of stories. We did not contact the people who posted the videos and know very little of their reasons for testing, their trust in the company and how they weighed up the risks of participation in genetic testing, especially in regard to privacy.

Procedural Ethics

For this study we applied for ethics approval from the College of Social Sciences and International Studies Ethics Committee, at University of Exeter, UK, where two of the investigators were based at the time. The Ethics Committee exempted the internet research from requiring ethics approval. There are several aspects of this ethics review process to be noted here.

First, the research was jointly funded by Dutch and UK research councils, with the researchers working across these two countries, a situation which is becoming increasingly common in regard to the funding arrangements in Europe and elsewhere. The UK has, like many Anglo-Saxon countries, long had ethics review committees overseeing social science research. In the Netherlands such ethics review committees did not exist for non-medical, non-psychological research, and are only now being instigated, mainly due to the pressures from European funding bodies and international journals, as well as the result of several local research scandals involving fraud and fabrication of data (KNAW 2013). While the material we researched was globally distributed (although mainly from users in the USA), our ethics review process was geographically bound and took shape very differently in the two countries. The borderless nature of using online images in research confronted the bordered nature of procedural ethics (Guillemin and Gillam 2004).

The second aspect of the review process that is relevant to this discussion of online image use is how the internet research was exempt from review. The internet research was not construed as involving human participants. This is a situation curiously mirroring the ethics review process that the companies we studied underwent when they conducted surveys of their customers. Their research was also exempt from ethics review because their surveys did not involve "interpersonal contact between investigator and participant (that is, data and samples are provided without participants meeting any investigator)" (Gibson and Copenhaver 2010). Yet as online transactions are increasingly embedded in daily life, can we make such an artificial distinction? Doing so risks separating the images produced online from the producers.

Using words such as "data" also potentially constructs a separation of visual material uploaded from those who produce it and potentially distances researchers from ethical questions their research might raise. As Carpenter and Dittrich (2012) point out in their analysis of the ethics

of computer science research, there needs to be a reconceptualisation of "distance" in ethics review. This demands a shift from thinking about the degree of direct human involvement to thinking about the potential risks of the research to individuals regardless of whether they are "directly" involved.

Everyday Ethics

Researchers are confronted with various ethical dilemmas when dealing with the vast quantities of material online, many that are characteristic of research more broadly (although with features particular to internet infrastructures and interactions). There has been much discussion about privacy and anonymity, with different views on how to deal with these issues (e.g. Ess and AoIR Ethics Working Committee 2002; Wyatt 2012). In regard to using found material on the internet, many researchers apply codes of conduct centred around the levels of privacy established by individuals and communities through the use of password protection (e.g. see Berry 2004). It can be difficult to make such clear distinctions however between what is considered public and what is considered private. There is also much visual material to be "found" which is not password protected, uploaded by individuals for their own purposes, not intended to be used as research material, or left as traces of transactions or other online movements.

As ethically conscientious researchers, how should we treat this material? Answering this question includes a closer exploration of the internet as an infrastructure and medium for social interchange. Is the internet a textual repository where authors and others deposit work? Or is it a space (or rather many spaces) in which embodied human beings interact (Berry 2004: 324)? Must it be one or the other? We considered carefully whether the individuals who appeared in the YouTube videos we studied—which in our case were also those individuals who had uploaded the videos—should be considered as individuals creating texts for public consumption, or as social science research participants.

Let us consider the internet as a textual repository, and in our case, the YouTube videos as texts, which is what we decided to do in our own research. We chose to treat the videos as public textual resources, similar to a television programme (Berry 2004: 327), and we analysed the audio-visual material of the video, and the surrounding online visual and written content. This was important for us theoretically, as we were interested

in contexts for storytelling about genetics and how internet technologies shaped this. We also came to our decision by considering the accessibility of the videos (no password required). Finally, we followed Berry (2004: 327) who suggests that the deliberations of the online community should be used as the basis for understanding and using their online artefacts. We thus considered the ethos of the site we were studying which is to "Broadcast Yourself" (part of the YouTube logo in its early, pre-Google days) in our ethical decision-making.

Researchers do not need consent from celebrities to write about them in their work, but how far does this extend to those whom Marwick and boyd (sic, 2011) refer to as "micro-celebrities", such as those broadcasting themselves on YouTube? While we chose to study the videos as texts, we were aware of the potential conflict this had with our own criticisms of *23andMe* for its practices in relation to the collection and use of customers' data that were collected when they completed health questionnaires and surveys (e.g. we were critical of the covert ways in which the company used data from customers, and the empowerment rhetoric they used to elicit participation in questionnaires and other data collecting activities, in order to build databases for profit). Were we any different from this genetic testing company in our treatment of these videos as data for our own research purposes?

Individuals going about their everyday online lives are not obliged to be part of research. Even if they are voluntarily uploading images and videos, it does not necessarily mean that this information is fair game for researchers. Nissenbaum (2010: 127) discusses the different expectations of privacy people may have in particular contexts, describing privacy "neither as a right to secrecy nor a right to control but a right to appropriate flow of personal information". Similarly, Bakardjieva and Feenberg (2000) highlight the potential for alienation that might arise from the indiscriminate use of material found online, material that has been provided in one context and taken up in another. Henderson, Johnson and Auld (2013: 547, 551) build upon these insights to argue that social media means that a variety of details necessary for moral deliberation can be lost, such as knowing who participants are, who has provided the data, as well as what is considered private. Dennen (2012) is particularly critical of researchers who use material found online as texts, without contacting those who have uploaded it. She argues that when images on the internet are viewed as "data sources", the images become decontextualised and separated from their authors.

While Dennen's point is an important one, it does also assume a clear and direct relationship between individuals "offline" and their images "online". This is not always the case, for example, individuals' use of avatar images. One of the complicated issues in regard to online research is the ways in which the technological infrastructure disrupts current ethical guidelines that centre on a particular kind of relationship between researcher and participant, where they may meet in person during an interview or fieldwork, for example. Internet platforms such as social media, however, are places where more and more everyday interactions and relations are played out. Ethics committees thus need to continually reassess their understandings of distance when it comes to internet interactions, as current understandings do not always reflect the potential risks and harms of the research, where online interactions can be just as potentially harmful as those conducted without the intermediary of the internet.

Online research is a moving target (Ess 2012: xi) and there are no clear answers. While my colleagues and I considered our approach to the YouTube videos very carefully, it is still not clear to us whether we have made the right decision. There is certainly a very good argument to be made for contacting the individuals who uploaded the YouTube videos we studied, however difficult this may be, to try and gain consent to use their material. We could potentially also learn a lot more about the motivations of the genetic testers and many other interesting details of their engagements with genetic testing companies and their results. To date there have been very few studies exploring user perspectives on this topic, and further research into the stories users tell about their engagements with new technologies such as online genetic testing would offer further insights into the ethical issues to be considered in these continually evolving health and lifestyle practices.

Conclusions

In this chapter I have outlined some of the ethical issues of social research using images found online. I have problematised what it means to "find" images and use them in contexts other than originally intended, giving an outline of research that uses this approach. Rather than considering found images as "easy data", I examined the complexities of undertaking this research, from ethics approval to everyday ethics. Other issues, which there has not been room to discuss, include the reporting of research when using this kind of material, and the ethical challenges of providing

empirical support for arguments. The issues I explored in this chapter are neither new nor specific to the use of images found online. Issues related to online identity, privacy and confidentiality have been raised since researchers began studying the Web in the mid-1990s. As images online become increasingly ubiquitous and internet research opportunities continue to grow and change, new issues will be raised. This demands continued methodological and ethical reflexivity on the part of social science researchers, more discussion of ethical challenges, solutions and unresolved dilemmas, as well as a continual revisiting of these issues by ethics committees.

McQuire (2013: 238) writes that a transition has been made recently in research from an understanding of the image based on aesthetics and politics of representation towards an understanding of images as data. We need to be careful once we turn images into data, not to lose connection with those who are implicated in the making, taking and uploading of the visual material. Yet nor can we assume simple social arrangements and connections, or that we will be able to understand the full "context" of an image. As well as considering the individuals involved, it is important to consider the infrastructural details of the internet (Bowker et al. 2010), such as the limitations and possibilities of different platforms, the rules of engagement of websites, the (sometimes robotic) mechanisms of editing and relations of trust constructed. Technology is not a neutral tool that gives researchers unmediated access to data, references, ideas and people. Technology mediates and structures researchers' interactions at all stages of the research process, something which ethics committees might neglect in their focus on a researcher-participant relationship perceived before the internet.

In this article I have focused on the empirical case of YouTube video use and ongoing dilemmas that my collaborators and I faced in our research, expanding this to discuss the ethical issues facing other social researchers dealing with found images online. There is of course another realm of research that we have not discussed here, that of commercial research. Computational tools, including algorithms, linked data and databases, allow industry to harvest data from multiple and diverse sources in order to recombine it for other purposes. While such tools offer many possibilities, they may also render in/visible some information, data, categories, institutions and people (Bowker and Star 1999), challenging notions of informed consent in the process. Research controversies such as those I discussed at the beginning of the chapter have not disappeared. For

example, social media sites such as Facebook are conducting research on the images uploaded by their users, in ways we don't fully realise (Matias 2015). With the increasing use of technologies that enable images to be taken and uploaded without even thinking about it, the ethics of online image use is a concern not only for researchers but society more broadly.

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CHAPTER 6

Cultivating Reflexive Research Practice When Using Participants' Photographs as Research Data

Carly Guest

Introduction

Researchers across disciplines are increasingly using visual methods to explore multiple layers of experience (Brookfield et al. 2008; Del Busso 2011; Silver and Reavey 2010). In this chapter I consider some methodological and ethical challenges that arise from the use of photographs as data, drawing on two examples from my research into women's narratives of becoming feminist (Guest 2016). This work, which involved blending photo-elicitation methods and narrative interviewing, was influenced by the developing tradition within social research for using creative research methodologies as a means of exploring experience. I argue that visual methods, specifically the use of personal photographs, presents opportunities for and demands reflexivity in order to navigate the challenges that unfold across the research process. As research data, photographs can have multiple layers of meaning for both the researcher and participant. To understand how and why these layers are brought more or less into view, we must reflect on our own response to the images and consider the factors that shape our interpretation of them.

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I discuss photographs shared by two participants who I refer to as Rebecca and Alice. Rebecca's photograph prompted questions about the process of interpretation and the importance of reflexivity to ensure participants' stories are not overwhelmed by researchers' own stories. Alice's photograph highlighted the challenges of navigating political and ethical concerns when disseminating findings from visual research. Both of these examples highlight the power that researchers have in directing the ways that images are interpreted and shared, and the importance of engaging in reflexive work to interrogate how and why we make methodological and ethical decisions.

Methodology

The study involved interviewing feminist women aged between 20 and 35. The interview approach was based on the Biographical Narrative Interpretive Method (Wengraf 2004), which was adapted to incorporate visual methods. The interviews were loosely structured in three parts. To begin the women were asked to tell their stories of 'becoming feminist'. I then asked questions based upon their account to draw out details of moments, people and places of importance. Finally, I invited the women to share photographs and explain why they were meaningful. These discussions drew out the participants' interpretation of the images and their significance to their story of becoming feminist.

Annette Kuhn's (1995) guidelines for visual analysis provided a framework for exploring the significance of the photographs with participants. Kuhn asks the viewer to consider the feelings they associate with an image, to explore its content, context and means of production and its intended and actual audience. These steps are designed to generate associations to extend the analysis beyond a solely personal response, in order to position the photograph in cultural and historical contexts. Kuhn places photographs at the intersection of the personal and social, illustrating that even these very intimate objects are never wholly personal. The images participants brought to the interviews ranged from childhood photographs, to images of people, places and events that were recently taken, and so spoke to the ongoing significance of past events in the women's present day personal and political identifications. Participants shared both personal photographs and publically available images and in doing so blurred these boundaries. Publically available, and often familiar, images acquired distinct and personal meanings for the women, whilst their personal pho-

tographs took on wider significance when discussed in relation to their feminist politics.

Visual Methods

My use of visual methods was driven by an understanding that the processes of narrating, remembering and forgetting are central to human experience and the development of identity and subjectivity (Lawler 2007; Plummer 1994; Middleton and Brown 2004). Therefore, the ways in which we select, recall and retell our experiences reveal something about processes of meaning-making and the construction of identities (Tamboukou 2008; Plummer 1994; Lawler 2007; Squire 2005). Visual methods can illuminate this by exploring how objects, such as photographs, mediate and provide some stability to our engagement with the past, offering a point of reference across the fluid and unstable processes of remembering (Middleton and Brown 2005). The incorporation of photographs into social research recognises that they link us with the past and take on new and shifting meaning when being viewed in the present.

Kuhn's (1995) work was instrumental in convincing me to take the visual seriously when researching the relationships and emotional entanglements active in the development of personal and political identifications. In her 'revisionist autobiography' *Family Secrets* (1995)—a term that signals a critique of autobiography as an individualistic endeavour—Kuhn uses written and visual narrative to explore the relationship between memory and identity. She views the production, content, reception and organisation of photographs as a form of narrative expression; photographs, and our readings of them, tell personal, social and cultural stories. Our response to photographs reveals the ways in which we might wish to reorder, retell or 'repair' the past in the present, and in this way they negotiate the relationship between past and present. The incorporation of photographs into social research, therefore, acknowledges their significance to the construction of identity and attends to the multiple ways in which narratives and memories are formed and expressed.

In bringing personal photographs to the interview—ones that have a meaning beyond their story of becoming feminist—the women 'reorder' the stories that these photographs have previously told and bring them to the centre of their feminist becomings. Photographs that might not have explicit or self-explanatory feminist content are displayed in the interview setting to form part of a narrative of becoming feminist. An example of

this was the way in which all of the women discussed their mothers and most shared a photograph of them. In the context of the interview, these family photographs told feminist stories, and displayed or discussed elsewhere they might take on different meanings altogether. These maternal images also operate at the intersection between the personal and social, because whilst deeply personal feelings are attached to them, they take on a collective significance for understanding feminist storytelling when considered together. It is by no means a coincidence that so many of the women shared images of their mothers to discuss a topic that is so often articulated in generational and familial terms.

This reordering and recasting of past events with new and shifting meaning in the present occurs in any narrative account, and photographs can illustrate this process in a very material way. For example, during the interviews different women sorted and discussed their photographs chronologically, thematically or affectively. The ways in which the women arranged and handled the images during the interview formed part of the construction of their narrative. The incorporation of photographs into the research method therefore offers possibilities for exploring the layers of meaning an image and its context of display can reveal. Whilst photographs can offer a fascinating means of exploring how identities are configured as we interpret and reinterpret past experiences, they also present methodological and ethical challenges precisely because of the shifting and varied meanings they have the capacity to convey. As researchers, our interpretation of visual data must include consideration of the meaning of the photograph for the participant and how this is shaped by the research context, but also take into account how our own responses to the image shape this interpretation and decisions made about dissemination. Reflexive research practice is essential for managing these different analytic considerations.

Reflexive Research Practice

Reflexive research practices illuminate the ways in which the researcher's positioning shapes the research process at every stage. For me, this is an approach that recognises that all research is auto/biographical. This is not just in the sense that as researchers we might pursue topics influenced by our own lives, but that our reading of others' accounts is inevitably filtered through our own experiences (Cotteril and Letherby 1993). As Pamela Cotteril and Gayle Letherby note:

> We draw on our own experiences to help us understand those of our respondents. Thus their lives are filtered through us and the filtered stories of our lives are present (whether we admit it or not) in our written accounts. (Cotteril and Letherby 1993: 74)

Cotteril and Letherby suggest that the stories we tell about our participants' lives are always understood through the prism of our own stories. Narratives are formed collectively as we draw upon other personal, social and cultural accounts in the construction of our own. Researchers are as much implicated in these processes as anyone else. This does not mean that researchers cannot make knowledge claims—we bring methods and theories to generate and interpret data and have the vantage point of aggregating personal accounts to discern social and cultural patterns. However, reflexivity should form an essential part of the process of making these claims to highlight how the factors that shape the research process are productive of the conclusions drawn.

Various scholars have contributed to the epistemological debates that challenge the boundaries between objectivity and subjectivity (Bourdieu 1990; Letherby et al. 2013; Rowan and Reason 1981). Reflexivity is an essential aspect of any position that posits that, whilst there might be such a thing as a material reality, the exploration of it can never be considered neutral. These insights are much more detailed and nuanced than I have space to develop upon here, but one articulation that I find useful is Letherby's (Letherby et al. 2013) discussion of 'theorised subjectivity'. Letherby acknowledges that researching, writing and theorising are political endeavours and that drawing attention to and exposing the processes of each is part of ensuring both methodological rigour and ethical practice. Reflexive research should not seek to isolate or eradicate the influence of our auto/biography, even if this were possible, but to draw attention to the ways in which the research process is shaped and formed by it. In adopting this perspective, we are able to consider the significance of processes of knowledge production, that is, being explicit about how the decisions we make about research design, data selection, interpretation and so on impacts upon the conclusions we draw. It also acknowledges that the auto/biographical position we work from shapes these decisions.

I am a feminist woman and so in researching how women 'become feminist' my own investment in the topic is evident in many ways. Whilst I anticipated that I would identify with many aspects of participants' experiences, there was always a risk of colonising the accounts by reading them

from my own white, middle-class perspective. Indeed, critical work on the production of feminist histories illustrates that this positioning makes certain (problematic) narratives of feminist history, such as generational inheritance, available and knowable to me in ways that might be different for other women (Henry 2004). This is a risk in any research process and it is for this reason that reflexive research practice is so crucial. In asking questions about our own positioning as researchers, we can consider how this shapes our research. Crucially, it can alert us to points where our own interpretation might overwhelm the voices of our participants. It is the blurring of these boundaries that requires reflection. I do this not to separate my own experiences from my interpretation, but to acknowledge and understand the role my feminist story had in the retelling of others' stories. This goes some way to acknowledging the power dynamics that are at play when, as researchers, we have control of the interpretation of participants' stories.

Whilst reflexivity is critical for all research methods, I found that my participants' photographs often drew my attention in very immediate ways to how my own personal perspectives and experiences were shaping my engagement with their accounts. My responses to these photographs repeatedly reminded me of the necessity of reflexivity for ensuring ethical and rigorous research practice. I turn now to Rebecca and Alice's photographs to illustrate the function of reflexive research practice for exposing the factors that influence our research decisions. Firstly, in my discussion of Rebecca's photograph, I consider how reflexivity helped me negotiate the shifting and multi-layered stories that photographs can tell and explore the processes and ethics of interpretation. Secondly, I consider the ethical issues that arose when Alice's motivation for sharing two photographs conflicted with my own concern for her wellbeing. Both these issues became apparent through the women's photographs and my response to them. I have chosen to discuss Rebecca and Alice's photographs here because they each exemplify in vivid ways how paying attention to our immediate and affective responses to participants' accounts can bring our preconceptions, assumptions or discomfort about a research topic and the processes of interpretation and dissemination into view.

Rebecca's Photograph

Like many of the participants, Rebecca's story of becoming feminist had a strong familial and, in particular, maternal narrative. Her parents were politically active and the images and sounds of the political landscape of

1980s Britain featured heavily in memories of her childhood. In particular, Rebecca recalled the 1984–85 UK miners' strikes and marches organised by the UK's Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament. During the interview Rebecca shared photographs, songs and stories from this period. Rebecca's mother was the protagonist in these stories, her prominence strongly suggested that Rebecca's own political activism was inspired by her example.

Rebecca's mother died when Rebecca was just ten. I read Rebecca's affection for the sights, sounds and socialist oppositional politics of the 1980s as placing her in time with her mother. This familial and maternal narrative of becoming feminist was, in part, reproduced and retold through images Rebecca brought to the interview, one of which was of her mother. In the photograph Rebecca's mother is alone, dressed casually in jeans and jumper, with no make-up, smiling as she leans against a dry stonewall. The photograph was taken in the early 1980s. Explaining its significance, Rebecca said:

> We never got to know each other as, you know, as you do as a teenage girl with your mum, or as a young woman, and also because I look like her, but, I have the same kind of mannerisms as her and that reminds me of me.

Rebecca recognises herself in the photograph and maintains a relationship with her mother through it. Her extended discussion of her mother emphasised the embodied markers by which, as a child, Rebecca 'knew' her mother was a feminist. These included wearing casual clothes and no make-up and other aspects that might be considered antithetical to the stereotypical markers of femininity. In recognising herself in this photograph, Rebecca perhaps also saw herself as feminist. Rebecca's narrative of becoming feminist is embedded in the politics of her childhood and in particular the association of political activism with her mother. I read her feminist identity as one that offered her a means of identifying with and staying close to her mother.

My own reaction to this photograph when I saw it during the interview illustrated how, as researchers, we interpret and shape participants' stories through our own experiences. When I first saw Rebecca's photograph, I noted her mother's striking similarity to my own feminist aunt. In my viewing, I recognised the photograph, and the female, familial, feminist history it speaks to, as my own. My initial reading of Rebecca's photograph highlighted the importance of reflexive research practice. It indicated how I might expect Rebecca to read the image herself and how my interpretation of her account was intertwined with my own feminist story.

Cox et al. (2014) refer to the 'fuzzy boundaries' between researcher and participant that can be associated with visual methods. Whilst they consider in particular the blurring of roles when both researcher and participant are invested in the *creation* of visual products, the interpretation of the visual in my research exposed 'fuzzy boundaries' between our stories. The immediacy of my affective response to the photograph brought this fuzziness to light in a very visceral way. It was in this moment of viewing that my investments in and preconceptions of the topic were revealed.

The incorporation of personal photographs into social research has the potential to venture into what Boydell et al. (2012: 10) term 'dangerous emotional terrain'. They suggest that artistic modes of representation have an 'emotional proximity and persuasiveness' (11) that can unsettle and trouble participants. Visual methods offered a form of data that, because of its emotional intensity, was likely to provoke reactions in both Rebecca and myself. In this instance my affective response to Rebecca's image—the feeling that it was *my* family photograph—alerted me to the influence of my own experiences on my interpretation. It prompted me to consider whether I was placing the familial and, in particular the maternal, at the centre of her feminist becoming because of the ways in which her images echoed in my own memories. This pushed me to question and challenge the focus of my analysis, and produced a more rigorous and justifiable interpretation.

Rebecca's photograph alerted me to the significance of my own feminist story in my interpretation of hers and drew attention to my investment in one of the stories the photograph told: that of a female, familial, feminist heritage. In this case the generational narrative that is given prominence in Rebecca's account was partly due to my own identification with the narrative. In exposing the ways in which interpretation is situated and specific, reflexivity served to push the analysis forward. In this example, without denying the importance of the maternal in Rebecca's account, I was obliged to reconsider its complexities and the ways in which other aspects of her narrative disrupted its dominance. Reflexive practice was critical for avoiding telling a final and authoritative story about Rebecca's feminism and, rather, offering an interpretation that was formed by various personal, political, methodological and theoretical positions.

Alice's Photograph

My second example is concerned with the importance and usefulness of reflexivity for thinking about the factors that influence the dissemination of participants' photographs. Assuming a participant has given consent for

the photograph to be reproduced, decisions about dissemination might be based on the image's relevance to an analytical point. However, my response to some of Alice's photographs illustrated that, beyond this, there are other factors at play in this decision making process.

Alice brought a number of personal photographs to the interview that documented periods of her gaining and losing weight that were suggestive of relationships to her sexuality, femininity and feminism. She used these images to disrupt and challenge dominant ideals of feminine beauty and to tell a story of becoming feminist as something that helped her resist pressure to conform to these norms. Her discussion centred around two photographs. The first was an image of Alice standing in her underwear, with one foot on a chair as she adjusts her stocking. The photograph was taken by a professional photographer as part of a series that also featured a former girlfriend. The second image was taken some years later for an informal photoshoot with a friend. It was intended for a calendar that was never printed. It showed Alice, sitting on a bed, looking directly into the camera and smiling. She is naked in the photograph, although the viewer cannot see the detail of her body due to her pose and dark lighting. In the second image, Alice has gained weight and her discussion of it suggested that she was using it to defy the coupling of slimness and attractiveness.

Guided by the work of Rose Wiles et al. (2008), I offered participants different levels of consent for their photographs. These ranged from images being discussed but not reproduced, to being reproduced in full. Alice gave the highest level of consent for both these images, agreeing to them being reproduced in full in presentations and publications. In the context of her discussion of 'fat positivity' (Cooper 2010), Alice's consent for the reproduction of the second image was driven by her feminist politics. However, despite Alice giving full consent for these photographs to be reproduced, I have felt uncertain and uncomfortable about doing so. In part, this unease reflects concerns that Alice might come to change her mind about sharing the images, and this is a concern that can be addressed by a staged consent process as suggested by Cox et al. (2014). The intimacy of the images, however, meant that I was unsure about reproducing them even with contingent conditions for consent.

This conflict between Alice's consent and my own unease with the reproduction of her photographs raised questions about the reasons for this. When images are shared with wider audiences, participants might have little control over the context in which they are displayed or how they are interpreted. The generation, sharing and distribution of images can evoke unexpected emotional responses, perhaps particularly when the

images depicted are intensely personal and intimate. I was concerned that Alice might feel exposed if the images were shared and so regret giving consent. I was also concerned that she would be subject to judgement by different viewers and audiences. This is despite at least one of the images originally being intended for publication as part of a calendar. This calendar was not published because of difficulties with printing, rather than reluctance from the subjects. There were, therefore, numerous indicators that Alice was willing and enthusiastic for the photograph to be published in some context.

Alice had explicitly political intent in bringing the images to the interview and giving permission for them to be shared. In wanting to take account of the possibility of Alice changing her mind about sharing the photograph, I was also undermining her reason for giving full consent—that is, to challenge, question and disrupt popular and heteronormative notions of 'beauty'. To exclude the images when she had been so enthusiastic about their inclusion could contribute to and imply the shaming of the fat female body that she was resisting by sharing them. It also highlighted the power dynamics that were active in our relationship because, as the researcher, I had the power to make the final decision about how a photograph would be shared, within the parameters of the consent awarded by Alice. In the case of Alice's image, I draw on this power to undermine her own intention for the distribution of the image, albeit out of concern for her.

My reluctance to share the photographs highlighted a tension between an ethical obligation to protect participants, but also to offer them a platform to tell their stories. In Alice's case, to refuse to reproduce the photographs would deny her the opportunity to use her participation as a form of political action. Choosing not to reproduce the images in the context of a research project that is concerned with the development of a political consciousness, therefore, might seem contradictory. However, Alice's discussion of beauty norms and body image revealed that she was by no means immune to the social pressures to conform to beauty standards. Her resistance to these pressures was a daily struggle; she described an ongoing and transforming relationship to her body that, she acknowledged, required her to use various strategies to maintain a positive body image and challenge hegemonic notions of beauty. The sharing of these photographs might have been one such strategy, which perhaps made my reluctance to do so even more problematic. But it was a reluctance that was, in part, prompted by a sense, or assumption, of Alice's vulnerability in the face of societal pressures.

I was also aware of the different degrees of control that Alice and I had over how the research would be disseminated. As researchers we have the privilege of making decisions across time and dependant on context, in ways that are not always possible for participants. One possibility for managing this is to allow participants to reassert or withdraw consent at different stages and so acknowledge that their feelings about consent can change. However, as I discovered through Alice's photographs, it is difficult to always account for, or adequately respond to, our *own* feelings about participants' images. The choices made about dissemination, therefore, go beyond the procedural issue of consent (Guillemin and Gillam 2004) but take into account our feelings and concerns about dissemination, as well as what we might infer about our participants' sensitivities and vulnerabilities, even when they have given consent.

I chose not to reproduce the image here because it is not necessary for making an analytical point. I did decide to include the image in the thesis for which this research was carried out, but included with it a reflection on the reasoning for this. It felt more ethically problematic to not take seriously Alice's reasons for sharing the image and its importance to her story of becoming feminist, than to maintain an anonymity that she had not expressed a desire for. There are tensions between wanting to protect Alice and potentially undermining her autonomy and these cannot be erased and must be addressed through careful consideration given to the sharing of images in each particular instance. Where the photograph is important to the analysis, I foresee it being more appropriate to share it than not. However, it is likely that a level of discomfort or hesitancy in doing so will remain.

Incomplete Resolutions

Visual methods can present distinct ethical challenges (Cox 2014; Wiles 2008). Many of these challenges unfold across the research process and cannot be contained or managed by formalised ethics procedures (Guillemin and Gillam 2004). Likewise, there is no clear resolution to the kinds of challenges I have discussed in this chapter, but reflexive research practice does offer ways of exploring and navigating the issues that are raised (Guillemin and Gillam 2004). Reflexivity is essential for addressing ethical issues that emerge in practice and visual methods can offer valuable opportunities for engaging in this important reflexive work. Reflexive research draws attention to our research choices; there are avenues of

interpretation that we might be more or less inclined to pursue, stories to which we pay more or less attention, and positions from which we approach and interpret data. It is vital that these are explored, illuminated and questioned as part of ethical and rigorous research.

Kuhn (1995) emphasises the importance of paying attention to our thoughts, feelings and responses to photographs as a means of understanding the stories they tell. In a research context, this can involve thinking carefully about how the photograph might be understood and experienced differently by researcher and participant. Kuhn offers an approach to working with visual data that is part of a tradition of auto/biographical and reflexive feminist research (Cotterill and Letherby 1993; England 1994; Letherby 2012). Visual methods offer ample opportunity for engaging in this important reflexive work and illuminate the various dynamics that are active in the research process.

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CHAPTER 7

The Impact of Photographs on the Researcher: An Ethical Matter for Visual Research

Kim McLeod and Marilys Guillemin

Introduction

The use of visual methods in the social sciences has expanded rapidly over recent years. Visual research commonly employs videos, photographs, drawings and a range of graphics; images can be researcher or participant-generated or collected from existing sources. A common approach, broadly referred to as photo elicitation, involves participants generating photographs, which are later discussed during interviews with researchers (Lapenta 2011). In contrast to using interviews alone, integrating photographs has been found to enable the researcher to gain in-depth insights into participants' experiences. Participant-generated photographs foster the sharing of an expanded range of emotion (Padgett et al. 2013) and promote engagement with the sensual aesthetic dimensions of life (Pink 2011). Photographs also enable sharing about environments and places, and the connections participants have to material worlds and objects

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(Johnsen et al. 2008; McLeod 2014a). In addition, photographs expand interactions between researchers and participants by assisting collaborative meaning-making (Catalani and Minkler 2010) and increased intimacy of exchange (Sitvast and Abma 2012, p. 190). Other researchers have indicated how using photographs enables access to vulnerable populations who are not discursively empowered (Padgett et al. 2013).

Although the benefits of using participant-generated photographs in research practice are well documented in the visual research literature, there is little academic discussion of the agency of the photographs, or researchers' reactions to the photographs themselves. The literature on visual research ethics is similarly sparse with regard to the ethical effects of visual materials. A small number of scholars have discussed how photographs can enable additional insight about research encounters, if researchers are willing to include how they were affected in the research processes (e.g. see McLeod 2014b, pp. 384–385; Warren 2008, p. 569). Discussion about researcher conduct speaks to managing the emotionality of using visual methods via trust and rapport (Padgett et al. 2013, p. 1442). This reflects the emphasis in visual research ethics on ensuring participants are not harmed by research processes. Overall, there is little regard for the action of visual materials on participants, and even less attention given to the potential impact of visual materials on researchers. One exception is found in the ethical guidelines of Cox et al. (2014), which do explicitly note the potential action of evocative imagery on participants, researchers and audiences. Another key exception is Clark's (2013) brief discussion about how images have the capacity, using Mitchell's (2011) term, to "haunt" us. This points to how photographs themselves are actors; in visual research, they do things in ways that invite ethical scrutiny.

In this chapter, we argue that ethical consideration needs to expand to include the impact of photographs on the researcher. After outlining the research project and its theoretical framework, the chapter provides two empirical illustrations that show how photographs were agents in research encounters. We detail how photographs elicit different kinds of imaginative, bodily and sensory responses, and activate memory in contrasting ways. This is followed by a discussion about the ethical implications of accounting for the work of photographs, including their action on researchers. We propose a framework based on the concept of ethical sustainability (Braidotti 2006a, b) to address these ethical concerns.

To illustrate these issues, we draw on a previously reported research project with eight participants that explored their experiences of wellbe-

ing and antidepressant use (McLeod 2013, 2014a). Debates about antidepressant action are usually underpinned by the depressed individual and oscillate over whether antidepressants work to remedy chemical imbalances in the brains of depressed people, or produce inauthentic states of being. The aim of the research was to explore how people experienced antidepressant use without producing these potentially negative positions. This approach is informed by the insight that there are broader aspects of experience that cannot be subsumed in the subject positions taken up by users of mental health services (Brown and Tucker 2010). The main strategy was to displace the usual subject position of the "depressed individual" from the research process. Instead, an expanded notion of agency, which includes the action of nonhuman elements, was applied to all stages of the research project (McLeod 2014b). In this sense, matter itself is regarded as being able to initiate action, form relations and elicit reactions (Bennett 2005). In other words, material and nonhuman elements are regarded as having agentic capacities. All proximate human and nonhuman elements are seen as active co-participants in forming a relational network, which produces the research encounter. In addition to each element in the relational network having a different capacity to act, the overall relational network has agentic capacity (Deleuze 1977). The power of this capacity or action (to engage, relate and connect) is called affect and is an intensity or force that exceeds the subject (Massumi 2002). Photographs are theorised as embodying vitality and an affective force that can co-create intensely felt bodily connections with viewers (Barthes 1981). In this theoretical framework, photographs as material elements in the research encounter act, and co-construct, the relational network that constitutes the research encounter.

In this project participants were invited to share their experiences of changing wellbeing over time using a timeline on a chart. Participants then took photographs in their own time to communicate what was happening in their lives at different points from their wellbeing charts. The participants came from a variety of cultural backgrounds and ages but shared some key characteristics including tertiary education, professional work roles, and access to a range of support for their emotional wellbeing. The charts acted in contrasting ways to the photographs in the research encounters (McLeod and Guillemin 2015). In this chapter the focus is on the action of the participant-generated photographs and its effects on the researcher.

The Work of Photographs in Research Encounters

This section of the chapter provides two illustrations, from Rowan and Steve (both pseudonyms) that detail how the participant-generated photographs themselves were agents in the research encounters. In these examples, the discussion centres on the effects of the visual materials on Kim, the first author, who undertook the research. What follows are Kim's reflections in relation to the photo elicitation exercise and her experiences following this.

Rowan

Rowan, a university student in his early 20s, has taken a lot of care to prepare photographs to convey to me the range of states he has been in over recent years. He presents a photograph (Fig. 7.1) he took to share a despairing period in his life.



Fig. 7.1 Rowan's photograph, "Blind"

Rowan explains:

> This is just to represent suicidal tendencies or suicide attempt. This would have been before the relationship ended, but after everything went wrong, because a lot of unfortunate things happened, it didn't end when it should have. It followed on from this and just got worse, and worse, and worse. I like the imagery of the receding into darkness. You can't see your hand, that blindness. That's what it was, the absolute incapacity to see anything beyond that point.

As I listen to Rowan's words, I am lured into a viewing position. Like Rowan, I lean out over the platform, and look into the darkness down the receding train track. The photo brings me into a feeling of immediate contact with Rowan's experience. I inhabit Rowan's position and feel the cold night air, the edge of danger in the possibility of an oncoming train. I ask Rowan what title he might consider giving to the photo. He replies:

> Something simple, like "blind". 'Cause that's really, looking back on it now, that's what I feel that I was. The sheer weight of that moment just stopped me from being able to see anything in front of me. That's where the tracks ended and all I could see was that receding into darkness.

Rowan's description of the blocks to his bodily state further illuminates my sense of leaning out over the train tracks. He does not welcome my attempts to reflect back to him what he has conveyed, indicating my verbal input is not required for him to satisfactorily communicate this affective state using his photograph. I am limited to relating to the photo and Rowan's words with my body and imagination. It is difficult for me not to form a direct bodily connection to this rendering of vulnerability.

I am moved that Rowan is sharing this moment with me and want to form a supportive and respectful audience as best I can, within the confines of a nonverbal role. The only move available to me is to use my body to simply be present to the state of pain and suffering the photo communicates. It feels like this requires a form of stillness, or a slowing of time, so that I can meet and be present to the rhythm of the state that Rowan is sharing. My body registers and connects to an imagining of this moment. Rowan does not invite my verbal contribution, and I contain my bodily intensity of being present to the photo, because it seems important to not contribute to escalating any sense of despair in the situation.

Steve

Steve is a retired police officer and has a sharp, neat appearance, like an American baseball player. He arrives with his photographs on a memory stick for us to look at. He has made a list of the photographs at his own instigation, numbered them, ordered them and written a brief explanation of what he wanted to show in each photograph. He has a clear sense of how we should proceed. However, the process of taking the photographs did provoke Steve's feelings in unplanned ways. Steve mentions this in relation to one of the first photographs he shows me, which details the location of a planned suicide attempt—his garage. He describes the photograph to me:

> So that's the garage. I had a rope already hung over. No-one would even know what it was, because I look after the garage and it was just like it was tied to something else. But all I had to do was pull the rope and it would drop down. Probably the thing that would take the longest is move the car out of the garage, longer than anything else.

I am affected to hear about Steve's practical planning for ending his life. I glance at the photo, taking in Steve's words at the same time as I note the utilitarian garage objects in Steve's garage. I feel like I can smell the dusty interior of the garage. A flicker runs from my sternum down my back. For a half-moment I notice the quicksilver sensation through me, but like watching a light that is extinguishing—so fast—in the next half-moment, I'm no longer sure anything happened. My attention swings fully back to Steve, his photos and story. Steve is sharing a vulnerable moment, and I feel compelled to reciprocate by being a receptive audience. I sustain this orientation through the rest of the encounter (Fig. 7.2).

A year later, I am asked how my PhD is going, and the voice I use to answer sounds strange to me, detached. Later on, driving home in the dark, in the rain, I watch the windscreen wipers flick back and forth, back and forth. A memory of the garage photo flicks past my eyes, following the movement of the windscreen wiper. The next instant is filled with a visual image of the interior of a garage from my childhood. A total, intact, return to a place I have given no conscious regard to for many years. Somehow, at the same time, I recall the sense of the dustiness of Steve's garage, and I am—eight, perhaps—feeling the grit of my family's garage concrete floor under small gumboots. I am filling up the grass mower with the can of petrol, enjoying the tang of petrol fumes. To



Fig. 7.2 Steve's photograph, "The garage"

this complete, sensory and spatial return to a place from the past, other memories join. The memories intersect to create trajectories that seem to have a life of their own, and they move me with them. Fortunately, I was able to explore how to bring these disrupted aspects of self back into relation with broader contexts in personal, academic, creative and therapeutic places.

The two illustrations have shown how the photographs had the capacity to provoke the researcher's imagination and memory and enabled the communication of intense affective states of being. The agentic properties of photographs included the capacity to convey affective force which is received as sensation (Barthes 1981) and which enabled the photographs to enact partial and affectively intense processes. The photographs had an agentic capacity of setting up a viewing position (Rose 2007) for the researcher. This agentic capacity guided me to empathically enter into the place occupied by the body of the research participant and facilitated my imaginative engagement with the photograph. I was co-constructed as a nonverbal participant in the encounter, taking up the silent but active position of the witness (Laub 1992; Poland 2000). In particular,

the photographs had the capacity to stimulate nonvolitional memory (Anderson 2004) in ways that had profound effects on me.

Discussion

Much of the literature on research ethics concerns protecting participants. Although this is clearly vital, in this chapter, we focus on the importance of also being sensitive to the effects of research processes on the researcher. This is relevant for all research but in the case of visual research, we argue that there are particularities that we need to attend to. We have noted the agentic capacities of photographs; these can be productive in the research process and generate particular kinds of understandings that may be otherwise unknowable. However, the flip side of this is the potential disturbing capacities of photographs on both participants and researchers. We have conceptualised this in terms of a network of relations between the visual materials, participants and researcher. This network of relations can have powerful effects, long after the actual research encounter. We acknowledge that these effects can have serious destructive consequences for the participant as the producer of the photograph, but we suggest that much attention has been given previously to how to best manage these possible effects on participants. However, for the researcher, these effects are often unanticipated and therefore, not well managed, with potential serious damaging consequences. In the two examples presented, the interaction with the photograph and the participant's narration worked to connect the researcher with the pain and suffering being elicited. This was not just a momentary response, but one that stayed with her months after, releasing previously forgotten memories and past experiences. These were strongly affective experiences which were unexpected. We suggest that the effects photographs can have on the researcher remain a key and unresolved ethical issue that requires further examination.

Just as we appropriately acknowledge and militate against risks to our research participants, we have a similar responsibility to researchers. In the case of photographs with their particular agentic capacities, we propose an ethical framework that draws on Braidotti's (2006a, b) concept of ethical sustainability to address this issue. This concept focuses on the processes by which we endure as subjects, by exploring different ways of inhabiting our bodies. Relevant here are the processes by which a subject enacts a community or collective to rework and transform into new more productive configurations that are sustainable over time. Braidotti (2006a, b,

pp. 270–78) acknowledges that a network of relations that is breaking down can have serious consequences for the subject. However, she emphasises the generative possibility of reconfiguring a disturbed network of relations. This is a reconceptualising of ethical action as not just about minimising and avoiding harm but as actively reconfiguring the network of relations.

It is useful to consider the concept of ethical sustainability with that of "ethics of care" proposed by Mol (2008) and Puig de la Bellacasa (2011); they advocate for ethical responsiveness, or to respond with care to all the components of an encounter, with a view to overall sustainability or productivity. What is particularly relevant to visual research is Mol's inclusion of responsiveness to the action of nonhuman actors, namely photographs. In this instance, being open to the agentic capacities of the photographs was, in an overall sense, productive for the researcher and the research project. New analytic approaches and styles of writing were enabled via the reconfiguring of the researcher's network of relations. The insights generated from this methodological approach produced novel findings about antidepressant use (McLeod 2014a) and wellbeing (McLeod 2013). The concepts of ethical sustainability and the ethics of care are suggestive of researchers cultivating an active orientation towards photographs that contain disturbing topics or "difficult knowledge" (Simon 2011) in research projects. The orientation could include openness to how the nonspecific affective intensities elicited by photographs can provoke thought (Simon 2011) and facilitate critical discussion and analysis (Gil-Glazer 2015). The risks attached to exposing oneself to the affective forces of photographs can be mediated by attending to the design of the overall encounter with photographs that address disturbing topics; this is well illustrated by Gil-Glazer (2015) in the careful crafting of the encounter with photographs in the classroom, and Simon (2011) in the curatorial judgements that shape exhibition spaces. To ensure overall sustainability in projects using visual research methods, this approach urges us to consider and plan for resources to support the researcher to be a cared-for component throughout the research project.

This is best illustrated by referencing the two examples. It is important to first acknowledge the agentic capacity of the photographs, and the potential vulnerability of the researcher to this. This of course has the potential for both generative and decomposing effects. In the examples, we showed how the researcher's bodily engagement facilitated openness to the action of the visual, enhancing the research encounter. The partici-

pants and images were actively engaged in their configuring. However, it also resulted in the strong affective responses on the part of the researcher. The researcher was "lured" into a viewing position and felt immediate connection with the participants' experiences. Following Mitchell (2011) this continued to "haunt" her, long after the initial encounter, in ways that had not been anticipated. The researcher was able to enact existing and new collectives through various personal, academic, creative and therapeutic supports to redress these disruptions. Being reflexive to these potential responses required a reconfiguration of bodily engagement. There are myriad of bodily practices, such as dance and yoga, that develop skills in bodily awareness and receptivity and which can resource visual research practice. Such practices can also enhance understanding of bodily limitations to the intensity of certain situations. It is an understanding of these capacities and their limitations that can lead to ethical sustainability, limiting the impact when required.

We pointed earlier to the paucity of literature on the potential action of photographs, particularly on researchers. In the ethical guidelines for visual research proposed by Cox et al. (2014: 11), they note that "it could be distressing to researchers and audience members who are confronted with evocative imagery on sensitive topics. This can often be unexpected and unforeseen, highlighting the need for a reflexive and iterative approach to minimising harm that goes beyond the planning stages of the research." It is this kind of reflexive and iterative approach that we build on here in relation to the concept of ethical sustainability. The creative processes and products of visual research bring with them certain unpredictability, which is both valuable and challenging. This means that ethical consequences are not always predictable and planned for. The answer here is not a simple checklist of do's and don'ts. Rather, what is needed is a more nuanced approach which equips the researcher to reflexively consider possible ethical effects of the visual encounters, and puts in place resources that will ensure that researchers are supported and ethically sustained. This approach can be extended to projects using other kinds of visual materials generated in visual research methodologies. However, empirical investigation is required to ascertain if the proposed ethical framework is useful for projects involving visual materials that have contrasting agentic capacities to photographs.

In their guidelines for visual research, Cox et al. (2014: 11) also point to the ethical effects of the visual on audiences, beyond the researcher. We suggest that this is an area that remains ripe for exploration. It is

unproductive to resort to censorship and restriction in terms of audiences engaging with the products of visual research. But how to ensure that audience engagement is generative and enabling? It would be interesting to consider how the concept of ethical sustainability could be adapted to support audiences affected through engaging with the visual. We suggest this concept offers some useful possibilities and is worthy of further examination.

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PART II

Ethical Issues in Contexts

The chapters in this section discuss ethical issues that are entwined in the particular contexts in which the research takes place. Authors describe how they navigated ethical challenges that arose in projects focusing on particularly sensitive or complex settings, with participant groups who might be considered vulnerable or marginalized. These settings and groups can present complex ethical challenges for researchers, regardless of research methods that are used. Researchers must negotiate tensions between recognizing and responding to participants' individual—and possibly complex—needs as they emerge during the research, while also ensuring the research protocol follows standard procedures for ethical research. As the chapters in this section illustrate, visual methods can help to address some of these challenges but also introduce new tensions.

In Chap. 8, Gloria Puurveen, Alice Phinney, Susan Cox and Barbara Purves provide a careful analysis of their use of video for research conducted in a particularly complex environment: an aged care facility. The research used video recordings to explore the lived experiences of people with dementia and to document the activities involved in their care as they near the end of life. The authors demonstrate the sensitivity required in developing nuanced understandings of assent in order to determine the right times and places for using video cameras in this research.

Chapter 9, by Philip Waters and Sue Waite, focuses on a participant group in a different stage of life: young children attending an alternative school in England. The research used fixed cameras in the playground and 'GoPro' cameras worn by children, to explore children's experiences of

play. The authors illustrate how the cameras enabled children to take on an active role in the research but were also imbued with social and cultural values, which influenced how the children responded to and engaged with the cameras. The authors provide vivid examples to illustrate the value of images as research data and to demonstrate the need for researchers to respond carefully when encountering ethical issues that emerge in the doing of research.

In Chap. 10, Geraldine Donoghue and Evonne Miller return to the complex research setting of a residential aged care facility. The authors describe their encounters with one aged care resident, Cassie. Their interactions with Cassie illustrate a challenge that is common in this setting: maintaining boundaries around the role of the researcher. In this research, the authors gave participants cameras and used the photovoice method to explore the lived experience of aged care. Their experiences with Cassie highlight the power of images to alter the relationship between researcher and participant by providing a portal into the participant's world and creating opportunities for extended and informal communication.

Chapter 11, by Jaime Roberto Fontbona and Deborah Warr, delves into another complex setting, focusing on the use of participant-generated drawings and photographs to explore first-person accounts of suicidal behavior among young adults in Santiago, Chile. The authors provide an overview of the complex socio-political environment in which this research is set and describe how the innovative use of visual methods helped them to traverse the ethically difficult terrain of this research. They discuss the challenges of researching an emotionally painful issue, the need for strategies to care for participants during the research and the importance of protecting participants' confidentiality.

In Chap. 12, Aline Gubrium, Alice Fiddian-Green and Amy Hill describe a project that used digital storytelling methods to empower young Puerto Rican women living in an American city to explore and address their experiences of sexual health inequities. The authors discuss two key ethical issues that emerged in this project: tensions between the multiple aims that the project served, and the challenges of minimizing harm in a project that involved uncovering experiences of trauma. The authors demonstrate that these challenges require sensitivity and flexible approaches from researchers. They show that digital storytelling provides a powerful means of articulating traumatic experiences, which can be harnessed to create participatory and empowering health interventions.

The final chapter in this section describes another digital storytelling project with young people who have experienced social inequities. In Chap. 13, Fran Edmonds, Michelle Evans, Scott McQuire and Richard Chenhall describe an ethical framework that emerged from their work conducting digital storytelling workshops with groups of Aboriginal young people from southeast Australia. Reflecting on the opportunities and challenges that digital storytelling provided for these participants, the authors describe three ethical considerations that informed their work: decolonization, the participation gap (between Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal people in Australia) and the importance of learning through situated practices.

CHAPTER 8

Ethical Considerations in the Use of Video Observations in Dementia End-of-Life Care Research

Gloria Puurveen, Alice Phinney, Susan Cox, and Barbara Purves

Introduction

Over the past decade or so, video-based research in dementia care environments has increased significantly. It has been used to support the evaluation of care practices (Hammer et al. 2011; Skovdahl et al. 2003), evaluate the effects of specific interventions on the wellbeing of residents with dementia (Dassa and Amir 2014; Swall et al. 2015; van Weert et al. 2005) and inform an understanding of verbal and nonverbal expressions of people with dementia (Beck et al. 2011; Husebo et al. 2007). In this body of research, video observation enables researchers to closely attend to the individual with dementia's embodied responses to the social, sensory and material environments in which they were emplaced, thus offering a nuanced understanding of the individual's experiences.

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Given the sensitivities needed in conducting research with vulnerable populations such as those with dementia living in nursing home environments, it is somewhat surprising that procedural and emergent ethical issues related to video observations have been largely unexplored. Most typically, researchers document consent procedures such as securing consent from a resident's proxy decision maker (proxy). A few papers have discussed processes of ongoing consent, specifying if residents expressed discomfort, the camera would be turned off and/or the researcher would come back at a later time (Beck et al. 2011, 4, 8; Hammar et al. 2011, 162; Skovdahl et al. 2003, 889; van Weert et al. 2005, 314–15). Some researchers have noted the potential for staff or residents to feel uncomfortable or to change their behavior while being filmed (Engström and Hammar 2012, 223; Hammar et al. 2011, 165). With respect to issues of privacy, one study explicitly addressed the issue of filming resident participants (Skovdahl et al. 2003), while another has addressed privacy in terms of the use and retention of video data (Dassa and Amir 2014, 137). Finally, another study conducted outside the nursing home context explored issues of representation and othering (Cook 2002).

With the exception of Cook's work, which focused on emergent ethical issues in her research, the purpose of the aforementioned articles was to report on their research findings, not to unpack the ethical complexities of conducting the research. As such, the purpose of this chapter is to further the methodological conversation about the use of video in dementia care research, particularly in terms of consent and ongoing consent, privacy and the related issue of representation.

Contextualizing the Visual

This chapter draws from the first author's ethnographic case study research that explored the experiences of two residents—both women—with advanced dementia who were identified as nearing the end of life. Both women were nonverbal, immobile and completely dependent on others for assistance with all activities of daily living (e.g., dressing, toileting, eating). Family and staff who most frequently interacted with the two resident participants were also included in the study. Staff participants (n = 23) included care aides, licensed practical nurses, registered nurses, recreation and pastoral care staff and nursing home management; family participants (n = 2) comprised residents' proxy. Fieldwork included over 500 hours of participant observation, including 30 hours of video

observation, to document times when resident participants were alone, in social activities and in personal care. A small hand-held camera was used and it was either fixed to a surface or held, depending on the situation being filmed. In addition, in-depth interviews were held with staff and family, and video reflexive interviews were held with proxies and staff who consented to video observation. This study received ethics approval from the University of British Columbia's Behavioural Research Ethics Board.

Being Emplaced: Filming in Dementia Care Environments

The nursing home setting is a communal living environment purpose-built for people who are no longer able to live safely at home and need 24-hour nursing care. The physical, social and organizational dynamics of the nursing home play a central role in the individual and collective well-being of those who move in and out of the space. Thus, to understand the experiences of people with dementia and the staff who care for them, it is essential to understand that these experiences are poignantly shaped by the context within which they are emplaced.

Casey (1993) argues, "The power a place such as a mere room possesses determines not only *where* I am…but *how* I am together with others…and even *who* we shall become together" (p. 23). Conceptualizing the nursing home as being continually constituted by the people who weave in and out of its structure suggests that socio-political, cultural and historical factors must be carefully considered. Thus, the nursing home is a place that is shaped not only by the residents and staff who occupy the space but is also shaped and reshaped by the larger socio-political healthcare environment of which it is a part. Moreover, in the case of this research, it is also a place where research happens and the dynamic of place shifts with the presence of a researcher.

Researchers are called to consider the entanglement of place with who we are as individuals and as people in relationship, as this gives rise to complex ethical issues related to conducting research in the nursing home space. Inasmuch as this speaks to procedural ethics such as consent, it also highlights research praxis and ethical issues that arise in the everyday practice of conducting video observations. Thus, the issue of consent, for example, is more than a signature on the page, but encompasses ongoing consent and the negotiation of what is permissible to film in the moment.

Likewise, the issue of privacy is more than considerations of anonymity and confidentiality, but also includes filming in private spaces and in private circumstances. Finally, visual images not only represent what is explicitly on the screen, but also what is implicit—for example, guidelines and policies of both the nursing home organization and regulatory bodies. In the following discussion, we take up each of these issues in turn.

Consent and Ongoing Consent

In Canada, research governance offers guidance on the inclusion of people with advanced dementia in research, mandating the researcher to fulfill ethical obligations to the individual by involving her to participate in the decision-making process and maintaining consent from the resident's proxy decision maker (proxy) (Canadian Institutes of Health Research [CIHR] 2014). Implicit in these guidelines is that while individuals with advanced dementia may lack the legal capacity to provide consent for participation and consent is thus sought from the proxy, consent is not considered solely an a priori event, but rather an ongoing process (CIHR 2014; Dewing 2007). Dewing suggests that consent as a process includes getting to know the resident and gaining an understanding of her needs and wishes, however these are expressed, which opens the opportunity for the resident to voice her assent/dissent to participation in research.

In this research, consent was renegotiated with each video observation. The resident was shown the camera and given a simple explanation about the purpose of the research. Time was given for the resident to respond and close attention was paid to her vocal and embodied expressions. In addition, staff were consulted to clarify how the resident responded to care interactions, how she responded to new staff or someone unfamiliar, and other cues of assent/dissent to care or other interactions. The proxies were also consulted to solicit their perceptions of how the resident may have responded to a camera in the past, and of the residents' overall ease of participating in the research. If the resident showed signs of discomfort or if the staff/proxy appraised that the resident was distressed because of the research, the camera was not used at that time.

The appraisal of signs of dissent must ensure that the rights of the resident to decline participation in the research are honored. This is particularly crucial when considering residents whose embodied cues may be ambiguous. Signs of discomfort, such as a grimace or a cry, may be related to other internal/external factors, but it also may be related to being a

subject of the researchers' attention. Therefore, cultivating knowledge of the resident and discussing with the proxy and staff the possibility that filming might cause distress are imperatives to respecting her rights to participate or not. Overall, resident participants did not express dissent and seemed largely unaware of the camera's presence.

In terms of staff, initial written consent was sought and the act of filming was negotiated with individual staff participants each time the camera's gaze could be fixed on them. It was assumed that participants would have some degree of "camera-consciousness," (Pink 2013, 107) and if staff showed signs of discomfort (e.g., tension, distractibility) and it interfered with the enactment of care, the camera was turned off. However, similar to Hammar et al. (2011), this was not observed over the long term. Staff appeared comfortable with being filmed and carework did not appear to be any different than what was observed in traditional observations.

The process of securing consent and the need to keep the conversation about consent alive through the research process, and the practice of getting to know the person with dementia and monitoring her assent, are essential to cultivating a research practice based on respect and doing no harm. Moreover, consent and ongoing consent are the primary drivers of what can be filmed and what can be shared with a wider audience.

In/Outside the Frame: Considerations of Privacy

In recent decades there has been a shift in the conceptual understanding of the nursing home as modeled on the hospital setting, to the nursing home as a domestic setting reminiscent of a private home; it is coming to be viewed as a space "associated with privacy as well as being a place where people live together and establish fellowship" (Hauge and Heggen 2008, 461). Thus, how privacy is realized in private (e.g., bedroom) and communal spaces (e.g., lounge) is influenced by the interrelationships between those who live and work in the space, and the amount of power residents have to control of the space (Hauge and Heggen 2008). In the negotiation between communal and private space, issues confronting researchers using visual methods relate to: (1) the act of filming in private situations (e.g., an undressed body), (2) the practice of collecting video footage in a private yet collective living environment and (3) the practice of protecting the privacy of research participants in a structured healthcare environment.

First, issues of filming private situations are most glaring in the context of personal care routines when a resident is likely to be in various stages

of undress. However, it is not limited to personal care as the notion of privacy also relates to the degree of intrusiveness a camera's gaze has on the person's interactions with the environment around them; for example, an emotionally charged moment between individuals could be considered more private than being transferred out of bed in the morning. The potential intrusiveness of a camera in a resident's private world is not explicitly addressed in research using video observations. While Skovdahl et al. (2003) noted filming "tactfully, from the waist up" (889), in bathing situations, other researchers who filmed in communal spaces did not untangle what privacy might mean in these situations.

In our research, proxies gave consent to film social situations, times when the resident was alone and personal care encounters. However, in consideration of a nuanced understanding of privacy, this did not mean what could be filmed should be filmed. Some situations were straightforward; for example, perineal care was not filmed, as it would likely compromise the dignity of the resident. Other situations were less obvious. For example, filming intimate and tender moments between the resident and a significant other seemed to intrude upon their privacy, particularly because private moments are hard to come by amidst the busyness and clamor of nursing home life. In grappling with this dimension of privacy, adopting a reflexive approach prompted the researcher to critically scrutinize her motivation for video methods, its importance for addressing the research questions, the data generated and the relationship between herself and participants. Thus, getting to know the participants was instrumental in determining what would be appropriate to film; and subsequently showing them the footage was important to build an understanding of whether the product was acceptable. In addition, the use of the camera was guided by several questions: to what extent would video data contribute to answering the research questions that could not be answered as fully by traditional observational methods alone? In what way would participation in video observations benefit the resident—whether directly in that moment, or indirectly through the generation of new knowledge? Could the situation be filmed a different way?

Second, the practice of filming in a private home, yet a communal living environment demands consideration of whether video methods infringes on the daily lives of others in the space. While this resonates for filming in any closed environment, it is especially salient in the context of dementia care environments where some residents might not understand the reasons for a researcher to be in their home, let alone filming

in their space. In our research, this was especially difficult to navigate as not all residents and staff were involved in the research, and some were suspicious of the camera being used as a surveillance tool. Thus, it was essential to build an understanding of those who were present outside the camera's frame—not only to alleviate their suspicions but also to ensure that they were not inadvertently filmed. In reviewing footage taken in the communal spaces, it became apparent that while there may have been visual anonymity, oftentimes there was not aural anonymity. That is, the audio captured not only names but also vocal utterances of nonparticipants that could uniquely identify those individuals. While one could argue that maintaining visual anonymity of nonparticipants is sufficient for ethical practice, revealing other unique identifying features of place and people raises the question of whether privacy has indeed been compromised. In consideration of this dimension of privacy, filming, for example, did not take place when unique and identifiable sounds (e.g., repetitive vocalizations expressed by particular residents) dominated the sensory environment.

Finally, protecting the privacy of research participants in structured environments such as a nursing home was difficult to navigate as the camera's gaze was fixed on certain individuals. Nonparticipants could discern those who were participating or not. While this was anticipated and accounted for to meet the requirements of ethic review boards (i.e., participants were given assurances of confidentiality and protection of personal information), in the actual research practice, this was more challenging to realize. Being discrete and filming as unobtrusively as possible was in part impacted by limits in the physical environment (e.g., small, crowded spaces) as well as the enthusiasm of nonparticipants who were curious about the research. Like addressing other dimensions of privacy, ongoing consent was key to protecting participant's privacy in the moment. When and what could be filmed was determined with participants at the time of filming, and thus their readiness or reluctance of being in the camera's gaze was respected. Likewise, getting to know the participants, their patterns of relationships with others and their comfort level with the camera also supported their need for privacy.

This broader understanding of privacy points to the larger issue of filming in the nursing home and the extent to which filming intrudes on the privacy of those who dwell and work in this environment. In this respect, grappling with the notion of privacy took a reflexive approach and was considered in terms of the negotiation of ongoing relationships with both

research participants and nonparticipants, protecting the privacy of place and according respect to *all* those in the space. In the next section, we take up the concept of privacy as it relates to representation and sharing of images.

Representation

Anonymizing data and obscuring identifying information is a standard process in social and health research practice. However, this presents a significant dilemma for visual researchers—while there is the responsibility to protect the privacy of participants, there is also the desire to make visible a phenomenon that text alone fails to reveal (Cox et al. 2014; Pink 2013). Even when consent to share images is granted, researchers still must consider the short- and long-term implications for participants represented in the image, as well as the socio-political circumstances in which the images were produced and in which they might be viewed and interpreted (Cox et al. 2014; Pink 2013).

Video images of research participants with advanced dementia and those who care for them place participants in a vulnerable position. Cook argued that images of people with dementia that are shared with a wider community have the potential to perpetuate negative stereotypes, thus her research team employed artistic ways to recreate research findings as a way of dissemination (Cook 2002). However, it is also possible that video images can contribute to positive perceptions of dementia, aging, dying and the carework involved.

In our research, video feedback sessions were held with the residents' proxy and the care staff who were represented in the images. In these discussions, participants were asked to consider the notions of privacy and the long-term implications of images being in the public domain. Understandably, the researcher or participants cannot anticipate how various audiences could interpret the images; yet the researcher has a responsibility to consider if distress or harm could be incurred at a future point. It is thus necessary to build an understanding of benefits and risks to not only research participants but also to the broader community that images might represent (Sherratt et al. 2007).

Moreover, it is also imperative to consider the ethnographic context in which images were produced. As noted earlier, the nursing home is both a home for the resident and a place where healthcare happens. Thus,

images of carework not only reveals an individual staff's style but also shows compliance to nursing home practice guidelines, which in turn reflect adherence to the healthcare policies set by regulatory bodies (e.g., provincial legislation). For example, a segment of video data shows a carer assisting a resident with lunch. The carer is positioned very close to the resident, lightly touching her and speaking quietly to her. In reviewing the footage together, the carer informed the researcher that while her carework followed one standard of practice (person-centered mealtime assistance), it also did not align with another standard (infection control). Despite this, the carer was very pleased with how her work was represented and gave consent for the footage to be shared.

Inasmuch as the conversation revealed how two standards of practice could be at odds with each other, it also highlighted the unclear boundaries between protecting participant's privacy, how work is represented and the right course of action thereof. On one hand, sharing footage might prompt a fruitful discussion on standards of practice, and could be an empowering situation for staff who are able to give voice to tacit care practices that are difficult to describe in words. On the other hand, it is unclear whether sharing footage would cause unacceptable harm to her and her reputation as an exceptional caregiver.

In consideration of both the representation of people with advanced dementia and the carework of the staff who care for them, it is thus fruitful to explore ways to respectfully represent individuals while maintaining the fiduciary responsibility toward participants. In our research, we attempted to resolve dilemmas of representation by implementing processes of ongoing consent and showing staff and proxies video footage—inviting them to participate in the process of selecting images to share that were acceptable to them. Moreover, we considered a realist approach whereby fieldnotes, video transcripts and a description of the context were combined with the images to provide the necessary situated background in which the images were produced. Alongside, we also considered an expressive approach whereby images were subject to manipulation (e.g., blurring staff name tags) to render those in the images unidentifiable, thereby protecting their privacy. Yet, while we have received consent to share a range of footage, we have yet to fully realize what has been entrusted to us. As we look to various knowledge translation activities, how ethical issues play out over time will need to be carefully worked through.

Conclusion

The aim of this chapter was to explore ethical issues in the use of video observations of people with advanced dementia and their caregivers in nursing home settings. Grounding our understanding in the notion of emplacement, we argued that ethical practice of producing and reproducing moving images calls for careful consideration of the specific social and material contexts in which images are created. We offered an open and reflexive account that elucidated how critical issues such as informed and ongoing consent, privacy and representation were navigated. By discussing these issues and describing possible ways to respond to the issues, we hope to have contributed to the growing body of knowledge that informs visual methods in nursing home settings.

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CHAPTER 9

Toward an Ecological Approach to Ethics in Visual Research Methods with Children

Philip Waters and Sue Waite

Introduction

It is often assumed that video cameras provide an unfiltered observational record (Simpson and Tuson 2003) that is impersonal, dispassionate and distant (Sorensen and Jablonko 1995) simply because they are seen as neutral devices that can record events objectively (Craig et al. 2000; Dunn and Hughes 2001; Scott and Panksepp 2003). We argue otherwise (Waters et al. 2014) and suggest that video cameras are, in common with all research tools, extensions of ourselves. They enact our intentions, moral choices, social position and cultural biases, and are bound in the time, place and context in which they are used, leaving impressions on participants and the environment long after research projects have finished (Rose 2012).

While we respect the purpose and function of ethical research guidelines issued and monitored by research institutions, we take the stance of Andrew Clark who suggests that 'ethical decision-making in visual research should be considered with regard to epistemological approaches, specific

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research contexts, and in relation to researchers' and participants' own moral frameworks' (Clark 2012, 17–18). As such, we position this text within the concept of 'fuzzy boundaries' (Cox et al. 2014) to express the complexities of co-constructing meaning through visual media. On that basis, we focus on the deeply embedded nature of ethics within research praxis; especially the ethical considerations taken in everyday, moment by moment interactions with children as they go about playing in the natural areas of their school grounds, while wearing chest-harness cameras. We therefore adopt a line of enquiry similar to Guillemin and Gillam (2004), who locate ethics across two domains—procedural ethics and ethics in practice—and propose that ethical stances should not be considered as static, formulaic or abstract ways of approaching or practicing research. These understandings may be encouraged by current university practices that require detailed ethics approval before research begins (procedural ethics), but we argue that organic, malleable and adaptable ways of being in a research relationship with participants is more appropriate (ethics in practice).

Dialogic Imagination

To explore this we are using Bakhtin's 'dialogic imagination' (Bakhtin 1981) as reported by Brian Edmiston, who says: '…it matters little what people know about ethical principles if they cannot be wise about their lives and act ethically in the moment' (Edmiston 2008, 18). Thus, a dialogic imagination approach requires practitioners to empathize and locate themselves in the physical, social and moral experiences of others. One way that Edmiston advocates this is through play, which he suggests is a useful enabler for dialogues to be 'acted upon' rather than merely imagined. Likewise, our research utilizes play as a dialogic method that entails multiple shifts in role, from researcher to practitioner (player), from adult to child, and, as in the case of the first author, from male to female. Furthermore, we are mindful that dialogic may imply oppositional and binary ways of thinking, but we propose that dialogic imagination ought to involve not only the relationship of researcher with participants but also with the environment and research artifacts, particularly video cameras. Our approach, then, considers ethical issues and their solutions as encountered always 'in the making'; continually in a moment of flux, of being exposed, silenced, included and excluded within an ecological dialogic context.

Building an Ethical Relationship

Christensen suggests that we should 'move away from seeing power as residing in people and social positions' and instead view 'power as embedded in the process, that is, the 'doing' of research' (Christensen 2004, 166–7). In the 'doing' of our research, which involved studying children's physical behaviors as they played within the outdoor spaces of a small, off-grid school in Cornwall, UK, we equipped the environment with static Go-pro cameras that would capture children's mobility as they freely moved about their school grounds. We knew the cameras would only provide a broad view of children's ranging and would not capture moments of intimate play in small spaces or their dialogues and play narratives. In particular, the latter was crucial to our study as we were interested in the relationship between narrative and physical activity—how children's physical activity could be influenced by storied themes—and so supplemented the static cameras by issuing a small sample of participants with Go-pro cameras mounted on chest harnesses, each equipped with an external microphone.

The study was designed to ensure that the relationship between researcher and participants would be as open and friendly as possible, partly because the children were young (5–7 years) and also because the study involved developing a story-based pedagogy where the first author was both researcher and practitioner (Waters 2014a, b, 2011). In being playful, the researcher was able to present the cameras and their functions to children in an accessible manner, supported by a cartoon story-board to further explain and describe the research activity and its ethical protocols in order to obtain children's informed consent.

As expected, children performed and played to the cameras, especially the static ones located on various landscape features and play structures, by pulling funny faces and through the framing of extreme close-ups. Likewise, the chest-harness cameras provided the focal point for all manner of humorous camera engagement, including the intentional black-out by covering the lens with their hands, or by the muffling of the external microphone. We welcomed 'play with camera' as an important component in our method because it supported the conditions for negotiating power and renegotiating child-adult relations. Moreover, as Kullman points out: '…visual research extends far beyond the production and interpretation of images to all kinds of performances: running with cameras, sharing them with friends, even using the equipment as play objects' (Kullman 2012,

1–2). Children were advised, however, to remove their camera should they need the toilet, and also to hand it to a member of staff when they had tired of wearing it. The intention was that these instructions to the children would mean they retained control over what they recorded for our research. For the most part, play sessions varied between 45 and 90 minutes, and although some activities were highly physical, such as jumping from a swing onto a crash mat, children were told they did not need to restrict or adapt their play to protect the cameras. This was not easily accepted, as during some of the early sessions, children were deeply concerned about damaging them and, perhaps more significantly, concerned about what the repercussions might be. These self-imposed checks on their behavior indicated the existing habitus of the school and concerns for respect for property and safety, but also illustrated that apparent freedoms bestowed within procedural ethics materials are not unalloyed by situated cultural norms (Waite 2013).

We anticipated the cameras would prove somewhat intrusive during the first study where the context for observation was children's unadulterated free play, but we thought that in the second study, which incorporated a narrative intervention, camera intrusions would be negated. However, we did not foresee what impression the presence of the cameras left behind would create, as a conduit through which participants could consciously or unconsciously communicate with the researcher; an observation made by Frers, when he suggests cameras act as extensions of the researcher (Frers 2009).

Cameras often provided the context for children to engage with the researcher directly. For example, on one occasion, the researcher was approached by two girls who excitedly told him a small boy's trousers had fallen down exposing his 'willy', which was allegedly caught on camera. After following ethical procedures and informing the teaching staff and the boy's parents, and proposing to delete the section of film, it turned out the boy's 'willy' was, in fact, safe from video exposure. However, the incident had a variety of implications. It highlighted the complexity of this research situation as a nexus of activity between camera, researcher and participants, where the boy as the subject of the girls' narratives, and the actual content and context of the film itself (the boy's trousers falling down) were not immediately verifiable because the film was only watched at the point of analysis. Yet, the cameras have an immediate ethical position to play in research activities and research relationships and could act as a tool of power for the children. Henley contextualizes this rather well

when he says the camera has the potential to act like 'a catalyst, provoking events, situations and relationships that are revealing precisely because of their atypicality' (Henley 1998, 37).

In the context of our research at a school that is completely off-grid, cameras were atypical. Their use hinged on them being quickly accommodated by children. In setting up the static cameras, a playful game emerged among children to see who could find them first, although, unlike 'Treasure hunt', the game only lasted a few sessions as the cameras were always located in exactly the same place. And likewise, each of the children who wore the chest harness cameras, which all had a unique ID number, developed a form of attachment for them, as the participants would insist on wearing the same camera from the previous session. Cameras had become familiar and accepted. Only when the research was well underway, we became mindful that these subtle quirks, no matter how small or apparently insignificant, helped provide for a playful relationship (Waters et al. 2014).

It is not surprising to find video in child-based studies located in the 'creative methods' categories in research methods texts, partly because the medium enables participants to become collaborators in the construction of their own films (MacDougall 2011), but also because film provides a method that connects many of the senses (Pink 2009) that work effectively in facilitating 'knowledge production' rather than 'knowledge gathering' (Veale 2005, 254). The danger here, as Lomax warns, is that '…children participate in and engage with creative methods differently and unequally and in ways which provide a challenge to the assumptions in some childhood literatures that creative methods sidestep verbal competency' (Lomax 2012, 114). This is further supported by the Gallaghers, who suggest that '…there are implicit assumptions in child-friendly methodologies that children are best placed to interpret their own experiences, and that epistemology of this kind assumes that people are transparently knowable to themselves, and privileges their 'voices' as the most authentic source of knowledge about themselves and their lives' (Gallagher and Gallagher 2008, 502). While there is no scope to explore this here, we would suggest, as Coady reminds us, that 'Children are [a social group that are still] heavily represented among victims of research' (Coady 2001, 64), and thus whatever the methodology, the importance of children's engagement in research about their own lives is both crucial and morally appropriate.

Ethical Dilemmas

Engaging children in visual methods in ethically suitable ways begins very early in a research project, and in our case, began when we first ethnographically entered the field, predicted as far as possible by our careful procedural ethical preparation and approvals before embarking on research. To begin with, we recognized that we were effectively strangers to the children, staff, parents and school environment and its values, practices and orthodoxies, and that we needed to be mindful of our own presence and effect, and of the influence of the cameras and the varied research performances that amounted from using them. Moreover, we recognized that research praxis, whether framed by an institution's ethical principles or through years of research experience, can be contested by participants as they collaborate in research activities. So taking a lead from scholars like Stuart Aitken, our approach to ethical praxis was to shift from seeing children as 'other' and not become embroiled in a state of research 'paralysis' while trying to figure out differences between children and adults (Aitken 2001).

For example, in a 'restorying' activity, each participant was presented with a selection of film taken from their own chest-harness camera. One girl, on watching a scene where she suggests the kidnap and 'murder' of another child at the setting, got up from her seat and closed the door because she didn't want other school staff hearing about the content of her play. The researcher was placed in the position of following 'safeguarding' procedures and insisting the door remain open so that 'child and adult' were not alone and were in full view of passing staff or respecting the child's wish for privacy, which had also been promised in the ethical documents. He recognized that she had trusted him to view the films with her, without judgment, and that his relationship with her had been built on an agreement about confidentiality. Here was a conflict between ethical procedures (protecting the researcher) and ethical praxis (respecting the child). In fact, the 'restorying' activity was also being filmed to capture a reflection on her play but also incidentally provided visual evidence of probity. So the child's rights to privacy were favored and the integrity of the research/participant relationship sustained. Ethical dilemmas like this bring to the fore the conflict between protection rights and participation rights as perpetuated in international treaties like the 1989 UN Convention on the Rights of the Child. Alderson and Morrow (2011) suggest that one solution to working with these tensions is to adopt a

risk-benefit approach, where researchers weigh the benefits of adherence to some rights against the risk of exclusion of others. Clearly these sorts of balances in judgment can often only be made in the moment, hence the need for perpetual engagement with an ethical stance.

Although our methodology was largely visual ethnography, our methods framework adopted a variety of techniques akin to the Mosaic approach promoted by Clark and Moss (2005), which is a suite of creative methods where no one method dominates, but where all methods collaboratively contribute to meaning-making. The method is considered a good approach in child-centered research with young children, particularly, as in our research, when applied within an ecological research context that accepts knowledge construction as happening in sites of practice; in the 'doing' of research where participants, practitioners, researchers, environment and research artifacts combine, and where time and place constitute ways of 'knowing' (Nicolini 2010). Sites of practice in our research were framed within Rose's (2012) sites of production, image and audiencing, through which we could explore and contextualize the myriad of ways that children, researchers and the environment ethically coalesce through visual media. Production, in our research, is the setting up of cameras; 'image' is the analysis of the visual data, while 'audiencing' is the showing or performing of the visual media to others (Waters et al. 2014).

While not typical of behavioral research, our behavioral coding was intended to be responsive and adaptable, to tell a story and not merely classify behavior as fixed, static modes of being. However, what we were less prepared for was our own shift in perspective from researcher to child when watching films from the first-person cameras. The static, landscape, third-person cameras represented what is a typical viewpoint in observational research: observer of 'others'. It was outside, apart and looking on. First-person cameras shift the viewpoint so that we see the world through the child's eyes. It is a shift that both privileges and complicates the researcher's role, and one that situates ethics within a relational context beyond the practical and strategic conditions of institutional ethic procedures.

For example, during a coding session, the first author viewed a scene of a girl attentively patching up a tree that had lost parts of its bark. As the 'story' unfolds her play takes on a fairy tale theme that is ecologically sensitive. When coding, the researcher is affected emotionally, and through his emotions is drawn into the story to be submerged beneath the practicalities of behavioral coding. When the sequence is shown to the other author,

she too is emotively drawn into the tale. And later, when the film is shown to an audience at a conference about nature-based play, many in the audience are also captured by the narrative, particularly as for them it affirmed their belief that nature-based experiences are beneficial for children's health and well-being and for the future 'health' of the planet.[1]

In this example ethical considerations shift beyond the standard procedures advocated by research institutions and play themselves out through various sites of visual activity. From the site of production, a child plays at patching up a tree. From the site of the image, her behaviors are coded and her 'story' has an emotional effect on the first researcher, who then shows her film to the other author, before then showing the film at conferences to illustrate children's nature-connectedness. The value of the film sequence as a 'good' story for promoting environmental education accords ethically that research ought to help change the world by informing people's practices. In this context, film positions the child's voice, actions and 'story' within the public domain in accordance with informed consent. However, is the voice truly of the child? Or is it merely the voice of the first author, or the second author, or even the conference audience? It is, of course, all of these. But as researchers we have the overarching responsibility of balancing ethical care, praxis and stances to serve all voices within research, but particularly children.

Conclusion

In conclusion we return to Edmiston's approach of adopting play as an 'ethical pedagogy' for the 'co-authoring of ethical selves and identities' (Edmiston 2008, 173). In praxis terms, our translation of his work effectively meant we had 'tuned' into children's ways of being in the world through play and visual methods. Becoming insiders in a sense granted us privileged positions through which we could observe behaviors and co-construct meaning. Our use of video was more than a tool devoid of influence or neutral in its perspective. It was an object of play, a collaborator, even conspirator. It was part of a nexus of story-makers and tellers situated and contested within the context of visual method ecology. Ethical considerations within this ecology can only partially be governed by institutional principles. The procedural materials are ultimately only provisional advisory guidelines, and are certainly important to inform research praxis by surfacing 'what –ifs' and considerations that would be difficult to weigh in the heat of the moment. But we must recognize that, like practitioners,

children have their own ethical selves and are situated in an environmental context, in this case, an off-grid school with a culture that includes many distinctive ethical principles. Cameras too, through the traditional, social, cultural and embodied ways in which we engage with them, elicit an ethical response. One need not search the tabloids for long before finding examples of children's school images being defaced with markers so as to protect anonymity, or stories of the exclusion of video at school plays and sporting events. Yet, cameras and their presence in our everyday lives have a major role to play in the construction of societal values and, in this sense, shape wider ethical principles and practices.

We propose that research with children ought to adopt a relational and ecological approach that takes as a starting point the ethical frameworks of research institutions, but keeps them live and flexible in practice to respond to the ethical identities of research participants and the environment. We suggest that such flexibility can be achieved through a playful approach that situates researcher, participants, environment and visual methods in a state of continual dialogue where ethics can be challenged and contested by all parties with reference to the agreed protocols. Clearly major departures or challenges need to be referred back to ethical committees to ensure due probity, but researchers adopting and applying playful ways of engaging children in research and reimagining ethical stances will steer us toward a more responsive ecological approach to ethics in visual methods research with children.

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Note

1. The film 'Annie and the Tree' can be viewed at: https://vimeo.com/88200898.

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CHAPTER 10

'I Understand. I Am a Participant': Navigating the 'Fuzzy' Boundaries of Visual Methods in Qualitative Longitudinal Research

Geraldine Donoghue and Evonne Miller

Introduction

> 2:00pm Arrived to collect Cassie's photographs capturing her life in aged care. Planned 15 minutes but Cassie asked if she could share some photos of her life 'before'. We sat together, as she looked at old photographs and told me about her two daughters she no longer sees. There seemed to be years of tension, escalated after the workplace death of one grandchild. Cassie was still clearly distressed by the loss and explained that one daughter does not talk to her because '*I told her it was her fault. I told her she should have told my grandson about the other job. And I told her that it should have been her instead* (diverts her eyes). *Now only one of them* (her children) *will talk to me…*' [Field notes, GD, August 2014, finish 3:00pm].

This extract, from the first author's field notes, documents discussions during a visit to collect a research camera and one participant's photographs (Cassie, a pseudonym for an 81-year-old aged care resident). The notes illustrate how a planned 15-minute visit escalated into a 1-hour

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intimate discussion about sadness and loss as Cassie is finally ready to discuss a significant aspect of her life: that she is no longer in contact with two of her children, after she blamed one for the death of a grandchild. What is thought provoking is not just the story and regret that Cassie shared, but also the ethical and methodological implications as participatory visual methodologies unexpectedly change and challenge the participant/researcher relationship. Drawing on data from our ongoing qualitative longitudinal research (QLR) exploring the lived experience of aged care from the perspective of older residents, their families and service providers in one Australian residential aged care facility, this chapter explores how the decision to utilize participatory visual methodologies has raised several 'fuzzy boundary' dilemmas (Gilbert 2001; Cox et al. 2014).

In our ongoing 'Inside Aged Care' project, we have repeatedly engaged with aged care residents (n = 20) since 2012, through multiple in-depth interviews, focus groups, observation, poetry workshops and photovoice (see Miller et al. 2015, for a project overview). Through these layered activities, we have been privileged to become 'outsider' participants in the day-to-day life in aged care. However, the use of visual methods in a QLR project situated in aged care has raised several ethical dilemmas that have challenged the traditional understanding of the researcher-participant relationship and our own ethical positioning as 'suitably dispassionate… and at the same time genuinely empathetic' (Foster et al. 2005, 10). To illustrate these challenges, this chapter focuses on interactions with one participant: 81-year-old Cassie, who at the time of first interview in 2013, had lived in aged care for one year.

Research Context and Setting: The Unique Visibility of Aged Care

Before outlining how visual methods in QLR have facilitated ethical reflection and rigor, it is important to understand our unique research context and methods. Within gerontological research, the use of QLR and participant-generated visual methodologies such as photographs, video, drawings, maps or artwork remains relatively rare. The participatory action research methodology of photovoice, simply defined as giving participants' cameras and asking them to photograph specific issues (Wang and Burris 1997), has rarely been used in aging (see; Rush et al. 2012; Novek et al. 2012; Annear et al. 2014), and literature searches showed only one study in an aged care context (Lewinson et al. 2012). The relative rarity of visual

methods in gerontological research reflects the fact that, traditionally, social science research has privileged methods that draw on numbers and words, seldom venturing 'beyond text' to explore the possibility of visual, image-based methodologies. In the last two decades, however, a growing body of disciplines, led by researchers in anthropology, cultural studies, sociology, education, health and communications, have demonstrated the creative, analytical and communicative potential of visual methods (see, e.g., Miller and Happell 2006; Genoe and Dupuis 2013; Nash 2014). At a theoretical level, visual methods provide a unique contextual lens that enhances insight, understanding and interpretation (Guillemin 2004). At a practical level, the creativity of visual methods helps engage participants with the research and has an evocative power that aids communication to a wider audience.

Our research has utilized three iterations of photovoice to visually capture highlights, lowlights, two weeks and a day in a resident's life. Depending on photovoice task iteration, participant capacity and engagement, residents engaged in workshops and/or were individually interviewed (up to four times) over approximately 18 months about their photographs, with an exhibition scheduled for 2016. What we did not fully anticipate was the intersection between method and place; the process and logistics of visual methods in the communal context of aged care made both researchers and participants highly visible. Residents displayed a keen awareness of the coming and going of other residents and visitors; the delivery and use of cameras thus became a talking point, increasing the frequency of contact between the main researcher, staff and residents (creating an additional 5–10 unscheduled interactions per participant). While this was highly valuable in terms of data immersion and building rapport, it also 'fuzzied' the relationship between the researcher and those being researched. For some residents who were isolated and seeking companionship, the researcher became a special friend: as one noted, 'You make me laugh, Geraldine. When are you next coming in?' (GD field notes, February 2015).

While the ethical challenges associated with maintaining appropriate participant/researcher relationships in ethnographic and social science research is not a new issue, the camera that is integral to the photovoice method became a continual 'connector' to the researcher. That is, the process of participatory photographic methods (where the participant becomes, in effect, the researcher) enabled participants to use the camera as a means of lengthening contact and as a tool to shape the conversation.

As highlighted by the quote at the beginning, the camera took on a distinct agency, acting as a non-threatening 'portal' that provided informal opportunities to deepen the conversation and enable unplanned participant revelation of sensitive and emotionally laden topics including loneliness, loss, death and family conflict.

Maintaining That Delicate Balance From Developing Rapport to Relationships

Other qualitative researchers have also identified the challenges of boundary setting (see Dickson-Swift et al. 2006, 2007; Gilbert 2001) and how, by using ourselves as the research instrument, we must experience the research 'both intellectually and emotionally' (Gilbert 2001, 9). As qualitative researchers, being empathetic and developing positive rapport is an integral aspect of the job description, yet the 'intimacy of intensive interviewing… is often more problematic and arduous' than many researchers wish to acknowledge (Charmaz 2004, 979). Despite ethics committees emphasizing the importance of 'emotional detachment and neutrality', close relationships can develop when there is ongoing contact between participants and researchers, who may become deeply involved in their participants' lives (Bellas 1999, 104). In reflecting on her practice, Charmaz (2002, 2004) argues that true respect may mean temporarily abandoning the researcher role. She describes how her ongoing participant interactions have included attending weddings and funerals and laments that 'our allegiance to social science ethics, however uncertain and ambivalent, can take precedence over human relationships and caring. And that may be the greatest ethical error' (2002, 323). What might aid ethical practice and decision making, as Duncan et al. (2009) argue, is a more transparent identification, discussion and reflection on how qualitative social researchers manage emergent, often unanticipated ethical dilemmas. Thus, drawing on our research in aged care, we explore three unforeseen 'fuzzy boundary' interactions with one participant, Cassie.

The Case of Cassie

The case presented is drawn from interviews and field notes compiled by GD, a sociologist and research fellow, as well as conversations with the project chief investigator (EM), an environmental psychologist. We have disguised key identifying features to protect Cassie's confidentiality. Like

Guillemin and Gillam (2006) and Duncan et al. (2009), we outline our interaction with Cassie in the first person to provide an intimate account of how boundaries are continually renegotiated. We found that the introduction of the camera and the sharing of photographs helped to build participant/researcher intimacy with several participants disclosing unexpected intimate revelations and insights. However, our interactions with Cassie were especially interesting as they demonstrated how the camera became a tool relied on for extended contact and interaction with the researcher. Importantly, the case of Cassie also reveals how researchers who employ visual methods need to be ethically aware of how place can impact on the confidentiality of participants.

GD first met Cassie in 2013 in a communal (but private) lounge room to interview her about what she 'did and didn't like about life in aged care'. Cassie was bright eyed with a determined voice and explained that she did not want to be audio-recorded during the interview: 'I will not talk with that thing on' (GD field notes, June, 2013). She gave a frank and at times humorous account of what she did and did not like about living in aged care: 'I like some of the staff, but the food is often terrible....they don't even bother to tell you when someone dies....a man burps at the table!' As the project moved on, I saw Cassie approximately every month; we would wave and exchange pleasantries about the weather, how she was or what I had planned ('another interview today, Cassie'). I enjoyed seeing Cassie but noted that staff and other residents characterized her as challenging or negative; another participant described her as 'a lady who was mean to me' and staff classified her as 'our bad feedback resident'. Despite Cassie's often curt manner, I enjoy her company: she is articulate and brash and freely shares her opinions.

Example 1: Visual Methodologies Increased the Visibility—of Researcher and Participant

By the time I had arranged my second and final formal interview with Cassie (July 2014), I had already seen her five times in addition to the first interview, although often for just a minute or two. Unlike the first interview, Cassie agreed to be audio-recorded and invited me into her room to conduct the interview. When I explained this interview would be our last, she asked why some other residents had been given cameras to take photographs. I reminded her that in the pilot project that she was part of (which was now ceasing), participants had not been given the sole use of a camera due to budgetary restraints; in this first iteration of photovoice,

staff had helped residents take photographs on a central facility-owned camera. I explained that this would be different for participants who were joining our larger study; as we had secured external funding, they would be loaned a personal camera. Cassie was not eligible, as she did not meet a key criterion: participants must not have lived in aged care for more than 12 months. She glumly responded 'those residents are lucky'. Although our research relationship was supposed to cease, I reached into my bag and offered Cassie a camera. This was a relatively simple and easy decision: I responded to Cassie's evident interest. On reflection, I can see I was also responding to Cassie's desire to feel included and valued, two areas of life she felt she had lost since moving into aged care. In offering the camera to Cassie, I was extending, rather than ceasing our research relationship; this was despite knowing that she did not fit within the participation parameters of the second research project. Importantly, Cassie's knowledge that other participants were able to independently use a camera and her sense that she was 'missing out', hinted at the challenges of conducting photovoice in a communal setting. It provided the first indication that other residents were actively watching and judging the research process, their own role and the photographic tasks their fellow co-residents were engaged with. This was an unexpected consequence of the communal setting, where all visits and behaviors were uniquely public.

Example 2: Visual Methodologies Changed and Deepened the Conversation

Two weeks later, I returned to discuss Cassie's photographs. Cassie had taken 17 images, ranging from her favorite coffee cup through to plants on her patio. After talking through the photographs on the project camera, she asked if I would like to see some photographs of 'my life before' aged care (GD field notes, August 2014). Perched on the end of her bed, Cassie slowly showed me through her various picture folders on her laptop; in sharing these visual memories, Cassie invited me into her life as she had lived and remembered it. She had lived most of her life in South Australia (SA), in a comfortable flat she shared with her beloved cat, Ginger. She had been an avid amateur photographer and for the first time, looking at her life in photographs, she finally opened up about her troubled relationship and eventual estrangement from all but one of her three children. She described her life as becoming increasingly small after the relationship breakdown with her family and how, when her only daughter who was still in contact with her announced she was moving to Queensland, Cassie

felt she had no option but to follow. Cassie showed me many pictures of Ginger, her past garden and the grandchildren she no longer sees.

At the end of our conversation, Cassie asked if she could keep the camera. I agreed; the camera had already become almost a 'portal' into her world; a mechanism that opened up a deeper and richer conversation about Cassie's life experience but also fuzzying the space between researcher and participant as Cassie sought to lengthen her connection with me. Rather than the one minute 'hello in the hall' (the case prior to loaning the project camera), she started to contact me in person on-site and via text message to examine more photographs she had taken. I often spent 20 minutes at a time talking over her photographs, concerns and thoughts on life. I noticed too that I was increasingly enjoying our interactions and would always try to fit in a visit with her. As Example 3 illustrates, I was no longer just the researcher but was becoming a friend.

Example 3: Recognizing and Setting Boundaries—The Taxi

In early October 2014, I visited Cassie again. She was very pleased to see me; we talked about the challenges she was having with her foot and that she finally had an appointment time for surgery. She was feeling anxious about the surgery and the recovery logistics; she could organize a lift *to* but not *from* the hospital. She was concerned the hospital would not let her catch a cab back home without a carer, a cost she could not afford. As I live close to the hospital, I offered to pick her up. Her whole face lit up: 'oh thank you, it's so good to know'. She said she would text me with her discharge time.

As I was walking back to the car, I realized I had likely overstepped the researcher/participant mark. I phoned EM for advice—had I gone too far and how should I best correct this? She thought it was a nice offer but agreed it was not appropriate. If I offered Cassie a lift home, what message was this sending to her? Would Cassie then feel beholden to us, to change her behaviors to be a 'good participant'? I called Cassie to explain why I could not help; I needed to maintain an appropriate distance as a researcher but sometimes this can feel a little blurred due to frequent contact and the intimate glimpse into her past and present world through the photographic task. I found myself apologizing for it: 'I'm so sorry', I said. There was silence and then she said: 'please don't worry, pet. I understand, I am a participant. It's fine…Tell your supervisor I understand'. I thanked her and wished her well for her surgery. Approximately a month later, when I went to collect her last lot of photographs, I asked how the

surgery went and how she got home. She showed me the photograph she had taken for me, of her foot dressed in ribbons and laughed as she explained that she got a lift from 'one of the nice staff members, on her way into work. I don't think she was supposed to, but people always do little things they shouldn't'.

Conclusion: Unpacking the 'Fuzzy Boundaries'

In summing up, by unpacking the case of Cassie, this chapter has illustrated how introducing cameras into a communal research setting, altered the researcher/participant dynamics and created unforeseen ethical challenges. While ethical mindfulness around participant/researcher relationships is a consideration in most qualitative research, we were unprepared for how a camera might open the opportunity for lengthened, extended and participant-directed contact with the researcher. We have endeavored to unpack those 'fuzzy boundaries' that challenge us 'in the grey moments of research fieldwork when we find ourselves uncomfortable and without appropriate guidance or precedent' (Duncan et al. 2009, 1698). At all times, we have endeavored to put the emotional wellbeing of the participant first. In our original application to our university ethics committee, we did not fully appreciate or consider how bringing a camera into a communal aged care setting might change the dynamics and enable the development of extremely intimate relationships and disclosures.

The desire of some participants to form close bonds with us as researchers was stronger than we had anticipated and we had not planned for issues of whether to extend research participation beyond arbitrary deadlines or to collect a participant from the hospital. Some researchers (e.g., Charmaz 2002, 2004) may have offered the lift; we chose not to. On reflection, given the uniquely visible and communal aspects of our research context, the decision not to give Cassie a lift avoided the very real risk of other participants feeling less valued; this point highlights the role place can play in participant participation and confidentiality. While there are private spaces in aged care, much of the daily lives of residents are lived in communal spaces where the arrivals, activities and departures of others are highly visible. We were unprepared for the extent to which shared spatiality might impact on participant visibility, with the case of Cassie highlighting how informal

surveillance meant she was aware (and jealous) of fellow co-residents who now had their own research camera.

Formal ethical guidelines focus on doing no harm, identifying risks and benefits, and awareness of power relationships and vulnerability; although the process is designed to enable ethical reflection and mindfulness, the paperwork is often viewed as a 'tick and flick' exercise (Bowtell et al. 2013). Fortunately, there is increasing acknowledgment and open discussion of the 'fuzzy boundaries' and ethical decision-making challenges facing qualitative social researchers, especially those utilizing visual methods in ethnographic, participatory and longitudinal projects (Gubrium et al. 2014; Cox et al. 2014). In the months since Cassie's surgery, frequency of contact between her and GD has reduced, although Cassie has resisted returning the camera. As in all research, where the aim is to do no harm, we have left the camera with her and continue to return to collect images as she requests, every few months.

Mitchell (2011) makes the point that in relation to ethical thoughtfulness, becoming more self-aware and reflexive through critical reflection is essential for deepening respect and ethical understanding of how visual research methods intersect with participants. We build on this point in this chapter in raising two important lessons for qualitative researchers engaging in visual methods. Firstly, it attests to the importance of having open and trusting communication between research team members, particularly more junior and senior researchers. By feeling supported to freely communicate concerns as they arose, we were able to jointly recognize and reflect on the changes in researcher boundaries and to respond in an appropriately considered way (see also Botwell et al. 2013 for how a trainee researcher dealt with the death of participants). Secondly, it demonstrates the value of field notes and reflexive writing, not just as a methodological tool, but also as a valuable component of the ethical process. It was through the writing and sharing of research social interactions that we were able to see the value and the ethical risks of changing researcher/participant engagement as more frequent and intense dialogue emerged from the participatory photographic process. This communication enabled us to have important conversations: with ourselves, with each other and most importantly, with our participants. Cassie's story has highlighted how the logistical mechanics of using, delivering and sharing project cameras and photographs enabled multiple informal interactions and the development of close, trusting relationships with older aged care residents. GD and Cassie developed a special bond, moving beyond a traditional researcher

relationship; as Shaw (2008, 408) acutely notes, the reality is that when researchers 'encourage people to tell their stories, we become characters in those stories, and thus change those stories'.

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CHAPTER 11

Using Visual Research Methods to Explore First-Person Accounts of Suicide Behavior

Jaime Roberto Fontbona Torres and Deborah Warr

Introduction: Socio-political Contexts for Suicide Trends in Chile

Suicide is an alarming public health issue in Chile. Between 1999 and 2007, suicide rates increased by 60 % among young people aged 15–24 years (Ministerio de Salud 2011, 19). Among adolescents aged 15–19, the rates increased by 82 % during over this period (from 6.1 suicides per 100,000 of the population in 1999 to 11.1 in 2008) (OECD 2014, 3), with rates among young adults aged between 20 and 29 years peaking in 2009 at 18.7 per 100,000 (Ministerio de Salud 2013, 20). Cultural and societal factors are emerging as significant contexts for understanding the alarming rise in suicide among young adults (Niner et al. 2009, 46), including their interactions with individual-level risk circumstances. While currently much research on suicide draws on biomedical explanatory frameworks, there are growing calls to conduct qualitative studies that explore first-person biographical accounts of suicidal behavior. These calls recognize the limitations of using quantitative methods to generate in-depth insights

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at the intersection of biography and socio-cultural contexts (Bertolote et al. 2010; Hjelmeland et al. 2000). It is also anticipated that qualitative data can usefully inform prevention efforts (Hjelmeland and Knizek 2010; Hjelmeland 2011, 63).

Chile's recent history contributes a critical socio-historical context for understanding rising rates of suicide among young people. After overthrowing the left wing Allende government in a bloody *coup d'état* in 1973, the country was ruled until 1990 by a brutal military *junta* headed by General Augusto Pinochet. The *junta* had close ties with the USA that were cemented through the influence of a group of Chilean free market economists who had studied under Milton Friedman at the University of Chicago. Pinochet's dictatorship was viewed as an opportunity to put neoliberal economic theories to the test in a real world setting. A radical agenda of economic reforms, blithely described as 'shock therapy', was implemented and included wide-scale economic deregulation and massive privatization of services, including the social security system (Harvey 2005, 7–9; Han 2012, 8–12). This economic program had devastating personal and social impacts and was enforced and managed by horrific state violence in which hundreds of thousands of citizens were arrested, imprisoned, 'disappeared' and murdered. Spiraling inflation in the early 1980s prompted further savage spending cuts to social and health services with consequent increases in infectious diseases and mental health maladies.

This turbulent history has had profound generational effects. The period of military rule produced marked discontinuity in the experiences of older and younger citizens. Among the older generations, many mourn the loss of commitment to collective life and political projects that pursued notions of social justice (Han 2012, 3–11). Younger generations who have grown up following the upheaval of the Pinochet years find it difficult to relate to the collective values espoused by older generations. At the same time, ongoing economic uncertainty undermines the ways in which young people are able to establish a sense of security and confidence in contemporary conditions. Estranged from believing in the potential of collective action, and growing up in an era that promotes rampant individualism, young people are particularly prone to experiencing the difficulties they encounter in establishing their adult lives as arising through personal deficiencies. The concept of 'social suffering', originally coined by Kleinman (1997), is helpful for understanding the contemporary psychosocial effects of Chile's history. Social suffering is a response to events,

such as war, famine, disease and mass torture, which produces collective experiences of socio-cultural and psychological distress. The concept suggests the ways in which political and social conditions interact with personal vulnerability to produce experiences of individual suffering, while cultural meanings and social dynamics play a moderating role (Wilkinson 2012). We wanted to explore if experiences of social suffering were significant for understanding the troubling phenomena of rising suicide rates among young Chileans.

New Approaches for Research into Suicide

The field of suicidology is dominated by quantitative studies and there is limited capacity to explore the links between socio-historical factors, individual biographies and suicidal behavior. Qualitative methods are well suited for exploring the social contexts of people's lives, including the complex and overlapping issues that influence meaning and behavior and how political and socio-cultural contexts are subjectively experienced and interpreted (Marsch 2015). These contexts are critical to understand because major international studies conducted by the World Health Organization have revealed significant differences across nations in the rates and practices of suicidal behavior (Bertolote et al. 2010; Hjelmeland et al. 2002). Political, social and cultural contexts within nations are similarly important for understanding intra-national differences within populations. Qualitative studies, however, have their own limitations when relying on information provided by relatives and friends of deceased individuals. In countries such as Chile, suicide remains a highly sensitive and even stigmatized subject that can be difficult to explore with grieving families who may only have partial insights into people's states of mind preceding suicide.

The experiences of individuals who have made suicide attempts offer potentially valuable first-person accounts of suicide trajectories, although there may be important differences between these circumstances and cases of completed suicide. In our study, we aimed to explore the intermingling of biographical and socio-historical factors for understanding why young adults were conceiving suicide as a solution to the difficulties they are experiencing. We were therefore concerned to use a methodological approach that offered the young participants opportunities to reconstruct and reflect on their life histories while bringing socio-political and cultural contexts within interpretative frameworks.

These closely related aims led us to use visual methods because they offered open-ended, non-threatening and emotionally supportive strategies for exploring first-person accounts of a sensitive and complex experience. Specifically, we used drawing and photographic activities, in combination with visual elicitation techniques. Visual methods, which have only relatively recently appeared in the methodological toolbox for social research, have a longer history of being used for anthropological research and therapeutic purposes in mental health settings (Wang et al. 1996; Virshup 1976). In these settings, visual methods are being adapted for research involving vulnerable participants. Researchers observe that they are helpful when participants are asked to reflect on and discuss emotionally complex topics that may otherwise be difficult to verbalize (Drew et al. 2010; McLean 2005). Visual methods are also considered particularly appropriate for engaging young people in research.

Methodological and Ethical Considerations in Exploring First-Person Accounts of Suicide

We consider three sets of interconnected methodological and ethical issues that are critical to the study. First, there are well-grounded concerns that exploring first-person accounts of suicide may be sufficiently unsettling as to lead to risks of reattempting suicide. It is therefore an ethical imperative to have a strong justification for such studies to be conducted. If these studies can be justified, this leads to the second issue we discuss which concerns the procedures we developed for recruiting participants into the study and caring for them during their involvement. The method was designed so that participants attended two interview sessions and collected visual data in between these sessions; their involvement in the study extended over a period of two to four weeks. The third set of ethical issues we discuss concerns strategies that were developed to protect participants' confidentiality and privacy, particularly as they were generating forms of visual data in which it may be possible for them to be recognized in a number of ways. Finally, we make some general comments about the processes for generating visual data and our reflections on whether these strategies for minimizing harm to participants were effective. Before discussing these issues in detail, we provide an overview of the method for the research.

The Methods for Data Collection

The study was conducted in collaboration with a major public hospital in Santiago and the researchers worked in close consultation with medical and allied health professionals. In consultation with the Chief of Psychiatry Services and a psychologist, a detailed protocol was developed that included the existing referral pathways for patients presenting at the emergency room (ER) following a suicide attempt (Cardenas et al. 2012). Potential participants were patients who were referred for outpatient treatment following a short stay in the ER to stabilize their condition. Once discharged from the ER, patients without consciousness impairments or imminent risk of reattempting suicide are usually referred to the Unit of Affective Disorders (UAD) for outpatient treatment and follow-up. Outpatients have sessions with a psychologist one or two times a week, and will see a psychiatrist weekly for the first month, with follow up according to case needs. During this time, outpatients are also likely to be accessing a range of other services, including family therapy, occupational therapy, social workers and a partial hospitalization program. Outpatients with cognitive impairments or impeded capacity to give informed consent, who displayed psychotic symptomatology and schizophrenia, were emotionally unstable, had current suicidal ideation or who showed no improvement since being admitted into the hospital were not considered for recruitment into the study.

Potential participants were approached with information about the study after they had been receiving treatment for at least four weeks following admission to the UAD and no later than 6 months. The timing for recruitment was carefully planned to avoid known periods of increased vulnerability for reattempting suicide that occur in the weeks following a suicide attempt and following discharge as outpatients, and before therapeutic relationships with counselors are established (Choi et al. 2012; De Leo and Sveticic 2010). This meant that potential participants would be continuing to receive outpatient treatment and support during their involvement in the study. Potential participants were also assessed by their treating psychologist to ensure that they were making satisfactory progress, achieving levels of emotional stability, and that participation in the study was not likely to have foreseeable negative impacts.

If patients met these criteria, the psychologist provided them with information about the study and explained that they would need to contact one of the researchers directly if they were interested to learn more. If

participants agreed to be in the study, interview sessions were conducted at the hospital and all participants were able to debrief with the psychologist afterward. The researcher remained with participants until the psychologist was available. Procedures for concluding participants' involvement were also developed. These included offering participants a final opportunity to reconsider their involvement and withdraw their data. These issues were discussed with participants during an outpatient session a few weeks after the research interviews were concluded, where they received a letter of thanks and copies of their visual data in sealed envelopes. The package also included a letter that participants could forward to the researcher requesting that they be withdrawn from the study and their data deleted from the files.

Participation involved attending two interview sessions and taking a series of photographs. In the first session, participants were asked to draw social network maps and timelines marking out key life events including the suicide attempt(s). In preparation for the second interview session, participants were asked to identify, in the timelines and social network maps, events, memories or relationships to be explored in the photographic task. Guidelines for this task were discussed at the end of the first session. The photographic activity involved taking no more than 20 photographs that might help the researchers understand events noted on the timelines and maps that the participants had created in the first interview session. The images could capture day to day worlds, situations or feelings that are associated with important experiences in their life histories, times when they had felt suicidal, and things that represented their hopes for the future. In the second interview session, photo elicitation techniques were used to explore how the images that were generated related to aspects of participants' timelines. The two interview sessions were audio recorded and transcribed and generated rich textual and visual data.

Ten participants were recruited into the study and attended at least one session. Eight completed a second interview session, and six participants completed the photographic task. Notably, although the researcher conducting the fieldwork was male (JRF), all of the participants were female (aged between 18 and 27 years). Only one young male matching the inclusion criteria was identified at the hospital, but did not finish the recruitment process. The women were all single and not employed when recruited into the study, although two were currently studying at tertiary education institutions. Three of the participants were mothers of young children. Most of the participants expressed satisfaction in having

participated in the study, and the psychologist in the UAD who assisted in recruiting and supporting participants during their involvement in the study is not aware of any ill effects among the young women following their research participation.

The timelines produced by the participants revealed that the recent suicide attempts were the culmination of accumulating personal crises. Some participants had histories of abuse and emotional trauma, long-standing and complex family histories and precarious socio-economic circumstances. The visual and narrative insights generated by the participants evoked their emotional fragility and the cumulative effects of personal and social pressures. In receiving access to treatment and support, we acknowledge that participants were also at a turning point that was perceived as an opportunity to change their lives. These situations confronted us with a fundamental ethical issue that broadly applies to all research exploring sensitive and painful issues—is the intrusion of research warranted, and, if so, what steps can researchers take to mitigate risks for participants?

Justifying Research into Sensitive Topics Such as First-Person Accounts of Suicide

The dearth of qualitative studies exploring first-person accounts of suicide is partially explained by reluctance among researchers to tackle what is generally considered to be a fraught and difficult topic (Meyer et al. 2010). Researchers and ethics committees alike are generally wary of the potentially negative effects of exploring this issue with inevitably vulnerable participants (Goldsmith et al. 2002; Hjelmeland and Knizek 2010). Nonetheless, the lack of qualitative evidence to inform suicide prevention initiatives is of particular concern. A report on Human Rights and Mental Health (Human Rights and Equal Opportunity Commission 1994) notes that if qualitative research potentially offers important insights into first-person accounts of suicide, then failing to conduct such research may be an unintended but significant source of discrimination.

Researchers seeking to gain first-person accounts of suicide attempts are understandably concerned about whether the topic of suicide should even be raised with people who may be vulnerable to suicide ideation. Linked to this, there are ethical concerns related to research topics that involve provoking feelings of sadness or distress in participants. Questions of whether it is ethical to discuss suicide with people who are recovering from suicide, or who may continue to feel suicidal at different times, are raised in a small

number of studies. Available evidence suggests that participating in studies exploring subjective experiences of suicide attempts is not associated with increased risk of dying by suicide (Fleischman et al. 2008, 703), or other adverse effects (Rivlin et al. 2012, 59–61). Nonetheless, there is limited research that explores these issues and caution is strongly warranted. The research consensus is that the risk of suicidal behavior among research participants cannot be completely eliminated if it is a central component of presenting health issues (Meyer et al. 2010; Goldsmith et al. 2002). These risks should be weighed against the benefits of gaining improved understanding of why people are feeling suicidal and the potential contribution of qualitative research for gaining in-depth insights. There is some evidence that talking about suicide can have therapeutic benefit and, if raised with sensitivity and care, it can assist families and communities in encouraging people who may be thinking about suicide to seek help (Gould et al. 2005). Some studies have reported that while participants in qualitative studies exploring first-person accounts of suicide experienced heightened emotionality, they also found that the opportunity to talk about a stigmatized experience in non-judgmental conversations had positive cathartic effects. In considering these issues, our study offered potential generalized benefits of gaining improved insight into an issue that is of growing national concern in Chile. Although significant public health resources had been directed to suicide prevention campaigns and initiatives, these were having negligible impacts in containing the problem (Page et al. 2011). We were also reassured by evidence that asking individuals to talk about their own experiences of suicide may have some positive effects for participants (Rivlin et al. 2012). Nonetheless, to maximize the potential benefits and minimize the risks, it is critical to develop comprehensive strategies to ensure the wellbeing of participants during their involvement in research.

Caring for Participants During Their Involvement in Research

An innovative and gentle triangulated technique was developed to monitor participants' emotional states at the beginning and conclusion of each of the interview sessions. This emotional assessment tool combined three tactics for 'checking in' with how participants were feeling (see Fig. 11.1). Two of the tactics drew on visual ideas by adapting concepts of 'emojis' and 'emotional thermometers'. Participants were offered a blank colored circle for them to draw a facial representation of how they were feeling.

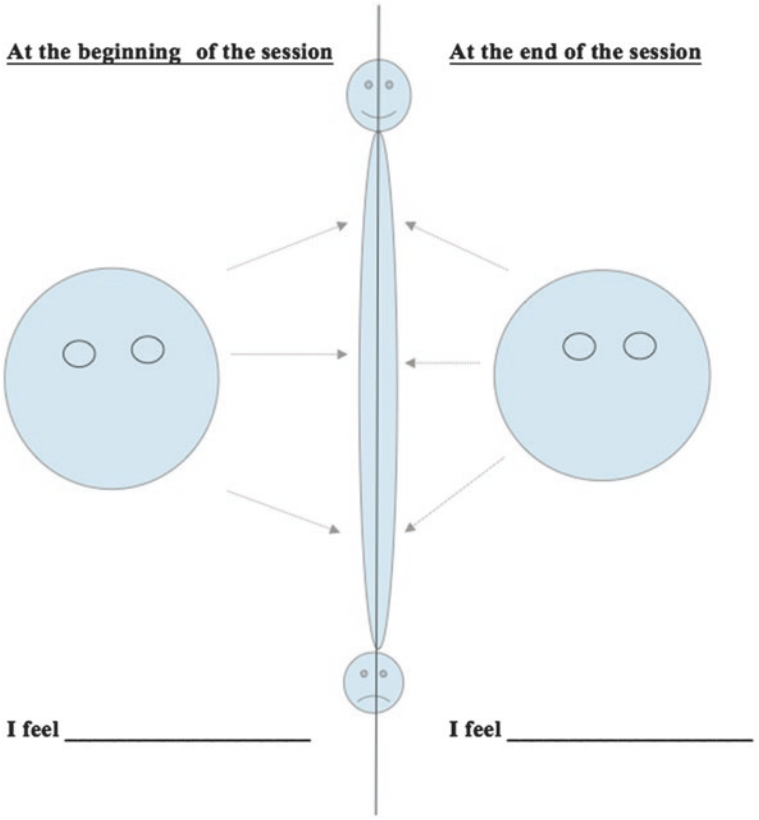


Fig. 11.1 Emotional assessment tool

The second tactic asked participants to measure how they were feeling on a drawing of a thermometer that had a smiling face at one end and a sad face at the other. Participants were also asked to nominate a word that described how they were feeling. It was explained to participants that their responses to these 'checking in' activities would be passed onto the psychologist to guide the debriefing sessions.

Participants recognized that these activities demonstrated the researchers' concerns that they were feeling comfortable during the interviews and they approached the tasks seriously and thoughtfully. Participants took time to think carefully when completing these tasks, including finding the

right word to express how they were feeling, and sometimes providing additional information to contextualize their feelings. Two participants reported feeling worse after an interview session and a few indicated they felt sadder following reflections on painful issues. It is important to note, however, that this kind of emotional reaction should not be unexpected due to the issues being explored. On some occasions, the interviewer offered to pause or stop interviews, although this was not required. The researcher conducting the interviews (JFT) is a qualified clinical psychologist in Chile with experience in treating patients of similar ages and mental health issues. Although this information was not disclosed to participants, his professional experience offered the capacity to recognize when participants may have been displaying signs of distress.

Protecting Participants' Confidentiality

Three kinds of visual data were collected for the study. In the first interview session, participants created biographical timelines and social relationship maps. In preparation for the second interview session, participants were asked to complete a photographic activity using cameras or their mobile phones. During the second interview session, photo-elicitation strategies were used to explore the significance of the images in relation to key events marked on the timelines, including events surrounding suicide attempt(s). Together, these activities offered participants engaging ways to represent subjective perspectives on their everyday lives, significant relationships and critical biographical moments (Woodley-Baker 2009).

In designing the photographic activity, we aimed to find the right balance between offering participants sufficient scope to generate images that were personally significant and which explored the research themes, at the same time as putting some limitations on what could and could not be photographed. Understandably, issues of whether participants should be 'allowed' to take photographs of other people can be a vexed one for ethics committees. To promote the value of the visual data and address ethical concerns regarding confidentiality of participants and acquaintances, a detailed protocol was prepared to guide the photographic activity. We encouraged participants to be creative in thinking about how to depict ideas, thoughts and emotional states; however, they were also reassured that they did not have to produce works of art. The protocol discouraged participants from capturing images in which individuals could be identified, and this included taking 'selfie' shots. Participants were reminded

not to intrude on the privacy of others when taking photographs in public places and that if (unidentified) individuals were photographed in the background of images, they should obtain their permission and explain that the photographs would be used in a research project. We urged participants not to place themselves in dangerous situations and explained that we would not be able to use photographs that showed anyone involved in risky behavior.

Participants were asked to bring their images to the second interview session where they were viewed using a laptop; photo-elicitation methods were used to explore their significance and relationship to events mapped on the timelines. Photographs were then printed and incorporated into the timelines that generated complex assemblages of visual, text and narrative data. It was evident that some participants were highly engaged in these activities, and a few even postponed scheduled second interviews to allow more time to capture specific kinds of images. Others, however, appeared to have felt constrained by the photographic task, particularly because we discouraged images of people. On their own initiative, some participants brought 'found' images downloaded from the Internet as substitutes for taking photographs, and so, in subsequent interviews, participants were offered the choice to take photographs or use found images. Most participants used a combination of photographs and found images to illustrate and explore their timelines in both literal and metaphoric ideas.

Many of the photographs that were taken by participants demonstrated their understanding of the ethical issues outlined in the protocol with images carefully composed to avoid showing people's heads or other identifying characteristics. The range of ideas in the images used by participants strongly suggested their familiarity with a visual vernacular. Many of the images operated as cultural tropes (e.g., tears, nature, figures alone in empty rooms, sunrises); images were used either as stand-alone representations of a feeling or idea or assembled in complex sequences that detailed biographical subplots. For example, one participant produced two extended sequences of images that portrayed a period of risk-taking, sadness and confusion that gave way to increasing anger, ambivalence toward the value of her life, suicide ideation and relinquishing of self-responsibility (through references to God's plan). Participants used captions to show the personal and explanatory significance of their images.

Discussion

It is likely that the injunction on taking photographs influenced the kind of data that were generated, including emphasizing the timelines rather than the social relationship maps as sources of biographical data. For instance, allowing participants to use images of people in their lives, perhaps pixelated to ensure their anonymity is likely to have generated more complex social maps. As it was, participants were required to think in abstract and intellectual registers and this may have been more difficult for younger participants and those with lower levels of education; three of four of the participants who were not able to complete the photographic task reflected these circumstances.

Nonetheless, most participants (16/18 interview sessions) noted that the interviews were largely a positive experience. This can be attributed to the strategies employed, such as the emotional assessment tool, that were used to check in with participants during their involvement in the research. In addition, the ways in which the visual methods gave participants some control over the ways in which they were able to approach and reflect on difficult and complex emotions and memories ensured the experience remained positive. Although we expected participants would find the interviews to be highly emotional experiences, our participants tended to display limited emotionality. There is highly tentative evidence that visual methods can have emotionally stabilizing effects for research focusing on highly sensitive issues (Amourous 2012). This effect is thought to be associated with the ways in which data generating activities such as timelines and taking photographs require participants, often over an extended period of time (from a few days to a few weeks), to carefully review and craft the memories and experiences they wish to communicate to researchers. In combination with an increased sense of control, this process may assist in 'managing' the emotionality of their experiences.

There was also evidence that the visual methods assisted participants to accurately recall sequences of events for the researcher. For example, when organizing the events in the timelines, some participants expressed surprise when realizing that the order of the events in their minds did not match with years, school grades or the timing of other related experiences. The staged structure for the photographic task also allowed participants to explore their feelings and experiences in reflexive ways. This occurred as participants identified key themes at the end of the first interview session, during the process of taking photographs and gathering found images and

then explaining the relevance of the images in the second interview session. This suggested that the processes of generating data were exploratory and meaning-generating for the participants as well as for the researchers. In these ways, data generated by the participants depicted potentially significant associations between their personal stories, their family circumstances and socio-historical events. This was particularly apparent in the fragmented family structures described by participants, and these preliminary insights will be explored in future analyses. These insights are also speculative because of the small sample size and the strong significance of gendered experiences in the women's narratives.

Conclusion

We have discussed an innovative visual qualitative research design that was used to explore the personal meanings and socio-historical contexts of suicide attempts among young people in Chile. We focused on three interconnected sets of ethical and methodological issues: justification for researching emotionally painful and potentially distressing issues such as suicide attempts; strategies that were developed to care for participants during their involvement in research; and protecting participants' confidentiality. The methods generated rich and robust data that affords useful analyses of circumstances associated with suicidal behavior, extending over longer periods of time than have usually been considered in previous research. In addition to presenting some resolved and unresolved challenges, the study generated detailed insights into biographical trajectories of suicidal behavior, and associated personal and socio-historical meanings. The findings will usefully inform ongoing efforts to understand suicide as a complex and multifaceted phenomenon.

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CHAPTER 12

Conflicting Aims and Minimizing Harm: Uncovering Experiences of Trauma in Digital Storytelling with Young Women

Aline Gubrium, Alice Fiddian-Green, and Amy Hill

Introduction

In this chapter we discuss ethical issues that arose in a research project focusing on sexual health disparities experienced by young Puerto Rican Latinas living in a city where community members face extreme social and health inequities. We used digital storytelling in the "Let's Talk About Sex" project as a vehicle for conducting community-based research and an intervention to improve sexual health outcomes among Puerto Rican Latina youth in the community. We begin by briefly introducing the Let's Talk About Sex project, and then present an overview of digital storytelling as a culture-centered approach for use in public health research and intervention. We trace two specific ethical issues that came up in the research project and discuss strategies we adopted to address these issues. One issue was that as the project proceeded, it became evident that our research aims conflicted with our intervention aims. The other issue centers on imperatives to minimize harm for participants who, during their involvement in

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the project, disclosed significant experiences of trauma. We conclude by suggesting that while digital storytelling and other participatory, visual, and arts-based methods offer great potential for surfacing alternative sensibilities that can inform effective sexual health intervention design, ethical tensions can arise in the process and must be preemptively considered and appropriately addressed. Our hope is that by spelling out some of these tensions, we will be supporting other researchers using these techniques to anticipate and address similar challenges that might arise in their work.

The Let's Talk About Sex Project

Let's Talk About Sex was a two-year, mixed-methods study located in a mid-sized New England city in the Northeastern United States focused on the experiences of self-identified Puerto Rican Latinas between the ages of 15 and 21. The city is home to a sizeable Puerto Rican community that experiences a disproportionate incidence of sexual health disparities, including one of the highest teen birth rates in the entire state. The project emerged from our long-term work in the community, and through collaboration with local organizations whose priorities are to both increase access to sexual health services and reduce high teen pregnancy and birth rates in the region. We prioritized digital storytelling (DST) in the project given our experience using it as an ethnographic and participatory research method for uncovering often-silenced local cultural meanings on sexuality and wellbeing. This experience has shown us how the process stimulates cognitive and affective transformations among storytelling participants.

Our project involved three, 4-day DST workshops. As a group-based process, DST engages participants in creating and sharing brief, first person, visually engaging narrative accounts of life events. Personal experiences are documented by synthesizing digital images, audio recordings, music, and text (Lambert 2010). For each workshop, we enrolled ten participants who were recruited by staff at partnering agencies, as well as through direct contact by research assistants (including this chapter's second author) who visited the agencies. Recruitment criteria included: (1) self-identification as a Puerto Rican Latina; (2) living or receiving services in the project city; (3) aged 15–21; and (4) pregnant/parenting or not pregnant or parenting, depending on the workshop. Parental consent and participant assent was obtained for all participants under the age of 18; all participants over the age of 18 signed a consent form. Our university's Institutional Review Board approved the project protocol.

The workshops were structured to consist of women with similar or divergent experiences (one group who were neither pregnant nor parenting, another who were pregnant and/or parenting, and a third, mixed group). We were interested in analyzing the varied interactions within groups based on fertility/parenting status and related experience, while recognizing that the mixed group might more realistically address dynamic influences of sexuality and more closely model what happens in everyday social interaction. Workshops were held in the offices of one of our community-partner organizations, and were facilitated by StoryCenter (formerly known as the Center for Digital Storytelling) and a local media partner. Thirty participants enrolled in the project and 29 completed a digital story. StoryCenter's workshop format is previously detailed in the literature (Gubrium 2009; Gubrium and DiFulvio 2011).

Digital stories were crafted with guidance from trained facilitators. We used story prompts to encourage participants to write about one of the following "moments": when they learned about sex and sexuality, experienced pleasure and desire, understood what love is all about, felt really strong or really helpless in a relationship, learned about contraception or tried to get or use it, were afraid that they had an STI, found out they were pregnant, were scared to ask about reproductive or sexual healthcare, or knew they were in a good or bad relationship. We have used similar prompts in previous workshops and found them helpful in guiding storytellers to pinpoint a topic for their stories. Providing this focus supports storytellers to identify a meaningful moment to share out loud. Participants received feedback each step of the way—from peers during group work and from workshop facilitators in one-on-one contexts, yielding an iterative process of storytelling (Gubrium et al. 2014). In the DST process, storytellers each determine what to share or not to share, and are asked to consider which parts of their story might leave the story circle and potentially enter the public domain (Hancox 2012).

The StoryCenter DST process serves as a site for solidarity building and collective analysis of the ways that individual experiences are situated within larger structures (Gubrium and Scott 2010). This takes place in three steps. First, in a story circle, each participant introduces the story they intend to share. The group collectively analyzes the story and the intersection of structural threads—economic, social, cultural, intergenerational, historical, and political—in the women's lives, and the ways these are woven through understandings of health and wellbeing. The second step involves participants reflecting on their lived experience and position

in the world through story idea generation, script writing activities, and hands-on production of digital stories. In the third step, participants articulate new ways of seeing and being seen (Gubrium et al. 2014) during a group screening and discussion of the final digital stories.

Digital Storytelling as a Culture-Centered Approach

Our strategy in Let's Talk About Sex utilized a culture-centered approach (CCA) as a framework calling for the "voice of the community [to be] central to the articulation of health problems and corresponding solutions" (Dutta 2007, 307). Originally articulated by Dutta (2008), the CCA considers three overlapping components: (1) local and dynamic cultural contexts of health; (2) structural factors, which both constrain and facilitate human agency, and, through a deep analysis of social inequality, politicize the endeavor of public health research; and (3) individual agency, which is predicated on a dialogic/process-oriented approach that engages participant voices and acknowledges the co-construction of knowledge. In this approach, the roles of researcher, as expert interventionist, and participant, as a vessel for public health information, are reconfigured to promote dialogue and acknowledge participants' cultural knowledge and expertise.

In contrast to top-down approaches in which policy makers, academics, public health practitioners, and others seen as experts generalize and articulate an experience—such as "teen pregnancy" and "risk" for a targeted community—DST enables participants to construct and represent their own experiences, in their own voices. Through the process, participants become conscious of shared experiences and the ways they make meaning of these experiences.

Similar to Freirian processes of conscientization, DST centers on the capacity of workshop facilitators to support participants in actively reflecting on, and naming, their own experiences while contributing to the development of the group's critical consciousness by analyzing issues embedded within the individual narratives and identifying proposed solutions/actions to address these issues (Freire 1970). Digital storytelling also encourages dialogue among participants, in this case, supporting them in the articulation, amplification, and analysis of their own views on sexuality, health, and wellbeing. In the process, "cultural contexts are placed at the core of meaning-making processes, and meanings are dialogically co-constructed by researchers and cultural participants" (Basu and Dutta 2009, 86).

Project Aims

The Let's Talk About Sex project had three aims. The first aim was to assess the potential of the DST methodology as an intervention to improve sexual health in the community. Based on our previous research, we expected certain cognitive and affective transformations to take place among individuals who participate in DST. These transformations include increased willingness to share personal experiences, feelings of belonging in a community, empowerment, self-esteem, and sense of agency—all generated through processes of telling one's story and mastering a new medium. These cognitive and affective changes may influence future behaviors related to sexual attitudes, beliefs, and practices. To explore these effects, we measured changes in participants' sense of hope, empowerment, self-esteem, social support, and sexual attitudes as a result of their involvement in the project.

An additional strength of DST lies in its utility as an ethnographic tool for conducting community-based and culturally situated research (Gubrium 2009). Accordingly, our second aim was to document the local "complex web of meanings" surrounding sexuality, which are "intertwined with the shared values, beliefs and practices that run through the strands of a community" (Geertz 1985, 11). Data collection included: participant observation and field notes written by researchers; interviews with participants; and audio-recorded and transcribed story circle and story screening activities. We understood from prior storytelling work with young women, and from our familiarity with the literature on violence among pregnant and parenting teens, that inviting the participants to share sensitive personal stories would likely surface narratives of trauma. We agreed to follow the StoryCenter's guidelines for addressing these issues.[1]

The third aim of the project was to explore the potential for resonant digital stories to be used for a large scale, health communication initiative in the next phase of research, given participant permission. To do this we used an adapted 8-item Likert scale Narrative Assessment (NA) tool (Larkey et al. 2008) to assess participants' responses to the digital stories produced in their workshop. The NA tool asks participants to evaluate the stories, and assesses the structural ingredients that are effective in narrative health promotion (i.e., identification and engagement). Workshop facilitators used this tool to prompt discussion during the story screenings and participants were asked to identify digital stories that they thought could affect attitude, values, and behavior change (i.e., increased self-efficacy,

self-determination, and self-esteem regarding sexual self-concept). Specifically, they discussed which aspects of each story they found particularly compelling and most likely to encourage self-reflection.

Emerging Ethical Issues

At multiple points during the Let's Talk About Sex project participants made references to experiences of trauma. We recognized that we had ethical obligations to respond to these issues. Additional ethical issues were associated with the "fuzzy boundaries" in project aims.

Ethical Issue One: Fuzzy Boundaries Between Project Aims

One tension that arose in Let's Talk About Sex relates to the "fuzzy boundaries" we established by incorporating data collection and intervention aims into a single project. In digital storytelling projects, multiple aims can cause "confusion between where priorities lie (research versus practice) [and] can lead to very different implementation approaches" (Gubrium et al. 2014, 1607). These tensions were particularly evident during story development and peer assessment of the final stories created, and required us to balance the therapeutic and creative possibilities of "telling one's story".

Story Development

The project emphasized dual aims (i.e., process versus product), and some tensions arose in the interplay between participants, researchers, and facilitators in crafting final stories. It is one thing to use DST as a method of data collection on its own, with no "grander" aims of intervention, advocacy, or action. In these instances, the focus is solely on the process—documenting the goings on of the workshop through participant observation, field note writing, and follow-up interviews—with the narrative arc and plot of the story left up to participant preference. Of course, we recognize that similar to other qualitative methods, data collection in the context of DST is never one-way: researcher and interlocutor each shape its trajectory (Holstein and Gubrium 1995). It is another thing entirely, however, to build on the potential of DST as a method for data collection, to use DST as an intervention for building esteem and solidarity among participants, and to develop content for health communication purposes.

We found that project participants were enchanted with the DST process (Vannini 2015), to the extent that they were willing and eager to talk and write about a moment or event in their lives that they had not previously shared with m/any people. As we had anticipated, given the project focus on youth sexuality, many participants told stories about early sexual experiences, with several sharing information about rape, attempted rape, incest, or molestation experienced as a child. Several other participants told stories about emotional and physical bullying they experienced in the public school system, and which had been overlooked by school administrators. In our roles as researchers and facilitators, we had to take special care in managing the three discreet project aims, while we worked with this sensitive content. We found that the intentional composition of our team to include at least one facilitator with more than a decade of experience in listening to young women's trauma stories was vital to our ability to navigate the challenges that arose.

From the outset of the project, we explained to participants that the final digital stories would be viewed as a group during a screening on the last day of the workshop (unless someone strictly refused). Further, with explicit participant permission, the stories might also be shared outside of the workshop. We highlighted the potential use of the stories in future health promotion work and in academic settings. The researcher-facilitator team worked closely with participants as they developed their stories, to discuss why each storyteller was telling *this* particular story, and where—and to whom—they hoped to show the story. Through careful work and with regular check-ins, our researcher-facilitator team supported all participants—those who were addressing issues of trauma, and those who were not—in creating stories that they were happy to have produced. The story release form, which included specific locations in which the stories might be screened, was only completed *after* participants had finalized their stories.

Peer Assessment of Stories

Another tension occurred during the peer assessment of stories, which took place on the final day of the workshops. As part of our third project aim, we planned to work with participants during each story screening to analyze which stories might be most resonant for use in future health promotion work with young people. In classic narrative health communication, a "good story" has plots and characters that viewers/listeners can identify with, emotionally transports them to another place,

and encourages (i.e., persuades) them to change their attitudes, beliefs, and, ultimately, their behaviors (Brown and Basil 1995; Green and Brock 2000; Green et al. 2004; Larkey 2006; Slater and Rouner 2002). In keeping with the tenets of the culture-centered perspective, we intended to use the Narrative Assessment (NA) tool (Larkey et al. 2008) to stimulate reflection, dialogue, and provoke novel understandings around the stories in ways that would offer insight into the value of particular stories for use in a future health promotion campaign.

We found that our aim of constructing a "good" story conflicted somewhat with one of our research aims, which prioritized a naturalistic (i.e., less guided) process, and our intervention-related aim, which focused on promoting the positive effects of the DST process for participants. In using the NA tool during the first workshop, we recognized that asking participants to discuss and rate each other's stories, in the midst of a process that had encouraged and honored vulnerability, introduced an element of judgment that might retraumatize participants. It could also derail the intervention we had set out to assess, particularly for individuals already subjected to myriad structural, social, and historical injuries in their lives.

The volume of sensitive story content that emerged in the workshops clarified the need to reconsider who is in a position to determine what a "good" story is: the creator, the viewer, or the researcher? Although the NA tool enabled individual storytellers to "pre-assess" the stories for use in future health promotion work, we realized that it would be more appropriately utilized to explore these issues in a carefully facilitated community forum with non-workshop participants. While the NA tool ultimately did not prompt the discussion around individual stories that we had anticipated, it offered participants the individual time and space to process each story before we moved on to the next.

Ethical Issue Two: Minimizing Harm in the Process

Our second ethical issue addresses the need to minimize harm for participants through their involvement in the DST process. In prioritizing DST in the Let's Talk About Sex project, we sought to reposition the roles of researchers and participants as "facilitators" and "storytellers" in order to create a safe space for young women to talk honestly about their experiences with sexuality and achieve some leveling of the power dynamics inherent to traditional research processes (Cox et al. 2014). We aimed to

generate a relaxed and pleasurable workshop experience for participants, and produce stories that might otherwise not be told using top-down approaches that are associated with health promotion endeavors. The federal funding climate for public health research in the United States, however, is based on a model of individual behavior change that is produced largely through methods of persuasion (Buchanan 2000). It is a thorny matter to propose to funding agencies that a participatory research project focusing on participant empowerment and self-determination (Lupton 1995) can also lead to health-promoting behavioral change. We rooted our approach in the Digital Storyteller Bill of Rights (StoryCenter n.d.), which prioritizes, above all else, the wellbeing of the storyteller. During each workshop we negotiated between our desire to redistribute power, and afford participants the latitude to determine the direction and shape of their digital stories, and our priority of minimizing harm.

Two examples from Let's Talk About Sex illustrate this tension. During one story circle, Amara[2] opened up about being sexually molested by an older male friend of the family when she was a young child. This prompted other participants to disclose their own experiences of sexual trauma. Amara was determined to make and share a digital story about this abuse, although we were hesitant at first about assisting her with this given that she was a minor.[3] However, Amara was adamant that she had joined the workshop specifically so she could share this particular story. Throughout the workshop, we witnessed her as she literally gained a voice—she was committed to ending her own silence about the issue and encouraging other participants to speak up. We worked closely with her to produce a story that was visually compelling (in light of her intention to share the story publicly) and emotionally moving.

While Amara initially wanted to show her face in the story, we gently encouraged her not to do so, knowing that she might later change her mind about being identified in this way, and to avoid stirring up family tensions. Instead, she used a mask to represent the silence that had surrounded her experience, ending the story by throwing it to the ground and walking away. As we supported Amara in producing the story, we were able to ascertain that she had regular access to a social worker and therapist, to whom she had disclosed her experiences of sexual trauma. Amara has thrived since her involvement in the DST workshop—we maintained indirect contact as she entered and eventually graduated from a high school equivalency exam preparation program that had been recommended to her. Amara's experience is exemplary in successfully nego-

tiating between risk mitigation and power sharing during the process of producing her story.

These tensions proved more difficult for another workshop participant to negotiate. Jenna had suffered significant sexual trauma at an early age, and was currently in a violent intimate partner relationship. She also expressed interest in producing a digital story addressing these experiences. We were concerned that Jenna was in the midst of active trauma, particularly because we were unsure of her support systems—she was over 18 and therefore less connected to the systems charged with protecting the safety of minors. We were also working in an environment of "too many cooks in the kitchen", as several members of our team were researchers who had also been trained in DST facilitation techniques and therefore had dual roles in the workshops as ethnographic researchers and assistant facilitators. A tension arose among the team members in deciding who was best suited to talk with Jenna about the potential benefits and risks of continuing her involvement in the workshop and sharing her story. Our reactions to her story were mixed, with some of us feeling that it was fine for her to proceed; others were concerned that creating a story about her abuse might put her at risk of retaliation at the hands of her partner, and others, if she expressed a desire to share the story publicly. We wondered if we would minimize harm by asking Jenna to leave, or if this risked inflicting additional trauma, given that she had shared that the DST experience represented one of the very few times when she felt listened to and supported.

The researchers and facilitators collectively determined that writing about her current trauma could potentially trigger negative emotional responses for Jenna, and put her at risk of further violence. These were risks that we did not have the in-house capacity to address. Jenna was determined to create a story that included a message about the importance of not staying in abusive relationships; she was upset with facilitators for not being able to tell the story that she wanted to tell. In the end, one facilitator worked with Jenna to shape her script so that, instead of touching on her current situation, she was able to share her story with others in the workshop by representing issues of abuse more generally. Jenna's final story was framed as a plea to an anonymous family member who was living with an abusive partner. Although Jenna gave permission for her final story to be shown in multiple settings, including a community forum in her community, we noted as a group that we would not share her story, given the active nature of the trauma for both her and her family member.

Each participant was provided with a link to their final digital story on a private YouTube channel (which cannot be accessed through a name search); we are able to see that nearly a year later, her story has only been viewed four times, by members of the research team. We also took the time during the workshop to support Jenna in completing the necessary paperwork to document abusive text messages from her partner and file a restraining order against him—tasks that would have presented many challenges without access to office equipment in the computer lab we were using for the workshop.

Although Jenna attended the entire workshop and completed a digital story, it proved difficult to maintain contact with her. The research component of the project included two points of follow-up contact with each participant: an interview the week following the workshop; and a meeting three months later where participants completed a survey for intervention assessment purposes and received their completed stories. At the follow-up interview, which was conducted at Jenna's new apartment (a shelter for young single mothers), we were able to determine that her restraining order was still active, and that she was safe. However, we could not reach her at the three-month follow-up. Through information provided by other participants at that time, we learned that she had changed her phone number. Jenna had been recruited through one of our community partners at an alternative high school for young mothers, which provided guaranteed access to appropriate and necessary social service providers. Given that she was over the age of 18, we were limited in our ability to intervene beyond contacting this community partner and the other workshop participants, who had all lost contact with her.

Conclusion

The ethical concerns inherent to DST-based work are compounded by the potential presence of both historical and active trauma in the lives of participants. For the Let's Talk About Sex project, this trauma required that we grapple in new and heightened ways with the impact of fuzzy boundaries on the production of digital stories, and on peer assessment and discussion of stories. Although one of the project aims was to assess stories for use in a large scale, health communication initiative in the next phase of research, this stage was not confirmed at the time the workshops took place, and participation in such an effort was not required for participants.

Trauma also compounded our ability to minimize harm to participants throughout the DST process. Because our project focused on youth sexuality, and because we were recruiting minors, we closely followed the StoryCenter's required practice of working with respected community partner agencies. This requirement provided us with a trusted contact person who handled most of the workshop participant screening and preparation activities and also served as a conduit to appropriate follow-up, for participants in particular need of additional emotional or practical support. Nonetheless, we recognize that we failed to anticipate the extent to which trauma had impacted the lives of many, if not all, of the young women who created digital stories.

We recognize that individuals who have experienced trauma may benefit from the healing and therapeutic aspects of DST processes. The therapeutic benefits of telling a story and being heard include transforming traumatic experiences by "developing a coherent [and structured] narrative [that] enable an event to be stored in memory and then forgotten more easily" (Bosticco and Thompson 2008, 40), establishing and strengthening social ties to a community of supportive peers, feeling understood, creating a positive self-narrative, and feelings of relief and catharsis after telling one's story (Herman 2015; Bosticco and Thompson 2008; Pennebaker 2000).

We understand both the value and the delicate nature of these processes, and the importance of carrying them out with thoughtfulness, respect, and compassion. In spite of the challenges we faced when working with storytellers whose lives have been, or are continuing to be, marked by trauma, we argue that, when carried out responsibly, DST methods can be highly valuable for these storytellers. Not only does DST recognize and honor each participant as an expert of her/his own experience, it also creates space for the articulation of experiences that are often silenced. In the case of the Let's Talk About Sex project, the young women's digital stories, and especially those referencing experiences of trauma, point to the clear and urgent need for adolescent sexual and reproductive health and rights programs and advocacy initiatives to acknowledge and appropriately address historical legacies and current experiences of violence. We urge researchers and practitioners using DST to explore sensitive topics to carefully consider and plan for the gamut of ethical issues that may arise in order to protect or enhance the wellbeing of participants.

Notes

1. We refer readers to the "Ethical Practice" page on StoryCenter's website: http://static1.squarespace.com/static/55368c08e4b0d419e1c011f7/t/55e92424e4b0e50993544719/1441342500305/Ethics.pdf.
2. All names in this chapter have been changed to protect the confidentiality of participants.
3. As a minor, Amara had assented to participate in the project, with her mother providing parental consent for her participation. Furthermore, the Department of Social Services could no longer take action on this case.

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CHAPTER 13

Ethical Considerations When Using Visual Methods in Digital Storytelling with Aboriginal Young People in Southeast Australia

Fran Edmonds, Michelle Evans, Scott McQuire, and Richard Chenhall

Introduction

In southeast Australia the history of colonization continues to impact the way Aboriginal people are perceived. The legacy of the visual record connected to Aboriginal people, including photographs, art and material culture, has been used by Europeans since the earliest days of colonization to define and control them. This contrasts with the rich visual traditions, which Aboriginal people continue to practice, and determines their specific connections to Country and kin, their identities, and to reflect their stories and experiences (Edmonds and Clarke 2009).

In this chapter we discuss two digital storytelling workshops that involved Australian Aboriginal young people who are associated with the

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Korin Gamadji Institute in Melbourne.[1] The Korin Gamadji Institute provides opportunities for young Aboriginal people to achieve positive outcomes as emerging leaders within their community. Alternatives to the standard first-person, linear narrative approach familiar to the digital storytelling process were adopted in the workshops, enabling the participants to access a range of innovative digital technologies to explore identity and culture. The ethical framework that emerged from the two workshops informed three key considerations: decolonization, the participation gap and situated learning.

Digital Storytelling

In this project, digital storytelling is viewed as a way to support the expertise of young people as active consumers and producers of digital content. Standard digital storytelling workshops typically involve 3–4 days where specialist facilitators assist participants to develop short, autobiographical, linear narratives, which often rely on individual or collective stories of memory and remembrance (Center for Digital Storytelling; Lambert 2013). These workshops are frequently considered in terms of a co-creative environment, one that reflects the inclusive process connected with telling a story, while learning to use the technology (Hartley and McWilliam 2009; Lambert 2013; Burgess et al. 2010).

The workshops we conducted with Aboriginal young people sought alternative approaches to the traditional digital storytelling genre and focused on redressing the historical legacy of images (including material culture) used to define Aboriginality. Many of the young people in the workshops, like other Aboriginal youth, continue to experience marginalization from the mainstream, a result of lingering stereotypes concerning the authenticity of Aboriginal people, particularly those from southeast Australia (see Anderson 2005). The way young people represent themselves in relation to the use of digital images is affected by the continuing effects of assimilation policies, the grief and trauma connected with the Stolen Generations (the forced removal of children from their families) and the displacement of Aboriginal people from Country, culture and kin. These have contributed to a negative historical articulation of Aboriginality, which continues to affect the well-being of Aboriginal youth (Ferdinand et al. 2012).

In this project, the workshops aimed to provide the participants with the knowledge and skills to create digital-visual representations that reflected

their contemporary experiences as young Aboriginal people from south-east Australia. Digital-visual literacy focused on participants' capacity to control and manage their visual identities and to support and strengthen their explorations of self. For Aboriginal young people, knowing who you are and understanding your place in the Aboriginal community can have positive impacts on health and social outcomes. For Aboriginal young people, cultural identity and 'promotion of culture is a key factor in building resilience in families and young people' (DEECD 2010: 52).

The Storytelling Workshops

Two digital storytelling workshops and follow-up focus group discussions were conducted with eight participants, aged between 15 and 19 years (3 males and 5 females). Data gathered throughout the workshops and discussions informed the development of our ethical framework for conducting research with Aboriginal young people.

The first workshop included five participants who constructed individual digital stories, using a range of new digital art-making programs, including 3D programs (known as RGBD) and a time-lapse stop-start animation program (DragonFrame stop motion software). The workshop was preceded by a half-day introductory session at Museum Victoria, which brought together Aboriginal Elders, artists and museum curators. The story-making workshop involved spending four days at the Australian Centre for the Moving Image (ACMI) in Melbourne. The ACMI digital storytelling program offers communities and organizations the opportunity to learn to use state-of-the-art technologies in situ and to be assisted in developing their stories with expert facilitators. In this project, participants, facilitators and an Aboriginal scriptwriter and filmmaker were involved in the workshop.

The second workshop involved a collaborative process in which two groups of four young people worked together to each produce their own digital stories. There was a preceding introductory day at Museum Victoria with Aboriginal experts and museum curators, followed by a three-day workshop at ACMI. iPads were uploaded with the latest digital art-making and filmmaking apps, such as the iMotion timelapse app, Green Screen Movie FX Studio and McLaren's Etching on Film app. This technology assisted the participants to develop the confidence and knowledge required for independently creating their own films outside the workshop environment. This approach also acknowledged the ubiq-

uity of camera-enabled mobile technology, and the everyday use of these devices and apps by young people, for the consumption and production of all kinds of images across the digital spectrum. In both workshops, participants produced technically distinctive films that drew on a range of genres, including sci-fi, MTV style music videos and documentary style films.

We found that despite the diversity of the films, the technology used and their visual content, common ethical issues arose between the two workshops. These issues reside in the complex realm of digital-visual representations and focus specifically on ways for improving digital-visual literacy. Digital-visual literacy in this context is directed to assisting youth in developing skills that contribute to a visual rhetoric (a communication through images) and enabling them to acquire knowledge and experiences for confidently distributing visual material about themselves now and in the future. In addition, the overall ethical framework was informed by our reflexive position as researchers. This included our observations and experiences during the workshops, our ongoing consultations with members of the Aboriginal community, as well as our partner organizations.

Ethical Considerations

Three key sets of issues emerged to form an ethical framework for the project:

- Decolonization as a practice that prioritizes working with the Aboriginal community to promote ownership and control
- Narrowing the 'participation gap', by encouraging ongoing and appropriate digital learning, including intergenerational knowledge exchange; and
- Situated learning (in response to co-creativity) that contextualizes the digital storytelling process and supports digital literacy.

Decolonization

This project adopted a community-based collaborative and participatory methodology. This meant the non-Indigenous researchers and digital storytelling facilitators worked alongside the Aboriginal community, including participants, Elders, filmmakers, artists, curators and mentors from Korin Gamadji Institute to provide an inclusive workshop environment. The community-based approach to the research responds to decolonizing

methods, which in this project prioritizes the call from Indigenous scholars to 'recognize the radically unequal context of colonialism' and the imperative to 're-center' Indigenous perspectives in the research process (Coburn 2013: 3).

The decolonizing approach adopted in this research focused attention away from the researcher and the academy as 'expert'. As Indigenous scholars have argued, this offers 'a means of challenging the colonial institutional relations and practices that have constituted Indigenous peoples as objects of research rather than as authorities about their own ways of knowing, being and doing' (Coburn 2013: 1). The workshops therefore aimed to contribute to research that produces 'knowledge that makes sense in terms of [Indigenous peoples'] lived realities, experiences and challenges' (Coburn et al. 2013: 11).

In the workshops, the presence of Aboriginal facilitators supported a commonality of experiences for the participants, including the negative effects of assimilation, racism and stereotyping, alongside the significance of Country and kinship relations. These shared experiences assisted participants in constructing alternative digital-visual self-representations. The participants' responses contrast with images that have previously denied Aboriginal people opportunities to express their diversity and contemporaneity from their own perspectives, including those that reinforce fixed ideas about Aboriginal people and their culture.

Ownership and Control

A key finding, contributing to the development of an ethical framework in this research, emerged through participants' emphasis over the ownership and control of their digital stories. By moving away from standard digital storytelling methods, participants were able to experiment with new digital forms of self-representation. This responded to the reluctance of some participants to utilize revealing self-images as the central focus of their narratives (Edmonds et al. 2014). Some participants created digital identities in ways that enabled them to exercise close control over the extent of their personal recognition by audiences in their final digital stories. One film, in particular, highlighted the degree of remediation possible in developing digital-visual content, with the participant choosing to construct a story that was deeply reflective of his personality and identity. Leon (pseudonyms are used to refer to participants), a 15-year-old young man from country Victoria, drew on his fascination with, and skills in, computer gaming design to represent himself as a Gunditjmara warrior.

To develop the story, he learned about and manipulated the 3D RGBD software to create content in his film that was reminiscent of a Star Wars movie. His voice-over supported the imagery he had created and revealed his capacity to tell stories across genres, while exploring new avenues for image-making and self-representation.

> *Leon: I like the RGBD… because I didn't realize that your Xbox can connect a camera to it and make 3D images. I never knew that was a thing, so I was instantly hooked … Just the thought of a 3D image is amazing … I just love mixing around with the software with what we used to make the image look different every now and then, vertical lines and horizontal lines, make it all blurry, wavy, I just love that.*

Leon's experience suggested how digital technologies could offer young people ways of exploring and depicting concepts, such as identity and culture, in digital formats.

Our approach to digital storytelling also responded to concerns about the potential of images to be uploaded and inappropriately distributed online. Today, young people are encountering new challenges in negotiating issues of privacy in public forums, specifically through the use of social media. Learning when it is appropriate (and safe) to share images in public, particularly given the relatively uncensored online distribution of digital images, requires individuals to be aware of the complexities of sharing such content (see Gubrium 2014; Vivienne and Burgess 2013). For young Aboriginal people, these complex issues can be especially acute if images are interpreted by wider audiences in ways that reinforce stereotypes. Canadian researchers working with young First Nations peoples acknowledge that online experiences can potentially 'represent another space of colonialism', where the consequences 'may have a profoundly negative effect, especially if one's project is viewed by internet users with racist or intolerant attitudes towards Aboriginal peoples' (Adleson 2013, no page number).

The 'Participation Gap'

The 'participation gap' acknowledges that 'not all media ecologies are equal' (Watkins 2011). This also informed our ethical considerations for assisting youth to co-create stories that contrasted with commonly held views of stereotypes and images of Aboriginality. For Aboriginal youth, despite their expertise in manipulating technology, appropriate mentor-

ing of rich learning experiences can assist in maximizing the potential benefits of digital technology for learning and empowerment. Previous research has found that this is significant in reducing the disparity between the social, educational and economic outcomes between Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal young people (AIATSIS 2009; Biddle 2010; Walsh et al. 2011).

The American digital ethnographer danah boyd has pointed to the uneven distribution of technological skills and media literacy among youth. In doing so, she critiques the naïve notion that today's young people are 'digital natives' because they have never known a time without online technologies, and are therefore experts in navigating digital environments. boyd emphasizes that '[exposure] to information or imagery through the internet and engaging with social media do not make someone a savvy interpreter of the meaning behind these artifacts' (boyd 2014: 177).

Our observations of the museum experience during the workshops reveal the significance of community-based learning if the participation gap is to be reduced. The museum visit was directed toward providing participants with ways of witnessing and exploring their Aboriginality through the collections in the First People's gallery at Bunjilaka,[2] and the Australian Indigenous heritage material located back-of-house. Here, participants were able to take photographs and videos of images and objects that resonated with them, and that could be included in their stories. For Aboriginal people, artwork across the spectrum from historical to contemporary assists in connecting people with their culture and heritage, and in supporting identity and well-being (Edmonds and Clarke 2009). Art practice and access to cultural heritage are also acknowledged as a way of supporting community-development and Indigenous knowledge in digital storytelling workshops on an international scale, including among Maori in New Zealand, (Dibley 2012), Native Americans in the USA (Hopkins 2006), and among other marginalized groups, including Roma communities in Europe (Sabiescu 2009).

During the introduction to the second workshop at the museum, participants were welcomed by Wurundjeri Elder, Aunty Di Kerr, and supported throughout the day by the Yorta Yorta/Mutti Mutti/Wemba Wemba/Boonwurrung artist, Maree Clarke, and Gunditjmara filmmaker, Tim Church. Tim continued with the group throughout the week, where the participants drew on his expertise as a filmmaker to complete their digital story.

In addition to exploring the museum's collections, and collecting images and information using their iPads, time at the museum was allocated to allow participants to work in groups to begin developing their stories in brainstorming sessions. In these sessions, the participants developed story ideas that explored and critiqued stereotypes of Aboriginal people. Common themes emerging from these brainstorming sessions were later developed during the days at ACMI and created on iPads as moving-images. The themes explored representations of Aboriginal people as welfare cheats, as uneducated, and of skin-color as a marker of so-called 'authentic' Aboriginality. While the intention was for images collected at the museum to inspire their narratives, there was minimal use of this material in the digital stories. Rather, each group focused on using the iMotion timelapse photography app and the McLaren animation/etching app to create staged performances of Aboriginal stereotypes.

The stories created by the participants exposed shared experiences of negative stereotyping and racism (online and offline) that are widely experienced by Aboriginal people (Hogan et al. 2013). The participants then flipped these stereotypes to convey their lived realities of 'being' Aboriginal as a positive experience. All participants chose to be clearly identifiable in their videos where they displayed and performed their Aboriginality, directly challenging negative stereotypes of Aboriginal people.

The experience of working together in teams provided young people with opportunities to support and learn from each other (alongside Tim Church and ACMI facilitators) about the capabilities of mobile devices and apps for film production. The portability of the apps and iPads meant the participants were not dependent on the ACMI studio to further develop their skills and could apply their learning in the 'real' world. However, participants made limited use of the visual material they gathered at the museum. This prompted discussions with participants about how and why images collected from the museum could intersect with their lived experiences, and revealed that opportunities for further contextualization of these images are required before being considered appropriate for their stories.

Intergenerational Knowledge Exchange

Intergenerational knowledge exchange was an important factor in this project, with participants interacting with Elders to discuss protocols and understandings related to the sharing and dissemination of images of cultural artifacts and associated knowledge. This exchange also suggests rea-

sons for the limited use of images taken during the museum visit. The first reason is associated with young people's heightened awareness following their Welcome to the project at the museum by the Elder, Aunty Di Kerr.

Although the participants had permission from the museum to use images from the collections in their digital stories, Aunty Di emphasized the importance of observing cultural protocols and acknowledging the appropriate people when using objects and artifacts made by others, particularly objects made by people from other Aboriginal language groups or tribes. This was highlighted by participants in the focus group discussion:

> *Jody: I do remember Aunty Di talking a lot about permission and how you have to check when you're going to post something online, or use other people's information*
> *Oliver: [Y]ou don't want to be taking other people's stories. You want to make your own, or like, your tribe's dreaming, and your own dreaming. So, it's a little bit weird trying to do someone else's tribe group when you're from another tribe.*

As these quotes imply, ongoing intergenerational knowledge exchange in future workshops would assist youth in exploring their identities and support their cultural learning. This would include what is and is not appropriate to share online, while adults like youth could continue to learn about the technology (boyd 2014; Katz et al. 2014). This also resonates with a decolonizing approach to ethical research, reinforcing Aboriginal knowledge of Aboriginal culture, specifically as a response to the colonial constructions of Aboriginality.

Another reason for participants' limited use of museum material may be associated with the ways Aboriginal young people in southeast Australia experience their identities and culture. This possibility is explored in the next section where the significance of situated learning was revealed as another ethical imperative.

Situated Learning

The importance of learning through situated practices—as the third prong of our ethical framework—resonates with young people's insistence that 'seeing and doing something' through direct experience and observation is essential for reinforcing culture. In southeast Australia many Aboriginal young people are in a process of reconnecting with, and learning about

their cultural heritage, a result of the ongoing effects of the policies of assimilation (AHRC 2011). Accessing information about who you are and where you come from, although potentially enhanced through understanding one's connections to material culture, may be confronting for some young people. For instance, developing digital-visual constructions in relation to museum objects may simply be perceived by youth as reinforcing stereotypes (e.g. 'authentic' southeast Australian Aboriginal culture is old and can only be found in 'museums'), rather than responding to their contemporary ambitions and lifestyles.

In relation to this, it is conceivable that being immersed for a day in a place like the museum may not equate with young people's lived realities, and requires further contextualizing. Hence, future digital storytelling workshops could consider providing experiences throughout the week that resonate with those at the museum, including ongoing contact with Aboriginal artists and curators who could support participants in determining ways for appropriately incorporating images in their stories. Such an approach would promote situated learning while enhancing digital-visual literacy. A situated approach emphasizes the production of knowledge through informal and formal learning that is embedded in 'social practice' and accentuates learning for life (Kral and Schwab 2012: 9). This process also supports experimentation and 'mucking around' and intersects with community-based approaches to learning as 'an integral part of generative social practice in the lived-in world' (Lave and Wenger 1991: 35).

As an ethical imperative, supporting digital-visual literacy among Aboriginal young people through situated learning must be embedded in socially situated responses to image-making. Participants in this project were adamant that seeing the collections at the museum was inspirational and opened up new ways of understanding their culture and identities. It also evoked the complexities of viewing and making objects with cultural significance.

> *Leslie: Seeing something and doing something is a totally different thing. You get different experiences out of the both of them. And I guess for non-Aboriginal people it'd be interesting to see [the museum collections], for us it's a bit different. [The objects and images in the collections are] a bit more personal and… something that we want to reconnect with, to pass on to our family.*

Aaron: [I]f you do build, say the artworks [like the kangaroo tooth necklace] that Maree [Clarke] did, you actually get a deeper connection through that as well. Rather than just filming the whole process and just watching it, if you actually do it as well.

The young people's responses to the museum experience underlined their complex relations to culture and identity, and the importance of situated learning for building cultural knowledge that supports the responsible making of digital images and reinforces contemporary Aboriginalities.

Rethinking the Co-creative Approach

Although the expert technical advice and practical assistance from ACMI was significant in supporting the participants to produce their stories, there remained issues in relation to the overall ambitions of the workshops to enhance young people's capacity to tell stories. The traditional co-creative approach to digital storytelling remains a 'hothouse' environment where facilitators continue to determine the extent of technical interaction participants require for creating their stories. Of most concern are the limited timeframes that this approach imposes, which can influence participant's stories and inadvertently impose the facilitators' own agendas.

The advent of mobile media devices sees shifting parameters around the structure of co-creativity, as control of the technology resides increasingly in the hands of the user. Perhaps a better way of considering the co-creative approach in future workshops would be to position it within the context of situated learning. This includes approaching the workshop as a process that emphasizes the potential for ongoing everyday learning through the use of mobile devices and the interactions with experts that these enable. This could see Aboriginal young people exploring their digital identities across a range of media, developing digital-visual literacy that intersects across old and new ways for sharing stories, and creating visual material that reflects their endeavors to assert and reconnect with their culture. This approach would build on insights from related research that suggests that storytellers' 'well-being and autonomy of voice should be at the center of a project' and that 'reflexive attention to issues of power and a sense of cultural humility are key to excellent facilitation' (Gubrium et al. 2014: 1607).

Conclusion

In this chapter, we have presented an ethical framework for working with Aboriginal young people in digital storytelling workshops. The framework emerged from our experiences of working with young people and a consideration of three key sets of issues: decolonization; the participation gap; and situated learning. These three issues contest the colonial legacy in which images and representative practices were used to control and label Aboriginal people in the past. Ultimately, the workshops sought to promote Aboriginal young people's potential to use the creative capacity of digital technologies to tell their own stories and assert their contemporary identities.

Notes

1. The workshops discussed here form part of the Aboriginal young people and digital storytelling project, funded as an Australian Research Council Linkage Project (2014–2017). Partners in the project are VicHealth, Australian Centre for the Moving Image and Sista Girl Productions. Korin Gamadj Institute at Richmond Football Club is a key supporter of and collaborator in the project, providing recruitment of participants and ongoing mentoring throughout the workshops.
2. Bunjilaka is the Aboriginal Cultural Centre at Museum Victoria.

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PART III

The Ethics of Researching Art and Artful Research

The chapters in this section identify a range of ethical concerns arising from artistic research and practice, the dissemination of visual research and processes of institutional ethics review. Highlighting key tensions that animate the intersection of what sometimes appear to be two totally disparate worlds, art and research, the authors in this section each consider how to evolve an ethically and methodologically sound approach. What emerges is a portrait of ethical norms in flux as the contributions of artists and researchers employing visual and other innovative methods challenge institutional culture and organizations to entertain new conversations.

In Chap. 14, Barbara Bolt identifies salient issues that arise in artistic research. These include questions of what are "research" and "data" in artistic research, when art should be subject to ethical review, what happens when audiences become participants and what responsibilities an audience member may have in an artistic performance. As she argues, there is an inherently vexed relationship between aesthetics and ethics.

In Chap. 15, Katherine Boydell, Carmela Solimine and Siona Jackson take us into the world of dance to examine how artistic modes of research representation impact artists and researchers as well as audiences. Dance offers a powerful visual vocabulary for sharing subjective experiences of mental health but may also lead into "dangerous emotional terrain" for those depicting difficult lived experiences. Thus, strategies to address potentially negative emotional impacts are key in developing collaborative partnerships.

Continuing the focus on the use of visual methods in research dissemination, in Chap. 16, authors Casey Burkholder and Katie MacEntee examine the use of cellphilm methodology as a means for teachers to engage in dialogue and reflection on teacher identity. Cellphilming as an emerging participatory research methodology and their work explores the ethical and methodological complexities of developing a collaborative cellphilm archive in a project with pre-service social studies teachers.

In Chap. 17, Dawn Mannay is also concerned with the ethical challenges that arise with the dissemination of images. Drawing upon her work with mothers and daughters living in a marginalized housing district, she asks when being visible and recognizable may not be practical, possible or ethical, both for participants and the non-consenting others they present in their accounts. This prompts us to consider how to disseminate visual research without the use of images.

In the final two chapters, the focus shifts to tensions as well as opportunities that arise at the nexus of procedural ethics and artistic or other innovative research. In Chap. 18, Lois Klassen identifies the troubled integration of institutional ethical frameworks into sites of research by artists. As she suggests, problems of censorship and "ethics creep" are undercutting productive relationships; such problems may, however, be rectified through adopting a relational framework for critically integrating ethical frameworks into art research.

In Chap. 19, Susan Cox identifies the origins of the adversarial paradigm for ethical review and identifies strategies supporting an alternative paradigm. In this alternative paradigm, research ethics committees, researchers and research participants engage in dialogue and become allies to ensure that research is ethically as well as methodologically sound. In order to bring this paradigm into fruition, it is essential that researchers and research participants share their stories from the field so that we can all learn from our collective experiences.

CHAPTER 14

Whither the Aesthetic Alibi: Ethics and the Challenge of Art as Research in the Academy

Barbara Bolt

Introduction

Traditionally, art has existed outside a formal ethics framework and at least during the twentieth century, artistic freedom was protected by the "aesthetic alibi." Historian Martin Jay describes the aesthetic alibi as a "a special case of freedom of speech, which raises it to a more purified level … what would be libelous or offensive in everyday life is granted special dispensation, if it is understood to take place within the protective shield of an aesthetic frame" (Jay 1998, p. 110–111). The aesthetic alibi is invoked when contributors to public debate argue for the sanctity of a work on the basis that it is "art."

In Australia, the aesthetic alibi has existed in the form of a defence for works of "artistic merit" and work produced for "genuine artistic purposes" against crimes such as obscenity (MacNeill and Bolt 2011). However, the institutionalization of art in the academy has changed the context and the rules for art. The shift in the mode of training artists, dancers, filmmakers, theatre makers and musicians—from professional training as elite practitioners—to an education and research model has had

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significant implications for how artists are trained, how art is framed and how the creative arts are regulated (Baker et al. 2009). At the graduate level, artists have become researchers and creative arts practice has been reframed as artistic research.[1] As artistic researchers, creative artists and their art have become subject to the processes and procedures that oversee all university research including the university's codes of research and the research ethics processes.[2]

For ethics committees overseeing the conduct of research in the academy, the notion of the aesthetic alibi is not a valid rationale for practices that conflict with the fundamental principles set out in the *National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research* (2007), the code that establishes the guidelines for the ethical conduct of research within Australian universities. The mismatch between the values of the artistic community and the values, process and protocols of the research community has proved difficult for both artistic researchers and ethics committees.

This chapter focuses on two case studies of participatory art practice involving the artists and artistic researchers Amy Spiers and Catherine Ryan in order to address some of the vexed issues that have confounded both artists and research ethics committees in this new regime where art is framed as artistic research. What is the "research" in art? When does an audience become a participant in the research and what is their responsibility as a participant? What is data in art, particularly when the event is ephemeral and there appears to be no "data" collection on the responses of the participants? Do ephemeral works, for example, performances and performance actions, qualify as "research" that must be reviewed by an ethics committee? How does an ethics committee deal with the question of beneficence in a field where artistic researchers hold that art's role is to create discomfort and unease? How should artistic researchers address questions of informed consent in this context? Through these case studies, this chapter teases out these questions and proposes some ways in which artistic researchers and ethics committees may understand and address such issues.

Nothing to See Here (Dispersal): A Case Study

In March 2014, two Melbourne artists, Amy Spiers and Catherine Ryan (in collaboration with choreographer and dramaturge Ashley Dyer), staged their work-in-progress *Nothing to See Here (Dispersal)* as part of Melbourne's Festival of Live Art. The work was a response to the "Occupy

Melbourne" protest, part of the global "Occupy" movement that occurred during 2011. "Occupy Melbourne," like elsewhere, resulted in repression by the police. The protest was brutally broken up and the crowds dispersed, leaving empty barricaded spaces of no entry. "Move along, there's nothing to see" became the mantra that the authorities used to divide and separate the protesters and move along anyone else in the orbit of the occupation.

In two staged performances, first in the main hall at North Melbourne Town Hall and a second at the Meat Market art space in Melbourne, Spiers and Ryan adopted the crowd dispersal techniques of the police to choreograph a performative encounter with a regime of power. During the 45-minute performances, the audience-becoming-performers were variously directed, herded, divided, expelled or corralled into cordoned off spaces and denied any possibility of free assembly or movement by the uniformed controllers. These controllers were instructed in and employed the techniques of crowd controllers, security guards, ushers and police to "divide and separate" the audience (Spiers 2014, p. 1–2).

The strategy employed by the artists was inspired by Jacque Rancière's analysis of social control, which posits that political order is not merely maintained by political repression, but rather is effected through strategies of controlling visibility (to see is to believe) and the flow of people in public spaces. As Rancière comments:

> Police intervention in public space is less about interpellating demonstrators than it is about dispersing them. […] The police are above all certitude about what is there, or rather, about what is not there: "Move along, there's nothing to see." The police say there is nothing to see, nothing happening, nothing to be done but to keep moving, circulating; they say that the space of circulating is nothing but the space of circulation. (Rancière 2010, p. 37)

In the case of any social or political rupture, says Gene Flenady, the "visibility of force always effaces itself in the production of invisibility" (Flenady 2014).

By making visible such forces, Spiers and Ryan aimed to deconstruct and reveal the mechanisms by which political order is maintained in "public" spaces. The means they chose not just to produce a performance that illustrated a sense of unease, but rather one that provoked and enacted unease and discomfort in its audience; they invited an audience into a space and then denied them the very right of free assembly. Whilst

audience members were allowed to leave voluntarily, the mechanisms of control made that exercise of freedom a difficult choice to make. Here the politics of aesthetics came face-to-face with questions of ethics.

The artists' concerns to reveal the operations of repressive force came into conflict with ethical principles of informed consent and the participant's right to withdraw from participation in the project at any time.

There is a very critical issue that faces us in thinking about *Nothing to See Here (Dispersal)*. Amy Spiers and Catherine Ryan are artists and this work was created in the context of the artworld. In adopting a dissensus model of practice, where their art operates as a site of resistance and critique, Spiers and Ryan are committed to creating discomfort and unease in their audience. In the artworld, aesthetic and ethical judgements about art are made by art critics, art viewers and the general public (Bolt et al. 2010, p. 10). However, Spiers is also an artistic researcher who is engaged in artistic research, and in this context it is an ethics committee who will make the final determination about the ethical appropriateness of a research project. What are the ethical and aesthetic stakes involved such a performative work when art becomes research?

In Australia, all research, including artistic research, is conducted in accord with *The National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research* (2007) (more commonly referred to as *The National Statement*), which establishes a set of working guidelines for the ethical conduct for research within Australian Universities. It is not meant to provide a prescribed list of do's and don'ts but rather to set up an ethos or set of principles that underpins the way that researchers who are engaged in research with human subjects approach their research. The preamble to the *National Statement* provides the rational for codifying a set of ethical principles to oversee the relationship between researchers and the research participants. One of the first principles set out in the preamble is that of trust between participants and a researcher. A second relates to questions of public good:

> Research often involves public interaction between people that serves a public good. There is, therefore, a public responsibility for seeing that these interactions are ethically acceptable to the Australian community. (*National Statement*, p. 4)

The question of public good comes under the principle of beneficence. Beneficence involves an ethical judgement about whether "the likely benefits of the research must justify any risks of harm or discomfort to the participants, to the wider community, or to both" (*National Statement*, p. 13). In the academic context at least, researchers (and this includes artistic researchers) should:

- design the research to minimize the risks of *harm or discomfort* to participants,
- clarify for participants the *potential benefits and risks of the research* and
- care for the welfare of the participants in the research context. (National Statement, p. 13, my emphasis)

Here-in lies a conflict between the notions of beneficence as defined by the code and those recognized by the artistic community. We have seen from our earlier discussion of *Nothing to See Here (Dispersal)* that the question of harm of discomfort is a much more complex issue than at first appears. What is the value of art to a society if it doesn't confront the key issues that threaten fundamental human rights? What if art becomes so comfortable that it no longer provides a site of resistance or provokes artistic shock?[3] Thus, the question of minimizing risk and discomfort that is inherent in the notion of beneficence becomes a key point of tension when artists become engaged in artistic research and their research becomes subject to the guidelines of *The National Statement*.

In 2011, Spiers first encountered the complexities of research ethics whilst studying for a Masters of Fine Arts (MFA) at the Victorian College of the Arts, at the University of Melbourne. As the MFA is a research degree, Spiers was required to abide by the rules of conduct in research in the University and gain ethics approval for particular aspects of the research project, since the research design involved human subjects as participants/subjects in the research. She applied for ethics approval for a number of instruction-based and performance works including the work, *Say Nothing*.[4] *Say Nothing* is an instructional artwork that was exhibited as part of a public exhibition at the Margaret Lawrence Gallery at the Victorian College of the Arts in 2011. The instructions for the work were set up as a wall text next to a space where the work "would happen" through the duration of the exhibition.

The instructions were very simple. In order to become a participant in the work, visitors were asked to:

> write their mobile phone number on the gallery wall, with no other identifying personal information. In exchange, they must take a note of the number that was left by the participant before them, and then cross it out with a black marker. Only one phone number should be available on the gallery wall at a time. The participant is then instructed to call the number when convenient, and say nothing. On answering the phone to this silent caller, the receiver is also directed to not exchange any words. Instead both participants are asked to spend a little time on the line together, hanging up when either decides they've had enough. The aim is to create a private one-on-one experience that is meant to frustrate the participants' desire to connect with one another. There is no documentation of the calls except for the effaced numbers on the gallery wall. (Spiers 2011, p. 36–37)

Say Nothing required that the participants "put their trust to the test" (Spiers 2011, p. 36) by allowing a stranger to take their number and follow the instructions. Participants were also to follow the instructions given; ring the number that they had written down and say nothing.

In its response to the ethics application that Spiers submitted for *Say Nothing*, the Victorian College of the Arts Human Ethics Advisory Group (HEAG) sent the following response concerning the proposed artwork:

> The HEAG has significant concerns about the (…) implications for participants in this project (…). The ethical principle of beneficence is key here as there could be significant issues should someone take another person's phone number and use it for purposes other than those outlined in the project (...) It is extremely difficult to ensure that there will definitely be no harassment of participants by other participants – this is a risk that is difficult to control or manage.[5]

Whilst it is often said that risk management issues guide the decisions of ethics committees, their decisions are always underpinned by the fundamental principles of the code, including those of beneficence and trust.[6] In her assessment of the project, Spiers made the following comments revealing that "trust" was at issue:

> *Say Nothing* strongly evoke an imagined sense of the silent calls, even if the viewer decides not to partake in the experience (…). The silence and

> non-documented nature of the calls suggests something powerfully enigmatic, even to the non-participant. Even the viewers who do not participate are implicated in the provocation of *Say Nothing,* producing an intriguing effect, as the viewer realises they do not possess the trust to become involved. (Spiers 2011, p. 38)

For her, the work addressed fundamental questions about human relations of trust and the capacity of an art project to trouble and test such questions.

Spiers' thinking about the capacity of art to "trouble and test" concurs with a position, strongly held in the arts community, that the speculative and provocative nature of art (and art *as* research) enables it to become a site of engagement for ethical debate and hence gives art the ability to illuminate the ethical issues of our times. In a 2009 study of the attitude of artistic researchers towards formal ethical review processes in the academy, respondents expressed concern that the requirement for ethics review challenged the freedom of art to play a critical activist role (Bolt et al. 2010, p. 16). Respondents, particularly from the visual arts, argued that art can be a site of resistance and plays an important role in testing and troubling society's ethical and moral boundaries.[7] "Art acts as a provocation; it operates as the conscience of a society, it produces discomfort and brings its audience into crisis" (Bolt et al. 2010, p. 16). For many artists this discomfort and crisis is precisely art's benefit, both to the participants and to the wider community, whilst for an ethics committee such discomfort may be deemed an unacceptable risk. In this context, the aesthetic alibi no longer acts as a defence as two notions of beneficence collide as aesthetic judgement meets ethical judgement. How does the artistic researcher and the ethics committee address this tension?

In their study, "Human Research Ethics in Practice: Deliberative Strategies, Processes and Perceptions" (2009), researchers Lynn Gillam, Marilys Guillemin, Annie Bolitho and Doreen Rosenthal investigated how researchers and ethics committee members address the "ethical appropriateness" of research methodologies. They identified "imaginative identification" as a strategy for guiding ethical judgement on such questions (Gillam et al. 2009, p. 07.7). It involves putting yourself in the shoes of another person, of being able to empathize or imagine what it would be like if you were the one who was subject to a particular situation or practice. How would you feel if this was done to you (Gillam et al. 2009, p. 07.7)? However, there are several issues at stake in using imaginative

identification as a way of assessing the "ethical appropriateness" of an artistic research project, particularly one that tests the artistic notion of beneficence against the *National Code's* definition of beneficence. Firstly, in imaginative identification, there subsists an assumption of shared values. As a consequence, as Gillam et al. point out that the researcher may "bring along their own values preferences and experiences when imagining what it would be like for the other person" (Gillam et al. 2009, p. 07.7).

Secondly, what if an encounter with a work of art is beyond imagining? What then? The French philosopher, Jean-François Lyotard, tells us that in such encounters the imagination fails, producing a "kind of cleavage with the subject between what can be conceived and what can be imagined." (Lyotard 1984, p. 40). In this raw state, or intensification of being, all thought is disarmed. Further, he proposes that says that in such an encounter, "art abandons … (any) identifying role in relation to the receiving community" (Lyotard 1984, p. 41). Thus, the aim of the work of art is not to please its receiving community or bring it "into a process of identification" but rather to provide a shock to the senses (Lyotard 1984, p. 39). This "shock," he claims, provides the foundations of the transformative power of art. These are the stakes for an artist and, by virtue of their proximity in a performance, the audience-becoming-participant.

The Ethical and Aesthetic Stakes When Art Becomes Research

This brings us back to the questions that were raised at the outset of this essay: What are the ethical and aesthetic stakes involved in such performative works when art becomes research? *Say Nothing* was part of a research project undertaken within the academy. It occurred under the mantle of "artistic research" and Spiers was required to address the question of whether she needed to gain ethics approval before she could proceed with the project. This contrasted with *Nothing to See Here (Dispersal)* which occurred outside the context of the academy. However, given the growth in artistic research within the academy, increasingly the questions raised by such performances need to be addressed by artistic researchers, ethics committees and the academy.

Firstly, artistic researchers graduate into the artworld where the community and not the ethics committee will be the arbiter of efficacy and the ethics of the work. Artists need to be prepared for this encounter

and have the courage to pursue artistic research that makes a difference. There is evidence that artistic research students "self-censor" and avoid doing provocative research during their candidature to avoid having to do ethics. This raises critical questions for artists, ethics committees and the academy.[8] If art is to be a site of engagement for ethical debate, then both the artistic researcher and ethics committees need the ethical know-how to deal with the strategies that art uses and the issues that may arise.[9]

Secondly, ethics committees are much more familiar with and understand what constitutes "data" in traditional qualitative and quantitative research methodologies. However, they are often mystified by this question in artistic research. Here I would like to return to the instructional work *Say Nothing*. The University ethics department ruled that the work was not technically research since Spiers "was not retaining any 'data" and hence was not subject to the ethics process (Spiers 2011, p. 37). However, the photographic documentation of *Say Nothing* persists. Not only does it now form data that can be interrogated and analysed, but the photographic documentation allows anyone of us to decipher the telephone numbers, ring them and "say nothing." Similarly, in "ephemeral" performance artworks, such as *Lips of Thomas* (1975) a controversial performance work where Marina Abromovic put her own life at risk, the video and photographic documentation becomes data for analysis. In other words, artistic performances are *both* events with effects *and* data.

Thirdly, discomfort and dis-ease are central to art's potency and its capacity to move people. Instead of avoiding the issue, artistic researchers and ethics committees need to be open to the problems and possibilities of the research and work together to establish how to deal with the potential effects and side-effects of the research. There are existing protocols in the arts to mitigate against unexpected and unwarranted shocks, for example, through warnings posted at entrances to exhibitions or theatres, leaflets and flyers distributed at events and, in Australia at least, a national film classification scheme. Through these existing protocols, there is a sense in which entering a space of a performance or event with such forewarnings constitutes informed consent. Here audiences become responsible for their engagement with artworks.

In artistic research, and increasingly in the public realm of the artworld, the aesthetic alibi is no longer a form of defence that can be invoked by artists who avoid questions of harm or the risk of harm through the work. Like all researchers, artistic researchers are required to address the question of harm or risk of harm to the participants or audience-becoming-

participants. In adopting a dissensus model of practice, where their art operates as a site of resistance and critique, Spiers and Ryan are committed to creating discomfort and unease in their audience and whether as artistic researchers in the academy or artists in the artworld. They are critical of much socially engaged art which adopts a consensus model which they consider has been adopted by authorities to mitigate dissension and paper over social problems. Spiers comments that "problems need to be thought (and fought)" (Spiers 2014, p. 1–2). If this is the central principle according to which a practice operates, how does the artist negotiate this tension in the academy?

Harm or the risk of harm can be an unavoidable part of the research process and to judiciously eliminate all risk from research projects, apart from being impossible, would produce a situation where research becomes neutered; inadequate to address the complex issues that face us living in the world. This goes as much for clinical trials in science and medicine as it does for art. Yet there is a difference that has been identified through this article: In clinical trials, the risk of harm is not the purpose of the trial, whilst in certain participatory and performance art practices, the risk of harm or discomfort may be one of the aims of the work. This is true of *Nothing to See Here (Dispersal)*. Is there any common ground that may help in the ethical review of projects across fields? Though the possible adverse effects experienced in a clinical trial of a new drug are of a different order from the possible harm or discomfort created through an engagement with art, there are similar principles that can be considered in an ethics review and these coalesce around the question and capacity of the participant to give of consent: Is consent both informed and meaningful? Have the participants been informed of the possibility of the risks involved in participating in the research and do they have the capacity to make a meaningful and informed decision about consent? Are they able to withdraw consent or exit from the performance "without explanation or prejudice" (University of Melbourne Consent Form, HREC 090001 Version 1)? *Nothing to See Here (Dispersal)* revealed the tensions in a very public way. The audience engaged willingly and enthusiastically in the work they bought into the work's logic. However, in this participatory work, the issue of withdrawing consent was a more problematic one: The choice to leave or not was a key element to the work's structure and it was difficult for the participants to leave if they wanted to or stay if they wanted to.

In this essay I have discussed the rift between artistic researchers and the ethics process. I have demonstrated that, with their allegiance to the aes-

thetics of the sublime and to notions of dissensus, many artists and artistic researchers have a different understanding of beneficence to that which is embodied in *The National Statement*. This artistic vision is underpinned by the notion that art's beneficence lies in its capacity to create trouble, discomfort and dis-ease. The question that this raises is *not* whether it is ethical to create discomfort but whether it is ethical *not to do so*. The question for both artistic researcher and ethics committees is how this can be negotiated to minimize harm to participants but still maintain the power and efficacy of the art. There is no point if art loses its power as a site of engagement for ethical debate. Artistic research must maintain its capacity to illuminate some of the critical ethical issues of our epoch.

Notes

1. For a discussion of *how* art is research, see Barbara Bolt (2014) "Beyond Solipsism in Artistic Research: The Artwork and the Work of Art," *Material Inventions: Applying Creative Arts Research*, London: I.B.Tauris.
2. There has been a rapid growth in postgraduate education for the creative arts across the world. At the time of writing, some countries offering research higher degrees in the creative arts do not subject artistic research to the ethics process.
3. In her article, "On 'Shock': The Artistic Imagination of Benjamin and Brecht," *Mara Polgovsky* Ezcurra (2012) proposes that shock is a central concept of modernist aesthetics. She cites Walter Benjamin as a key exponent. *Contemporary Aesthetics*, http://www.contempaesthetics.org/newvolume/pages/article.php?articleID=659.
4. Instructional artworks are associated with conceptual art, a movement in art that gives precedence to ideas and concepts over visual aesthetics or material concerns. The artworks are constructed by simply following the textual description provided by the artist.
5. Email correspondence between the HEAG and Amy Spiers, 26 July 2011, quoted in Spiers 2011, p. 37.
6. The VCA took advice from the University of Melbourne ethics office, which, after due consideration, ruled that the work was not technically "research" since the Spiers "was not retaining any 'data,'" and hence the project proceeded as it had been designed (Spiers 2011, p. 37).
7. Whilst it could be argued that "relationship" replaced "shock" as a key value in socially engaged art, the contemporary critique of con-

sensus and the commitment of many socially engaged artists to Ranciere's theoretical work on dissensus as a political strategy and alternative to consensus has rekindled an allegiance to "shock."

8. A pilot study into the perception of the ethics process amongst academics in the creative arts at the University of Melbourne in 2009 revealed that research students tended to shift their research to avoid having to negotiate ethics approval. See B. Bolt, R. Vincs, R. Alsop, M. Sierra, and G. Kett, *Research Ethics and the Creative Arts*, 2010, p. 19.
9. For a discussion of ethical know-how, see B Bolt, K. MacNeil and P. Ednie Brown (2014) "Creative Practice, Research Ethics and the Doctoral Thesis," *Doctoral Writing in the Creative and Performing Arts: The researcher/practitioner nexus*, UK, Libri, pp. 79–97.

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CHAPTER 15

Visually Embodying Psychosis: The Ethics of Performing Difficult Experiences

Katherine M. Boydell, Carmela Solimine, and Siona Jackson

Introduction

Drawing upon artistic expression as a knowledge translation strategy to generate and disseminate research impacts health practitioners, patients, artists, policy makers and the general public (Boydell et al. 2012). Arts-based knowledge translation involves performative, visual and/or literary arts and offers audience members an opportunity to engage with the work in an embodied manner (Archibald et al. 2014). The arts are used in research to enhance awareness and knowledge of illness experience (Boydell 2011a); the arts in research can engage and empower participants to express emotions and acquire insight (Boydell 2011b). Arts-based knowledge translation strategies often have immediacy and an affective power that can evoke strong reactions as a result of engaging with emotionally charged material (Gray et al. 2003). Despite the power of the

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arts to share evidence-based research and reduce the knowledge to practice gap, there remain unexplored ethical challenges. One central ethical challenge is the notion of "dangerous emotional terrain," coined by Gray et al. (2003), which refers to the potential of using the arts in the research process to have negative effects on the individuals performing and on the audience members viewing (Goldner et al. 2014; Boydell et al. 2015).

In a recent publication outlining ethical guidelines for visual research, Cox et al. (2014) note the importance of reducing the harm that may be experienced by researchers and members of the audience who are privy to the stories shared via visual methods. They recognize that these narratives are frequently highly personal with the potential to both evoke and provoke. Cox et al. (2014) note that despite the enhanced sense of agency that sharing stories often produces, there is the potential for distress for researchers and audiences who are faced with powerful imagery on difficult topics. Whilst this is certainly true, there is also the potential distress experienced by those who perform research results via dramatic performance or dance. However, there is little literature that explores the impact of using the arts on the actors/performers/health care consumers who embody the lived experiences of a health issue (Boydell, Gladstone, Volpe et al. 2012; Sinding et al. 2006; Gray et al. 2003). This chapter draws upon our recent research-based dance project to focus on a specific ethical issue, namely, the impact of embodying experiences of psychosis on the choreographer, dancers and musician involved in the study. Although not the focus of this chapter, we acknowledge previous work focused on the ethical challenges of such performative work on the audience (Cox and Boydell 2015; Boydell 2011a, b).

Theoretical Framework

We draw on concepts of embodied research, based on the phenomenon of the "lived body" and "lived experience" which suggests that knowledge has to do with the lived experience (Todres 2007). Embodied inquiry focuses on the relationship between language and the body (Winters 2008; Andres-Hyman et al. 2007; Thomson and Jaque 2012). An actor embodies the physical life and emotions of the character; the initial task of an actor is similar to that of a psychologist/physician taking a history, understanding experiences and behaviors to acquire cognitive understanding of patient well-being (Thomson and Jaque 2012; Colantonio et al. 2008). After researching the character's emotions and life experiences, the

actor embodies the character in dance or theatrical performance (Andres-Hyman et al. 2007; Thomson and Jaque 2012). Embodying conflicted characters has the potential to emotionally affect the actor outside the theatrical role (Thomson and Jaque 2012). Emotionally difficult roles involving the embodiment of mental illness or psychosis may pose psychological risks to the performer (Jackson et al. 2006). It is important to ask whether actors are more vulnerable to performing difficult roles, and whether the embodiment of emotionally difficult roles impacts the actor/dancer more than other forms of art.

Dance is a powerful means of interpreting lived experience (Boydell 2011a, b) and, according to Winters (2008), is reported to have a greater effect on the audience and artist than other forms of art. Dance allows the dancers to use their body to express pain, emotions and gain a deeper level of insight at the unconscious level (Winters 2008). Dance therapy has also been found to have a greater therapeutic effect for the patient than other forms of arts-based therapy due to the stimulation of neurological areas related to emotion and memory (Boydell et al. 2012a; Winters 2008). The combination of body movements and facial expressions in dance therapy enhance emotional expression and release stress (Winters 2008). Few studies have examined the effect on the healthy dancer after the embodiment of painful and angry emotions as part of the performance.

A Research-Based Dance Project

Given these findings regarding the link between overall well-being and performing/embodying difficult experiences, we reflect on our use of a dance performance to disseminate empirical research based on a case study of pathways to mental health care from the perspectives of youth experiencing psychosis (Boydell 2011a, b; CIHR 2010). When we began to co-create the dance, we realized the challenges associated with the topic of psychosis, and the genre of dance to communicate the experience of young people (Boydell et al. 2012). The genre of dance was selected to explore knowledge physically, emotionally and mentally, allowing the audience to enter into the experience. Todres's (2007) work on embodied inquiry that attends to the relationship between language and the experiencing body was extremely important to us throughout the process of co-creation (Boydell 2011b). We asked ourselves what difference it makes to co-create embodied narratives to share the lived experience of psychosis.

Our reflections on the impact of embodying the experience of seeking help for mental health issues draw on audio-recorded conversations between our research team and dance choreographer, Siona Jackson. Siona describes dance as a unique visual form that allows the audience to become engaged and emotionally stimulated. The use of dance incorporates music, visual aids and body movements. The music, critical to the dance performance, is created and adapted to the dancer's body movements. The use of facial expressions and body movements is very powerful. Sinclair (2015) encompasses this notion in her statement that "the researcher/performer's body in physical and symbolic action, within an aesthetic space, contributes to the production of understanding, through an embodied knowing" (p. 90).

The dancers in our project read anonymized summary transcripts of in-depth interviews with young people, listened to the music and represented an emotional event in character, all the while attempting to be 'true' to the individual experience and without misrepresenting the research data. It was critical that experienced mature dancers were auditioned; dancers who had previous experience with emotionally difficult roles and who had a wide variety of performative experience were specifically selected, as it was assumed they would be better equipped to handle difficult content.

Dance performers were engaged as co-researchers and were intimately involved in co-creation of the performance. This included participating in research-creative team meetings to discuss the findings and exploring ways in which to highlight central themes. Themes were both universal, depicting the pathways to mental health care identified across all narratives, as well as unique individual stories. Dancers displayed an intensity of wanting to "get the story right" and were extremely concerned about authentically depicting experiences of psychosis. The team worked together over six months, reading and discussing the transcripts. This represented an intense and much longer period of training than is the norm.

The music was created with each dance posture; the music producer was also provided with summaries from the case studies and he created an original score based on the words of our participants. The music was then adapted to the dance postures and movements on stage. The use of "spoken word" along with body movements reflected each individual's journey in their pathway to mental health care. The final performance represented key themes that described help-seeking in first-episode psychosis, and has been presented to thousands of people internationally, including academics, clinicians, policy makers, educators, students, and community

members (CIHR 2010). A condensed film clip of the performance is available at www.katherineboydell.com.

The authorship team engaged in a conversation about the impact of performing and embodying an emotionally difficult role on a dancer. We were aware that dancers embodying emotionally difficult roles such as psychosis are likely to experience negative sequelae, such as emotional stress, insomnia, or depression. Siona, our dance choreographer, noted that insomnia often occurred in dancers and is believed to be associated with the stress and intensity of the training process. All the dancers were fully dedicated to training and production. Roles were emotionally exhausting because the dance movements and reading the case study summaries were both physically and emotionally demanding. The dancers were intent on representing and honoring the lives of young people experiencing psychosis to the best of their abilities, and were extremely concerned about the possibility of misrepresentation.

Choreographing roles for academia was noted to be very different than typical productions for entertainment. The artistic team has much more work to do, learning about the research project, its specific intent, what the research team wanted to convey, and the best way to do that. The performance was created based upon the intended audience(s); this necessitated choreographic changes based on each audience group, which resulted in extended rehearsal sessions to accommodate these adaptations. For example, when performing in secondary schools to students, changes were made to the dance to interest young people. The production was reduced to 10 minutes, and featured hip-hop and pop music. For young people in particular, short performances were more effective in sustaining attention and having impact than longer performances. However, short performances were more challenging to choreograph due to the complexity of representing two particular cases in addition to the universal aspects of the help-seeking process that occurred across all interviews. Further, the continual adaptation to new stage settings was difficult because the "stage" was often in a noisy or cluttered area such as a school cafeteria, as opposed to a theatrical stage. This required the dancers to adapt and maintain composure and poise during many distractions. These changes had an impact on the dancers, who had to rehearse different choreography based on the audience as well adapting to new performance contexts.

The emotional role most difficult to choreograph was empathy. It is important as a choreographer (and researcher) to represent each particular narrative/story and reflect the individual experience of help-seeking of the

participant. In order for a dancer to embody empathy, they must understand the emotions and experiences of the young person with psychosis. This required a great deal of time, understanding and reflecting on each of the case study summaries. The research team did not anticipate the need of the dancers to have more information to prepare for their roles and performances; the summaries of each young person prepared for them were often not enough, as they wanted to know much more about each young person in order to depict their experiences.

Strategies to Address Dangerous Emotional Terrain

We generated two strategies to address the emotional effect on dancers embodying psychosis and other difficult experiences. First, reflexive practice should be an essential component, offering opportunities for continued discussion throughout, and not just at the beginning and end of a project. One successful strategy for us was the work we engaged in individually with each case; dancers were encouraged to reflect on their own life experiences, as well as the emotions each young person was experiencing. Key words and emotions were identified; and then, in a group situation, the dancers and choreographers discussed the emotions and impact that might have on an individual's life. Because the dancers worked so closely with each other over an extended period of rehearsal time, a comfort level with each other emerged and personal stories became a key component of the process.

Second, creation of a safe and supportive environment via collaborative partnership between the research team and performers is critical. Dance is a social art, where dancers are interacting together in a team during rehearsals and performances; therefore, they become a "family." During our performance, we had a strong support group from the choreographer and music producer, as well as the researchers present during rehearsal and productions. Our research team explained the study objectives in detail. A comprehensive guideline of the overall purpose of the research and specific objectives was outlined to the choreographers and dancers prior to their involvement. It also helped that there were always researchers present and available to talk to any of the dancers on a one-on-one basis about any questions they might have about the study, and particularly, the illness itself. Ongoing group discussions created a supportive and safe environment in which to discuss personal experiences; we all felt comfortable acknowledging our vulnerable experiences. Dancers were never personally asked whether or not they were experiencing any difficulties; rather, a cohesive supportive environment was created where they were a

part of the greater dance family, supported by the entire dance team and validated to perform for education and awareness of mental health in general and psychosis specifically.

Discussion

Research ethics have been developed to protect research participants from harm (Gray et al. 2003). Ethical research guidelines include avoiding physical and emotional harm and protecting research participants' anonymity and confidentiality (Guillemin and Gillam 2004). However, researchers must maintain a critical awareness of emergent ethical dilemmas and explicitly raise the issues with participants as an integral part of the research (Goldner et al. 2011). Researchers can incorporate arts-based methods of dissemination by attempting to represent authentic patient experiences and incorporating aesthetic qualities to the artistic performance (Boydell, Volpe, Cox et al. 2012). Greater awareness and commitment to the unique ethical implications of arts-based health research has been advocated (Boydell, Volpe, Cox et al. 2012).

We draw on Hunt et al.'s (2014) work on the ethics of an engaged presence as a model. The model recognizes shared humanity and acknowledges limits and risks; it comprises two orientations—introspection and reflective practice, and collaboration and partnership. Although this model applies to expatriate health care professionals, we believe that it is equally applicable to artistic performers.

We address the need to be reflexive with dancers on an ongoing basis. This supports the work of Guillemin and Gillam (2004) who argue that reflexivity is intricately bound up in the ethical practice of research, and should be viewed as an active, ongoing process throughout the entire research enterprise. They note that engaging in reflexivity as a central component of research practice includes recognizing the ethical components of the everyday (or microethics), being sensitive to "ethically important moments" in research practice and strategizing with a response to ethical concerns that may arise. We extend the notion of reflecting on how research might affect research participants to include reflecting on how the research affects the performers throughout the project.

Given our experience working with the creative team, artists working on arts-based performative research projects should be informed of the potential negative effects of embodying difficult and traumatizing experiences prior to project involvement (Gray et al. 2003). Evidence suggests that risk of emotional fatigue and dissociation are manifest in healthy actors

embodying emotionally difficult roles (Seton 2006). During performances the researchers and choreographer should consider encouraging mentorship and emotional support for actors. Our experience in co-creating a research-based dance performance to disseminate empirical research findings and our subsequent reflections allowed us to identify strategies to incorporate in future work in this area. Ongoing, supportive relational networks between the research team and the performers are critical to the creation of a safe and supportive environment. It is essential to provide adequate preparatory material for dancers and associated cast, including an explanation of the research and the role they are expected to embody and perform. Rossiter et al. (2008) provide a good example of ways in which they incorporated knowledge translation at the outset of their project, ensuring that in the early stages of rehearsal, actors were informed of the research process, and began to experiment with methods of translating themes from the research into scenes and narratives. It is important to ensure a high degree of sensitivity to experiences of performers, to better understand the negative and positive impacts of engagement in this work. Lafreniere et al. (2013) noted that tension associated with balancing both negative and positive impacts might pose difficulties to researchers and artists working on such projects. It is also important to be explicit regarding ways to access the necessary supports and services to resolve any difficulties encountered in embodying difficult emotions and experiences. The importance of reflexive practice cannot be underestimated as it represents a central feature of ethics in practice. We acknowledge the implications of this work for ethics review committees, who are likely unfamiliar with some of the unique ethical challenges associated with performing data in this way. There is no need to "reinvent the wheel"—excellent work has begun with the publication of ethical guidelines for visual methods (Cox et al. 2014). It is also critical to provide appropriate guidance to Research Ethics Boards that, as researchers, we have considered issues unique to engaging in this work and have ways to address them.

Given the paucity of literature in this area, there is a need to address and assess the impacts, both positive and negative, of artists' involvement in arts-based health research projects. Although this chapter does not focus on the rewards of embodying difficult lived experiences and the ways in which they might intersect with, and inform, the challenges and potential harms, there is a need to do so. We follow the lead of other academics (Lafreniere and Cox 2012) who have assessed the impact of arts-based performances as research dissemination tools. We propose asking performers open-ended questions about the effects, both positive and

negative, of their presentation/performance on their understanding of the topic, the specific emotions generated, questions arising, and prompts leading to altered understanding of, or opinions about, their participation. We concur with Lafreniere et al. (2013) who state that in arts-based health projects, "researchers should ask participants how they are impacted by research, or else they are left with guesses, conjectures and hunches" (p. 28). We would extend this to include the performers themselves.

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CHAPTER 16

Exploring the Ethics of the Participant-Produced Archive: The Complexities of Dissemination

Casey Burkholder and Katie MacEntee

Introduction

Cellphilming (cellphones + filming = cellphilming) involves participants producing short videos (usually between 1 and 5 minutes) using cellphones. Cellphilm method has developed out of work conducted in South Africa by Dockney et al. (2010), and is identified as a growing participatory research trend (MacEntee, Burkholder & Schwab-Cartas 2016; Mitchell et al. 2013). Research accounts describing the methods of cellphilm production are becoming available, highlighting cellphilms' potential in resource-limited areas, schools, and for use with teachers and learners (Mitchell et al. 2015). However, there is a paucity of research that considers the ethical challenges of working with the participant-produced video products, as well as how and where these products are stored and shared (Park et al. 2008). Responding to this gap, we refer to research that we conducted with three female and three male pre-service social studies teachers at the University of Prince Edward Island (UPEI) when we sought to construct a digital space for participants to create, share, and respond to each other's cellphilms about learning to teach history and their developing professional identities.

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The chapter explores the benefits of working with the participant-produced archive for pre-service teacher education, and clarifies some of the ethical challenges present in employing YouTube as a digital archival space. Working within a participatory research framework leads us to ask how the participatory archive extends beyond the life of cellphilm projects and how we might encourage further participant engagement with visual methods in teaching and research.

The Cellphilm Archive Project

The cellphilm archive project began as a course assignment in Casey's Secondary Social Studies Teaching Methods class at UPEI. The class was comprised of pre-service teachers who were in the process of obtaining their Bachelor of Education degree through a one-year post-undergraduate degree program. Casey asked each student to create a one-minute cellphilm that responded to the prompt, 'Our Spaces/Our Selves: Exploring our sense of self, belonging and citizenship'. The students also viewed some example cellphilms, made by a group of pre-service elementary school teachers from McGill University, Canada (and Casey's former students). The process of viewing the previous students work introduced the UPEI group to various cellphilm genres as well as a YouTube-based digital archive of teacher-produced cellphilms. The assignment sought to encourage the pre-service teachers to consider their developing professional identities as teachers, as well as to put their own histories and experiences into a broader understanding of Prince Edward Island's secondary social studies curricula. In particular, the cellphilm production encouraged pre-service teachers to 'speak back' to the curricula and assert themselves as knowledgeable community members (Mitchell et al. 2013, 1).

Students created their cellphilms (from brainstorming to filming to editing) during class time. The students then uploaded their cellphilms to their pre-existing individual YouTube channels. The participants decided during the uploading process if their cellphilms were listed publically on YouTube and therefore searchable by the general public, or unlisted, and hidden from public viewing. Either way, by sending Casey a direct YouTube link to the cellphilm, she was able to access the videos. From these direct links, Casey dedicated one class with the UPEI students to view and respond to their productions. Casey created a YouTube playlist on her own YouTube channel, which allowed her to easily find and refer to the cellphilms in the future. After watching the collected cellphilms

together, the class discussed and compared the issues and themes that were explored.

After the class ended, Casey approached Katie as a 'critical friend' (Costa and Kalick 1994, 49) familiar with the cellphilm method (MacEntee 2015a; Using cellphones to discuss et al. 2016) to discuss the development of the participatory archive. Together they discussed the significance of using YouTube as a cellphilm archive. Casey reported the benefits of the technology for inspiring teacher reflectivity, but also lamented the potential problematic relationship with using an established online server, such as YouTube, for educational purposes. Given the proliferation of cellphones and social media in people's everyday lives, we recognized the potential for both cellphilming and participatory digital archiving as valuable pedagogical practices. With this in mind, in this chapter, we interrogate related questions: How have participants interacted with the digital archive? Are there ethical concerns in using YouTube to archive the digital material that is produced by participants/students? How might cellphilm method expand our understanding of participatory archiving?

Participatory Visual Research

We note that participatory action research (PAR) does not necessarily employ visual methods, and participatory visual research (PVR) methodologies do not necessarily lead to action. PVR has nonetheless been strongly influenced by PAR approaches (Wheeler 2012). Visual methods, including participatory video, have been popularized in social science research as they are seen to relate and draw on popular visual culture, as well as 'the concern for embodiment, the sensory and the affective' (Rose 2014, 30). The acceptance of visual methods in social science research has also generated claims surrounding the emancipatory nature of the participatory video process.

Questions about the inherent emancipatory claims of the participatory video process have been raised elsewhere by Milne et al. (2012). What is it about the participatory video process that challenges existing power structures? Taking up this question in her 2011 book, *Doing Visual Research*, Mitchell suggests that the process of constructing a video is helpful in allowing participants to acknowledge difficult subject matter in response to a particular community issue. Newman (2014) has explored the history of video (from film to digital) as a subversive medium as it appears to be more authentic and user-driven than film or television, which makes

it more threatening to existing power structures. With video, dialogue about community issues can be the focus of the visual product. Because participants are guided through the processes of brainstorming ideas, writing, storyboarding, filming, editing, scoring their videos, and reviewing their productions through each of its stages and incarnations, the participants are centrally involved in the process of knowledge production from the beginning to the dissemination of its visual products (Gubrium and Harper 2013). As Mitchell (2011, 89) states, 'each frame [in the video] is considered and reconsidered [by participants]. Nothing is accidental'. The significance of this method of construction is that the participants are engaged in each step of the process. PV, however, has been critiqued for relying on costly technical equipment and specialized editing skills that promote dependence on researchers to realize stories and this potentially exacerbates power inequalities between researchers and research participants (Mitchell et al. 2015).

Cellphilming

Commentators argue that new media technologies are democratizing the process of media production as they encourage DIY (Do It Yourself) media making, particularly in reference to young people's often prolific online practices, which are argued to support and challenge traditional media structures (Buckingham 2009; Lewis et al. 2010). While cellphones are a constant presence in many people's lives, using cellphones as tools in PVR has only more recently been recognized for their contributions to visual methodologies. For example, Dockney and Tomaselli (2009) recognize the potential of using cellphilms in community-based media production by disseminating the videos from phone-to-phone, over the Internet, or projected on screens in order to stimulate dialogue. In their work on the use of cellphones as a pedagogical tool, Mitchell et al. (2013) also realized that the ubiquitous presence of cellphones in the lives of the teacher-research participants presented opportunities for using cellphones as a resource in teaching and learning. In particular, this research highlights how watching cellphilms stimulated conversation and prompted the teachers to make their own cellphilms in response to issues within their communities. This process of 'speaking back' (Mitchell et al. 2013, 1) encouraged teachers to think more critically and reflectively about their roles as teachers. Using cellphilms as a pedagogical tool in collaborative tasks with other teachers, and then later in their work with learners, the

teachers' cellphilms are used to provoke and sustain ongoing conversations about community-based responses to challenges that arise in their lives, as well as recognizing resilience and opportunities for future organizing (MacEntee and Mandrona 2015). However, working with the cellphilm method also raises questions about participant consent to show cellphilms after a project ends, secure storage, and the cellphilms' accessibility for participant use in future projects.

Conceptualizing the Digital Archive

We consider recent literature defining digital archives, exploring the notion of the Internet as an archive, and how Internet archives can be conceptualized as participatory. Carter and Arroyo (2011) envision digital archives as spaces where democratic participation is not just permitted, but expected. Some academics posit that the Internet itself is an archive. For example, libraries have embraced digital archiving to enhance their participatory possibilities, including using mobile technology to engage diverse communities with their collections (Hopkins et al. 2014). In these settings, participatory digital archives can 'deepen community engagement and social inclusion, and to facilitate a participatory and learning culture—tapping into new communities, engaging with their stakeholders in meaningful ways, enhancing their social impact and transforming their essential roles in today's knowledge society' (Hopkins et al. 2014, 21). Others, such as Baron (2014, 140), contend that the Internet should not be considered a digital archive and that 'to call the internet an archive may be to extend the term "archive" too far, obscuring important distinctions and potentially making the term meaningless. If every collection of data is an archive, then what is not an archive?' Also noted are the contributions of Brake (2014), who point to the extent of the digital divide and how geography, gender, and socio-economic factors influence online content creation. Without equal access to computers and the Internet, the emancipatory claims of participant accessibility in online archiving are problematic.

What About YouTube as a Participatory Archival Space?

Despite the reservations about online archives as accessible participatory spaces, social media platforms such as YouTube offer potential benefits and challenges in relation to the participatory nature of digital archives.

Snelson (2015) points to YouTube's value in video-based research and pedagogical practices, as it is largely accessible to student-participants, already integrated in their out-of-school media practices, and it is relatively easy to navigate. Tripp (2012, 5) considers YouTube as a participatory space that facilitates the sharing of videos to encourage a 'democratically produced, decentralized public sphere'. Burgess and Green (2013, 41–42) conceptualize YouTube as a dichotomous space that comes:

> (E)ither from inside established media practice or outside of it. In doing so, YouTube is imagined as a space where these two categories co-exist and collide, but do not really converge: where familiar forms of mass media content will be encountered alongside amateur oddities (…) This dichotomy between the 'user-created' and 'traditional media' content is of course problematic for understanding YouTube as a site of new convergences and mutations of these categories.

Although they note that this binary creates an oversimplification, Burgess and Green's ideas suggest the difficulties of storing participatory visual data and working with the archive in this contested online space. Whereas Chau (2011) claims that participatory cultures are fostered by digital sharing platforms such as YouTube when young people use these online spaces to reflect their own ways of knowing, and learn from other youth across global contexts. Researchers and participants in marginalized and rural areas are also benefitting from the opportunities provided by the growth of digital spaces—often accessed via mobile technology (MacEntee, 2015b)—in facilitating dissemination and promoting social change (Mitchell et al. 2013; Skinnell 2010).

Others have less celebratory views of the possibilities of YouTube as a participatory space. For instance, Gehl (2011) argues that YouTube only pretends to democratize media, and the platform actually encourages big business and traditional media producers to curate content generated both by traditional and DIY media-makers. From these perspectives, YouTube is not neutral space, and while there is a tendency to look at archiving as a de-politicized practice, we need to critically consider what it means to integrate research data and outputs alongside and within for-profit corporate-controlled social media platforms (Snickars and Vonderau 2009). In light of these issues, there are considerable caveats in promoting YouTube as an accessible participatory archive for students and teachers.

Cellphilm Analysis Using the Participatory Digital Archive

Casey was inspired by participatory visual research (PVR) and participatory action research (PAR) approaches when she asked her students to make cellphilms. The method, in this regard, was intended to promote pre-service teachers to engage deeply with the PEI social studies curriculum, and promote agentic pedagogy (Ball 2000) so that learners have agency over what they learn and how they demonstrate that learning. The cellphilm method proved to be responsive to a diverse student body, while at the same time encouraging the pre-service teachers, themselves, to assert their developing professional identities.

After receiving project approval from both the McGill University and UPEI research ethics boards, Casey got in touch with her class and six (out of nine) of the students consented to participate in the research process. This involved Skyping with Casey for a semi-structured interview to talk about the cellphilm assignment and archiving their cellphilms on YouTube. The pre-service teachers' cellphilms and the digital archive alongside the interview transcripts were analyzed according to Charmaz's (2005) constant comparative approach.

The Student Cellphilms

In this project, the cellphilms were non-fictional and pre-service teachers played themselves. Each cellphilm consisted of multiple shots, and students edited these productions using the in-phone video applications *Magisto* or *Cameo*. These downloaded applications were linked to participant accounts, similar to YouTube. Each of the 5 cellphilms was between 60 and 90 seconds long. Guided by the prompt, 'Our Spaces/Our Selves', the pre-service teachers' cellphilms focused broadly on their constructions of teacher identities, and what it means to teach social studies on PEI.

In discussing the cellphilms that were created, participants are referred to using pseudonyms. Becky's cellphilm documented the behind-the-scenes process of cellphilming, from discussion to storyboarding, to filming, editing, and sharing the final products. Bryan's cellphilm *Live, Bike, Love* explored his sense of belonging, and a search for place by describing his passion for cycling, and its impact on his autonomy from his family and the place where he grew up. Maureen and Mark worked together to critique the gaps within the PEI Social Studies Curriculum from the perspective of indigenous people and Acadian Islanders. Deb's cellphilm interrogated her personal history and the way her identity affects her role

as a teacher. Joel's cellphilm was perhaps the most controversial for its depiction of (unidentifiable) participants attending an anti-abortion protest outside of the University campus. Joel suggested that his cellphilm explored understandings of civic engagement of pro-life activists in what he describes as an otherwise neutral space on the sidewalk outside the campus.

Viewing the digital archive during class time encouraged student reflection and participatory analysis of the cellphilms. In the individual interviews, Casey asked participants to reflect directly on this classroom experience. Mark noted that many of the cellphilms took up social justice themes, and Deb suggested that many of the archive's cellphilms explored issues of identity. Becky explained that:

> It was really fun to see how different people took on the [cellphilm prompt] differently. It was great to see how people perceived the assignment differently and what types of presentations people chose for their philms.

Deb echoed Becky's enthusiasm in regard to viewing the digital archive, and in seeing the production of other students' work, something that is not usually shared in the post-secondary classroom:

> I loved seeing other people's cellphilms [in the archive], and helping my classmates make cellphilms too. We were able to collaborate (…) and then see the rest of the class and how they took on and interpreted the prompt.

Joel reflected:

> I was amazed that everyone could come up with so many different [responses to the prompt] in such a short time period. It was also nice to see the styles that people used - some with only written words, some with music or spoken...

Maureen also indicated:

> I really enjoyed seeing the other cellphilms. The recurring themes I noticed were citizenship, minorities, history, geography.

This multiplicity of responses, indicated by Becky, Deb, Joel, and Maureen, suggests that the students were learning about their professional identities and citizenship practices through interacting with the cellphilm archive.

Specifically, working with the archive lead the participants to recognize the myriad ideas about civic engagement suggesting a growing sensitivity to diverse perspectives that may also emerge in their future classrooms.

The participants recognized the potential of the cellphilms and the cellphilm archive as pedagogical tools that they themselves could also use for subject-specific teaching. Becky suggested that:

> As a science teacher, I am still thinking of ways to incorporate cellphilms into the science classroom, although I feel it would be great to use in plant units and body system units where students can make short educational philms to share with their peers.

Joel reported that during his practice teaching placement, he went back to the participatory archive to show his students examples of cellphilming for his own teaching purposes. In this sense, YouTube facilitated the participants' ongoing engagement with the archive as a resource for their teaching practices. Maureen noted that, while the use of online social media as a digital archive itself had pedagogical merit—that is, YouTube can generally be accessed within most Canadian schools—the cellphilm method was limited because some school policies inhibited students' use of cellphones on school grounds:

> My concern is the resources and cell phone policies at the schools. Each school is different, and many do not allow cell phones or technology, while others are more liberal in their views on technology.

The pre-service teachers' reactions to the digital archive were nuanced by their ideas about cellphilm method as a teaching tool. We also see that policy frameworks about the suitability of cellphones within school environments indirectly influence the participatory archive. As such, the group raised important concerns over the appropriateness of cellphilming for particular subjects and the barriers in implementing the method with teachers and learners in schools.

Ethical Reflections

Barring contextual limitations posed by individual school policies, the interviews highlighted that the participants were overwhelmingly positive about cellphilm method and the ways in which the archive was being

used by the class. The data also revealed some unresolved ethical questions. These issues largely revolved around the complex consent process and how students controlled their cellphilms via the YouTube platform. Students gave permission to show the cellphilms within the classroom environment, however, they were not obliged to make their cellphilms publically available over the YouTube. Therefore the cellphilms were accessible only to Casey as course instructor. After the class had ended, the students-turned-research participants indicated consent for their cellphilms to be screened at academic conferences and other classroom settings for research purposes via the research ethics form. This research consent is long term and means that researchers have the ability to access the participants' cellphilms indefinitely. Importantly, using YouTube as an archive means the ability to remove or keep the videos online (and thus part of the research) remains with the filmmakers. YouTube's privacy settings are used so as to ensure that participants maintain control over their films in so much as participants are able to take their cellphilms offline at any time without having to consult the researchers. This means they can avoid potentially uncomfortable conversations or feeling guilty if they change their minds about having their cellphilms included in the visual archive in the long term. It also reduces the risk of participants feeling coerced by the researchers into keeping their video active should they wish to leave the project. As such, the playlist survives in its original state only as long as individual participants keep their videos on YouTube as either 'public' or 'unlisted'. If at any time the participants make their videos private, or remove their videos from YouTube, the archive will change. This co-construction of the archive is important because it aligns with the tenets of participatory video: knowledge should be co-created where the power is shared (Wheeler 2012). In these ways, ownership of the visual products remained with the participants and demonstrates that YouTube is an effective platform for digital archiving.

From our perspective as teacher educators and participatory visual researchers, even if participants did not raise issues of voice, representation, authorship, copyright, ownership, and ethics, they are critical concerns in our inquiry. From the interview data, it was clear that we had effectively 'persuaded' our participants of the pedagogical value of cellphilming and creating participatory archives; however, we also wondered if we had adequately alerted them to the ethical issues associated with these practices. Waycott et al. (2010) presented the opportunities in working with university students in the digital realm to create multimodal texts

as they drew on their lived experiences, collaborated with colleagues, and disseminated their work to large publics, while simultaneously presenting new ethical challenges regarding authorship and consent in classroom-based digital pedagogies. We wonder about how best to obtain ongoing consent from participants as time passes, and the cellphilms are shown in different environments, such as academic conferences. In particular, we continue to grapple with the ethical issues of using YouTube as a digital archive to store and disseminate the participants' cellphilms. YouTube servers are located in the USA, which means any information that is uploaded to these servers is subject to terms of services based in the state of California. This can include the cellphilms being subject to the USA Patriot Act. This legal policy raises ethical issues with regard to ownership and access to research data as well as the safety of research participants. We also have controversial surveillance issues being raised in Canada with the 2015 'anti-terror' legislation Bill C-51 where the government can monitor any online activity under the auspices of 'national safety'. The implications of this Bill have yet to be fully actualized, but we wonder, for example, about Joel's cellphilm that filmed anti-abortion activists. Putting our personal opposition to the pro-life moment aside for the moment, we also consider our role in posting video of any display of civil disobedience in a government state that is increasingly suspicious of acts of civic unrest. Indeed, these new policies could have serious implications for cellphilms and archiving with regard to surveillance and ownership.

Conclusion

This research helps illustrate how the creation of a participatory archive helps diminish the power differential between researcher and researched and offers opportunities for participants to engage with the cellphilms over a longer term. However, it is clear that the ethical challenges that remain with the participant-produced archive could be more clearly communicated to participants from the beginning of the project. Although the digital realm provides new spaces for teachers and students to represent their ways of knowing, this leads us to wonder: how might increased surveillance of digital practices encourage or threaten community-based participation in research and education? How might participant consent be continually negotiated in regard to a digital archive of cellphilms? How might participants be involved in defining 'safer' space to store digital media?

To these questions we look forward to the still unfolding cellphilm archive. We are still drawn to the possibilities for the cellphone as a tool for social change, especially in working with marginalized populations to raise pressing community concerns, and to do so in a creative medium. Cellphilming offers an important technique for creating these opportunities. The same could be argued for YouTube as a space for democratic dissemination and archiving. The ability to access the archive encouraged participants to engage in analysis of the themes that arose from the cellphilm collection and created a space for participants to 'speak back' (Mitchell et al. 2013, 1) to their previous understanding of history and citizenship while establishing themselves as emerging teachers. However, there are ethical issues associated with cellphilm archiving. In feedback on elements of another cellphilm project, our University's Research Ethics Board deemed that using YouTube as a digital archive for work produced by students did not warrant ethical review because the cellphilms were created in the classroom and the videos were made public by the students at that time. This feedback did not account for the ways that the Internet and digital media practices are pushing the limits of research practice, nor the necessity of the negotiation of ongoing consent in the construction of participatory archiving practices. Issues of access, data storage, privacy, and ownership of data must be carefully considered and managed when using technologies such as cellphones and YouTube where the line between public and private can be blurred. We continue to consider the possibilities and ethical implications as we negotiate the co-construction of participatory archiving practices.

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CHAPTER 17

The Politics of Visibility, Voice and Anonymity: Ethically Disseminating Visual Research Findings Without the Pictures

Dawn Mannay

Introduction

Contemporary society is characterised by an ocularcentric culture in which the visual image permeates our everyday lives; in parallel, the social sciences have witnessed an increasing move towards creative methodologies. However, in visual research, arguably, anonymity and confidentiality are almost impossible to guarantee (Sweetman 2009). Consequently, there have been calls for informed consent to be reconceptualised as something that is not fixed but fluid so that the use of images is continually negotiated with research participants (Cox et al. 2014); such participatory practice aims to rebalance the issue of unequal power in the research relationship (Wiles et al. 2008). However, once a visual image is created it becomes very difficult to control its use or remove it from the public arena if participants decide that they no longer want to be represented in a fixed visual trope for 'time immemorial' (Brady and Brown 2013, 102).

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While in many research contexts it is desirable to find ways of anonymising images, in other situations, disguising images can be tantamount to silencing the voice of participants. It is particularly problematic where researchers invest in the epistemological aims of participatory approaches predicated on giving 'voice' to participants (Kallio 2008; Thompson 2008). In contrast to an emphasis on 'protection' through anonymisation, Sweetman's (2009) 'politics of recognition' argues that collaborative projects in which participants are visible and recognisable are an alternative approach to ethical research.

Nevertheless, some participants may want a level of anonymity, and some topics may be particularly sensitive (Lomax 2015), and in such cases being visible and recognisable may not be practical, possible or ethical. Discourses around the ethics of visibility and invisibility have led to an impasse or 'crossroads' in visual research, whereby researchers are increasingly troubled by their ethical and moral obligations as visual researchers (Wiles et al. 2011). In response, this chapter considers the ethical challenges of disseminating visual images and the ways in which visual data can expose both participants and those in their social networks. The chapter offers alternative approaches to ethical and impactful dissemination of visual research findings, without the pictures.

The Study

To illustrate these issues, I discuss a study that was conducted in a marginalised housing area in urbanised south Wales, United Kingdom. The project employed visual techniques to explore the everyday lives of mothers and their daughters (Mannay 2010, 2013a). The project engaged with research methods that allowed space for subjectivities, listening to individual accounts to offer the opportunity to develop nuanced representations of people's lives that are otherwise marginalised.

Research was conducted in Hystryd,[1] one of the most deprived communities in Wales (Welsh Assembly Government 2008). As I had previously lived in the area, this shared sense of geography positioned me as 'experience near' (Anderson 2002, 23). Consequently, it was important to address my position as an indigenous researcher and make a deliberate cognitive effort to question my taken-for-granted assumptions of that which I had thought familiar (Delamont and Atkinson 1995). By offering participants expanded ways of expressing their stories, this avoided the propensity for participants' accounts to be overshadowed by the enclosed,

self-contained world of common understanding (see Mannay 2010). These techniques included photographs, maps and collages. In interviews, I explored the work produced by participants to ensure that I understood what they intended to communicate (Rose 2001).

These techniques were embedded within an ethnographic framework (Mannay and Morgan 2015) to provide an insight into intergenerational spaces of working-class femininity; however, they also raised issues that were unexpected, sensitive and previously unspoken (Mannay 2011, 2013b). This chapter reflects on these techniques, focusing on the ethical challenges of disseminating visual data. In particular, the following sections examine how studies that employ visual and creative techniques can engender particularly personal accounts which raise dilemmas around anonymity. The chapter also considers a wider application of anonymity that encompasses the position of research participants, the researcher and individuals who are unaware that they are a focus of research, as well as considering the ways in which future research can engage with researching and writing both creatively and ethically.

Exposing Personal Worlds: Participants and Non-consenting Others

As Gabb (2008) notes, in empirical qualitative studies of family life, the researcher inevitably becomes embedded in the personal worlds of those being researched; and within these personal worlds the future is often haunted by phantoms of the past, which impact upon the present (de Beauvoir 1949). These concerns can be accentuated when research studies employ visual techniques as the act of creating a visual image engenders techniques of 'defamiliarization' (Gurevitch 1998). Over time our perceptions of familiar, everyday situations become stale but visual data production can address this automization by forcing us to slow down our perception, to linger and to notice (Mannay 2010, 2016). Art and visual methodologies, therefore, may be elements that can overcome the confines of language and open up experience, but in doing so, participants may be confronted with elements of their lives that they manage to defend from consciousness in their everyday existence. Such techniques then can be seen as effective but there remain ethical considerations that engender a level of reflexivity for both researchers and participants.

Creating visual data can be accompanied by both defamiliarization (Gurevitch 1998), where participants slow down and re-evaluate their lives, and a form of free association where unconscious content is triggered; in this way, visual creativity contributes to a 'slow science', which enables time and space for reflection (Rivoal and Salazar 2013). In my work with mothers, such creative engagement surfaced memory work that was often characterized by experiences of domestic and familial abuse (Mannay 2011, 2013b). For Gabb (2010, 461), 'unsettling stories on emotional social worlds redefine our understandings of harm and distress and reconfigure ideas of responsible knowing'; accordingly, there is an important responsibility to connect wider audiences with the emotional weight of empirical evidence in such recollections.

As researchers we need to disseminate our findings in ways that not only contribute to policy debates, offer innovative methodological techniques and further theoretical dialogue, but it is also useful to connect with readers at an affective level because this can generate a higher level of engagement. Visual outputs can be an effective tool for accessing emotion and disseminating the power of participants' accounts. Accordingly, a 'politics of recognition' (Sweetman 2009) may well lead to greater impact; however, where topics are particularly sensitive (Lomax 2015) and where visual images act to represent, and fix, participants for 'time immemorial' (Brady and Brown 2013, 102) is recognition ethical? And importantly, who is made recognizable?

Visual Ethics can now be regarded as a specialist area within Visual Methodologies (Mitchell 2011) where researchers are discussing the limitations of participatory visual methods (Packard 2008) and critiquing the related philosophies, ethics and methodologies (Lomax 2012; Wall et al. 2012). However, much mainstream engagement with the ethics of visual ethnography focuses on issues of anonymity of place and participants so that the focus is on who is taking the picture, who is in the picture; and what else can be known from the geography or materiality of the image. Thus, the 'moral maze of image ethics' (Prosser 2000, 116) has been centrally concerned with the tension between revealing and concealing the contents of visual images (Cox et al. 2014; Lomax et al. 2011; Renold et al. 2008; Wiles et al. 2008).

These immediate concerns of anonymity and consent are important but they fail to encompass a wider application that appreciates the position of research participants, the researcher, and that of individuals who are unaware that they are a focus of research. Participants' accounts often

include a range of characters who are enlisted in the staging of their life story, and researchers are offered subjective perspectives of these other lives without their 'owners' informed consent. Consequently, it is important to think about those who are not in the picture, both in the respect that they do not form part of the research imagery (or can be easily deleted) and because of the point that they remain unaware that they have become part of the data set.

Visual images are widely recognised as having the potential to evoke emphatic understanding of the ways in which other people experience their worlds (Belin 2005; Mizen 2005; Pink 2004; Rose 2010). The creativity of art-based data production has the potential to open up experiences and offer new ways of knowing. However, images and the talk around the images are not simply representative of the individual participant; through their stories, researchers learn about the cast of participants' lives through many characters—sisters, brothers, fathers, mothers and friends (see Mannay 2011).

The presence of non-consenting others in the visual image is often seen as technically unproblematic as they can be deleted, blacked out or fragmented through digital pixelation (Wiles 2013). However, as Rose (2010) argues, family photographs are rarely thrown away because they are a material trace of the person photographed; in the same way, non-consenting others who appear in visual images will leave a trace even if they are visually masked. Focusing on applying a visual technique can act to side-line the importance of reflective engagement; however, shifting the focus will not overcome the problem.

Non-consenting others in research studies are unaware that their personal lives were ever subject to scrutiny, and this can be seen as unethical in itself. However, a further concern arises when researchers are indigenous or undertaking long term ethnographic research within a small community. Researchers active in the field may meet storied individuals who are unaware the consequences of their past actions have been explored. In order to maintain the confidentiality of participants, this knowledge must remain silenced; the researcher must remain neutral and resist any desire to confront or question the non-consenting other (Mannay 2011).

As Denzin (2009) contends, inquiry is, at all times, political and moral. As a researcher what I learnt in the field acted to compromise my relationships with others in ways that I did not envisage at the beginning of the ethnographic journey. Knowledge is often conceptualized as power, but in these circumstances, it also becomes disempowering. We are linked

in a complex web of connections so that when we ask our consenting participants about their own lives, we also learn about the lives of non-consenting others. This can be particularly difficult when creative techniques draw out defended memories into consciousness, and also when ethnographers have prior and/or ongoing sets of wider relations within the field. It is also important to consider that when we make our participants visible by publishing their visual images, we can also make their family, friends and the actual people who form the characters in their accounts visible through association. Therefore, it is important to explore how we can maintain the impact of visual research without relying on the images themselves to communicate our findings with wider audiences.

Disseminating Visual Research Findings Without the Pictures

As discussed in the previous sections, the responsibility of maintaining participant confidentiality must remain central when researchers are working with 'unsettling stories on emotional social worlds' (Gabb 2010, 461); and this can mean that the visual materials are not appropriate forms of dissemination. 'Time immemorial' (Brady and Brown 2013, 102) reminds us of the afterlife of images and how even though participants may want their images and accounts to be shared at the point of the research, in the following years, they may not want to be forever associated with a particular representation. Furthermore, the potential for images to be reworked and reused is particularly salient with the shift to Open Access publishing and the archiving of data sets (see Mannay 2014a).

Therefore, I have engaged with alternative and experimental forms of dissemination, which attempt to retain the impact of participants' data without compromising their anonymity. Importantly, dissemination without pictures also strengthens strategies to maintain the anonymity of non-consenting others, whose personal lives feature in studies. The following extract is taken from a larger poem that embedded words, images and events from participants' data. The poem was constructed long after the project, and was not a collaborative activity, rather the poem acts to disseminate participants' accounts, in an ethical form that retains their anonymity, while also retaining the affective power of the account: moving beyond the dense, dry, flat prose that form a 'linguistic armour' in much academic writing (Lerum 2001, 446). Consequently, poetry is one form of alternative dissemination that researchers could consider.

I like rough pubs
Words do not have to be measured
I have escaped from the waiting gaze on my face
I have escaped from the waiting game in this place
There will be no injury, no accusations, nothing to fear; here
I like rough pubs
I like rough pubs

The rules are easy to follow
Even the drunks have a certain predictability
And the toilets are safe; 'Ladies' with locks on doors
No one has ever punched my face; when sat and trapped
I like rough pubs
He hates rough pubs (Mannay 2013c, 135)

Violence was not my initial research focus; nonetheless, as Rock (2007, 30) contends, there is a 'need to remain open to the features that cannot be listed in advance of the study', and this family trouble was an invasive element in the construction of femininity (see Mannay 2013b). If we consider visual methods as techniques of defamiliarisation, then we must also realise that they may act to elicit memories that are painful for participants, implicate others within the wider research site and require careful strategies of protection. In response, as researchers, we must be ready to meet the challenge of hearing unsettling stories and to negotiate landscapes of trust and confidentiality; this needs to occur while still communicating the salience of participants' accounts, and their discussions of non-consenting others, which may well mean making the visual invisible; and instead employing creative forms of dissemination.

Thus, immersion in the lives of others cannot be easily forgotten; 'it engenders a sense of responsibility, to react, to act, and to find a way for what has been shared to translate into something worthwhile' (Mannay 2013c, 134). As Mills and Ratcliffe (2012, 155) argue, the ethnographer should be 'encouraged to acknowledge the complexity and unpredictability of the research encounter', and to meet this challenge in ethically responsible ways. In my own work (Mannay 2011, 2013c, 2014b), I have employed poetry to disseminate participants' stories in an ethical form that retains anonymity, while also retaining the affective power of these accounts.

Poetry, then, can be used to offer participants' accounts further decontextualization and anonymity, but can, 'at the same time, be applied to

a form that can increase understanding' by disrupting taken for granted meanings and challenging us to see and hear in new ways (Mannay 2016, 111). Poetry has been used creatively in academic writing (Richardson 2005). However, there are alternative forms from visual research that can also be successfully applied to negotiate the tension between concealing identity and giving voice, while also engaging audiences at an affective level and achieving impact. For example, the use of theatre where actors draw on the verbatim accounts of participants (see Richardson 2015) or the epistolary genre of letter writing where narratives are constructed from observations, video footage and interviews (see Carroll 2015). All these forms offer opportunities for the ethical dissemination of research findings from studies that draw on visual methodologies and potentially facilitate the translation of visual ideas.

Concluding Remarks

Reflecting on my ethnographic journeys, visual engagement can be advantageous, yet also complex and challenging, and critique is key to progressing research traditions. Therefore, the lessons that I have learnt are to embrace the notion that learning is an ongoing process; no method is a panacea for the problematic nature of qualitative research, and there are likely to be unintended consequences of our fieldwork; by accepting this, we can refine our craft and move beyond the 'indignity of speaking for others' (Spencer 2011, 15) to working and speaking with our participants. Visual and creative methodologies may generate different forms of data and allow new insights into participants' lives, nonetheless, the dissemination of these materials needs to be considered in relation to anonymity, confidentiality and time immemorial. For these reasons, visual researchers themselves need to remain ardent critics of creative work and to continue to explore landscapes of representation, interpretation, voice, trust, confidentiality, silence, and the intended and unintended consequences of research with images.

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Note

1. The place name Hystryd is fictitious and was chosen to maintain anonymity.

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CHAPTER 18

Research by Artists: Critically Integrating Ethical Frameworks

Lois Klassen

Introduction

The framing of art practices by way of ethical parameters is a prescient concern in both professional and academic settings. The understanding that people who encounter an artwork are implicated, along with the artist, in authoring the artwork's meaning has resulted in productive critique that extends beyond the usual research ethics discourse. Participants of what has come to be known as "socially engaged art," in particular, take on much more instrumental roles than those of artist's model, silent spectator, or gallery visitor. Employing approaches akin to community-based participatory research, art projects might involve artists in a blurring of artist/creator, community member, and advocate functions. At the same time, artworks that challenge normative ethics have produced critical discourse. In *Scandalous: A Reader on Art and Ethics*, editor Nina Möntmann describes how artists and writers make artistic representations to confront and resist neoliberal social strategies. These works demand openness to a range of "'ethical' or deliberately and provocatively 'unethical'" strategies by artists (Möntmann 2013, 18). Attending to this increasing preoccupation with ethics, Walead Beshty wonders if what is being witnessed is an "aesthetics of ethics," in which the dynamics

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of social relations take on aesthetic form (2015, 19). In his introduction to the *Ethics* volume of the Documents of Contemporary Art series from Whitechapel Gallery and MIT Press, Beshty reclaims the Greek origins of the term "aesthetics" as a site of perceivable or sensate change. Instead of reiterating arguments surrounding the ethics of aesthetics, Beshty's *Ethics* gathers texts, including artworks and artists' statements along with philosophical excerpts, that ask about the aesthetics of social relations. Overall, he posits that ethics is a current methodology in art that includes publicly situated art objects, "unethical" social interventions, and community-based art programming.

Similar to Beshty's observations, philosopher Simon Critchley asserts that "interesting art is always ethical," because it is "organized around ethical demand" (2013, 29). For Critchley, aesthetic forms work as a kind of "sublimation"—a psychoanalytically articulated process aimed at the experience of satisfaction in the midst of the tragic confrontation with "the real" (including social encounters with an "other"). In this way, the ethical demand posed by the real—such as our encounters with challenging social or political situations—may be revealed through aesthetic objects or processes (2007, 71–73).[1] For artists, the execution of an artwork is inseparable from its socially situated emergence—a situation that is increasingly inflected by ethical judgment from critics and institutions, as well as participants in the artwork's process of meaning making.

This chapter considers how current research by artists has been affected by increasing demands for "ethics," both in the regulatory contexts of research institutions and in the critical discourse encountered outside of universities, such as critical art texts, exhibition-related events, and other forms of public reception. From a set of key policy documents and researchers' rebuttals, three common themes emerge as relevant to artist-researchers and policy developers engaged in the integration of institutional ethical frameworks in sites of research by artists. First, research ethics review processes uncover unique challenges in situating artists' research in academic worlds. Second, often overlooked within academia, non-institutional practice standards present relevant ethical framing for artist-researchers and reviewers. Third, the perception of institutional "ethics creep" as manifest in censorship lingers as a specter over the integration of research ethics structures in sites of research by artists. An examination of these themes will be concluded by a set of recommendations to inspire further discussion and considerations for future policy development.

Reflecting on a Process of "Critical Integration": A Canadian Experience

The documents that chronicle the trajectory of research ethics policy integration into sites of research by artists in Canada can serve, well beyond this specific setting, as texts from which to parse key issues affecting artist-researchers. These include the demand of institutional research standards and a practice-based emphasis on ethical concerns. Indeed, though this analysis is based on available documents from the trajectory of Canadian research ethics policy development, the summaries depend on research from other qualitative research settings outside of Canada and speak to similar concerns in other jurisdictions. Although comprehensive guidelines for institutional research ethics review of government-funded research involving human participants in Canada have existed since the late 1990s, the adoption of these standards and processes in the area of research by artists has been gradual. The texts considered here span documents including stakeholder surveys, committee reports, and ad hoc submissions to the Secretariat on Responsible Conduct of Research (Secretariat). Overall, they record an awkward and incomplete process, whereby institutional research programs have struggled to integrate ethics review structures into emergent forms of research by artists.

The blanket guideline statement *Tri-Council Policy Statement: Ethical Conduct for Research Involving Humans* (TCPS) and its subsequent revisions (2010, 2014) have served as the de facto regulation statement for institutional research ethics review since 1998.[2] Not legislated in the same way as the US *Belmont Report*, the TCPS is enforced through research funding being contingent on compliance. Shortly after implementation, a 2001 survey on the impact of the TCPS on humanities and fine arts scholarship by the Humanities and Social Science Federation of Canada described the need for more involvement of humanities and fine arts researchers. In response, the Secretariat's Panel on Research Ethics authorized the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Ethics Special Working Committee (SSHWC) to examine the TCPS's impact on social sciences and humanities research in general. The SSHWC report, *Giving Voice to the Spectrum* (2004), was based on previously received and newly solicited feedback from researchers and research organizations, but admitted that it had failed to adequately account for the concerns of those engaged in "creation—and/or performance-based research." Later, in 2008, a more specific survey by the same committee informed another report; this

one proposed a specific chapter for the TCPS called "Research Involving Creative Practices"—a draft of which was included—as well as an additional chapter on qualitative research. The report, somewhat contradictorily, also suggested that creative practice be exempted entirely from mandatory research ethics review. When the 2010 revisions to the TCPS were finally released, a chapter on qualitative research was included, but one on creative practices was not. The TCPS2 instead offers a "creative practice exemption" for ethical review, albeit with a proviso. Article 2.6 describes how creative practice activities do not require institutional ethics review unless those activities generate what could be described as research data from participants:

> Creative practice activities, in and of themselves, do not require REB review. However, research that employs creative practice to obtain responses from participants that will be analyzed to answer a research question is subject to REB review. (Canadian Institutes of Health Research, Natural Sciences and Engineering Research Council of Canada, Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada, hereafter referred to as "CIHR et al." 2014)

Documents following the implementation of this "creative practice exemption" record both consternation and confusion on the part of affected artist-researchers. A letter of appeal from artist-researchers prepared by Sandeep Bhagwati and Devora Neumark (2010) reiterates some of the SSHWC's recommendations, including the need for more comprehensive exemption of research by artists from review standards borrowed from other disciplines, as well as a guidance chapter specific to research by artists. With 24 signatories from various Canadian university programs spanning art, music, theater, media art, performance, architecture, art history, creative writing, photography, sculpture, and computational arts, Bhagwati and Neumark's letter of appeal implores the Tri-Council's Panel on Research Ethics to acknowledge preexisting "principles and professional rules of conduct within the artistic community" that could guide academic research by artists, in the same way it affects non-academic practices (2010, 3).

These Canadian texts—the Tri-Council's statements, SSHWC's 2004 *Giving Voice to the Spectrum*, their 2008 "Research Involving Creative Practices" chapter proposal, and the Bhagwati and Neumark letter of appeal—inform the following summary of key issues affecting artist-researchers struggling to integrate research ethics demands into both institutional-based and practice-based research.

Research Ethics Uncover Challenges in Situating Artists in Research Worlds

The "creative practice exemption" is contingent on a specific definition of the term "research," given in the TCPS2 as an undertaking intended to "extend knowledge through a disciplined inquiry or systematic investigation." In the 2014 revision, "disciplined inquiry" is further described as "an inquiry conducted with the expectation that the method, results, and conclusions will be able to withstand the scrutiny of the relevant research community" (CIHR et al. 2014). Though this revision attempts to situate research within discipline-specific jurisdictions, the emphasis remains on non-artistic models of knowledge production. Whereas SSHWC's proposed chapter on creative practice acknowledges that research by artists may employ hypothesis testing or other qualitative research methodologies, the Bhagwati and Neumark letter of appeal describes the difficulties of conflating qualitative research standards in research creation that bridges academic and non-academic settings (2010, 3). SSHWC's chapter includes a myriad of research approaches:

> Arts-based research may be used to test hypotheses derived from many disciplines; discover new approaches for researchers inside and outside the Arts; ask questions which challenge commonly held beliefs; provoke debate on and exploration of a critical social issue; enable individuals or a society to see things from a different perspective; and/or empower individuals who lack a voice in their community, etc. (3)

This description differs substantially from the TCPS2 in its emphasis on innovation. "Art is supposed to surprise us," it asserts (2008, 3–4). Here innovation is privileged over disciplined inquiry or systematic investigation.

So far the terms "research by artists" and "artist-researchers" have been used in this chapter to include an unbounded category of creative practices and disciplines that could encompass visual art as well as music, other performing arts, and other creative practices in the humanities. In the specific documents described above, a surprisingly diverse list of terms are used: fine arts; creation- and/or performance-based researchers in the humanities; creative practice activities; university-based artistic practice; art-as-research; artistic knowledge production; practice-led research; practice-based research; and research-employing creative practices. Seen together, the terms reflect a conflation of practice and research whereby research is embedded in existing creative practices. This might be seen as

distinct from research that generates visual data using varied visual methods described elsewhere in this collection, in which creative practices could instead be understood to be embedded in research with aims other than the production of art. A term that is currently in wide circulation within the Canadian context and is used to articulate the specific work of artists whose work is situated within research contexts is "research-creation." The Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council (SSHRC), the primary funding agency for humanities research in Canada, defines research-creation as:

> An approach to research that combines creative and academic research practices, and supports the development of knowledge and innovation through artistic expression, scholarly investigation, and experimentation. The creation process is situated within the research activity and produces critically informed work in a variety of media (art forms). Research-creation cannot be limited to the interpretation or analysis of a creator's work, conventional works of technological development, or work that focuses on the creation of curricula. (2012)

The definition offered by the SSHRC, one of the agencies behind the production of the TCPS, appears to be less responsive to empirical knowledge production epistemologies than that of the TCPS2.

The complexities in combining the dual purposes of research toward production within creative practice and academic research has been a starting point for artists involved in research to explore the production of knowledge. Artist-researchers "use art to produce knowledge rather than knowledge to produce art," Risa Horowitz asserts in an editorial project for *RACAR: Revue d'art canadienne/Canadian Art Review* (2014, 25). The artist-researchers selected by Horowitz write candidly about the ways they produce academic research within art practices. The artists demonstrate how the term "research-creation" risks splitting academic art from non-institutionally produced art. *RACAR* contributor Donna Szoke writes: "As the term artist-researcher becomes a burgeoning category within academia, however, I question the basic tenets of this nomenclature. What fuels the expectation that artists can or must 'researchify' their practice? And does 'research' imply a rational order according to which we justify creative outcomes?" (2014, 34). A subsequent issue of the same journal responded to these practitioners' hesitation to "researchify" with a section edited by Natalie Loveless that advocated for a proliferation of diverse approaches to research-creation (2015, 42). Elsewhere, Owen Chapman and Kim Sawchuk test the scope of this terminology within digital humanities and social sciences. They

poetically and insightfully enumerate a family of research-creation terms for various modes of operations: research-for-creation; research-from-creation; creative presentations of research; and creation-as-research (2012, 15–21). In their exploration, Chapman and Sawchuk question if the TCPS2's creative practice exemption and its ill-fitting research definition have devalued research-creation by implying it is outside of an empirical human subject research model. In their estimation, "Questions regarding compliance with institutional research ethics protocols are extremely important in terms of the academic future of research-creation" (2012, 17). For artist-researcher Garnet Hertz, there are opportunities in the research ethics requirements that have been a necessary part of his interdisciplinary collaborations. For Hertz, concepts borrowed from biomedical and animal science have caused him to ask: "Is artmaking essentially a form of pure research?" and "Do artists create basic knowledge?" (2008, 10). His curiosity for scientific epistemologies by way of research ethics produced an expansion of his artistic inquiry. Whether artists take up the challenge of framing their work through research epistemologies or they resist it, these debates seem to be an unintended, albeit important, consequence of the process of integration of ethics review structures into the realm of research by artists. What remains to be realized is if artists' use of the term "research" is different from the terms, "to extend knowledge through a disciplined inquiry or systematic investigation," what expectations for ethics review are held by artists' own practice communities, and ultimately by publics, including participants of those diverse research activities.

Ethical Standards and Practices from Non-institutional Practices Are Relevant for Academic Researchers and Ethics Reviewers

The Bhagwati and Neumark letter of appeal from artist-researchers urges the Secretariat to "leave research employing creative practices entirely alone and let artists doing research-creation at universities apply existing professional and contextual rules of ethical conduct in their specific fields" (2010, 5). Similarly, SSHWC's proposed chapter acknowledges the double accountability that artist-researchers may face: "Ethics review in the arts requires a respect for the existing norms for cultural and artistic fields outside as well as inside academia and a recognition that artists must compete for grants, commissions and awards and function outside the university" (2008, 9). It describes a set of ethical considerations reflecting these norms. These include the awareness that the public often tolerates a degree of risk, challenge, and surprise in activities that are contextualized as

art; see Bolt in this collection for a further exploration of this. Participants' consent (as well as withdrawal) is often implicit in zones of artistic risk and challenge. The report also points out that artists have developed approaches to the representation of others that respects copyright legislation and authoring conventions. It explains that publicly engaged art often requires "periodic ethical review" in order to be responsive to emergent and changing methodologies. Finally, it summarizes existing ethical debates in art practices concerning cultural appropriation and the use of surveillance footage.

The guidelines in the SSHWC chapter are consistent with a flourishing dialogue outside of the academy. Pablo Helguera in *Education for Socially Engaged Art* advises that artists consider a set of ethical issues including an assessment of the nature of the communities involved, the settings or situations in which the work is located, the power dynamics inherent in the commission, and, finally, the way the audience's (or community's) reaction will be documented and circulated (2011, xxii and 76). Similarly, Nato Thompson, curator and director of Creative Time, a commissioning agency for socially engaged art projects in New York, describes the set of questions he applies in his analysis of work that will be situated in social and public settings: "Does the project actually provoke a reaction? Whom is it for? How does it resist instrumentalization? And finally, how does it line up with a larger framework of instrumentalization and power?" (2013, 117). Other theorists of socially engaged art like Grant Kester seek to articulate critical frameworks for evaluating what he describes as "dialogical art" projects. For Kester, this involves consideration of the duration of the project, the level of the artists' engagement in community issues, and the project's social policy context (2004, 137–139). Artist-researchers have also utilized other available ethical frameworks such as the "theatre of the oppressed," visual methodologies, or participatory action research. Given this increase of critical literature in practice-based ethics and the expansion of research-creation methods, the specific concerns outlined in SSHWC's proposed chapter are simply a starting point.

The Risk of Creative Censorship as a Result of Institutional "Ethics Creep" Presents a Fundamental Concern for Artists

Since the arts constituency carried a history of resisting similar controls as forms of creative censorship, SSHWC's initial report describes the possibility of critical resistance on the part of artist-researchers to the

integration of research ethics (2004, 10). Bhagwati and Neumark's subsequent letter of appeal also warns that imposed restrictions on artistic activities by way of ethics reviews could "endanger art's impact and importance as social commentary and critique" (2010, 28). Through the use of the term "ethics creep," the letter echoes a well-documented concern of qualitative researchers that ethics review structures form a seductive absorption of governmentality and constraint into research practices. The divisive nature of "ethics creep" discourse, beyond the issues raised by artist-researchers, has been described as producing emotive responses that are inexplicably greater than reactions to other academic demands. For Adrian Guta, Stephanie A. Nixon, and Michael G. Wilson, an analysis of the proliferation of "ethics creep" complaints requires both empirical review and a theoretical review (2012, 301–310).

Through a survey of research ethics reviewers (research ethics board and committee members) and staff, Guta, Nixon, and Wilson concur there is empirical evidence of an incursion of ethics board jurisdiction in the research landscape; research ethics personnel indicate that their role could or should be expanded. However, by applying Michel Foucault's conception of power and governmentality, the authors challenge previous analyses of "ethics creep." They suggest that a critical accounting of research ethics scope needs to be contextualized within a culture of commodified and technologized knowledge production (307). The increased demand for participant-informed research needs to be matched by increased innovation and resources for ethical review. This, write Guta, Nixon, and Wilson, could be understood as a form of internal resistance to other forms of institutional power working its way through the growth of participant research: "Foucault cautioned against one-sided analysis of power, and insisted that where there are exercises of power there will also be resistance" (307). These writers found evidence of resistance in the inventive accommodations for researchers offered by frontline research ethics workers such as ethics board members and staff. Their text describes how the TCPS2's chapter "Research Involving the First Nations, Inuit and Métis Peoples of Canada" formed an act of redress in the face of historic and ongoing exploitation of Aboriginal people by researchers. Investigating actual artistic censorship resulting from the integration of research ethics reviews would require a more specific study. The theme of censorship risk that runs through the existing documents requires a more thorough review, akin to the critical approach modeled by Guta, Nixon, and Wilson.

Conclusion

The themes of criticality in the midst of ethics encroachment in the artist-researcher community suggest that existing guidelines do not adequately match the rapidly developing discourses on ethics forming within artistic practices. To conclude this overview of Canadian documents and experiences, some provisional recommendations are offered to stimulate further interest and discussion.

First, since the "creative practice exemption" has produced unintended challenges to the status of research by artists, and because its application is arguably inconsistent, it needs to be revisited. The current growth and availability of critical resources for ethics in art (particularly with respect to the increasing prevalence of social practice art) suggests that ethical review is happening within and without academic ethics review processes, as was argued in the SSHWC documents as well as by the 2010 letter of appeal. Appraisal of the eligibility of the "creative practice exemption" based on the alignment of the research with social sciences knowledge production epistemologies has thoroughly been discounted as damaging to artistic disciplines, not just in the official documents but also by artist-researchers like Risa Horowitz, Owen Chapman, and Kim Sawchuk. Instead, researchers and ethics committees are advised to appraise the eligibility of the research for review based on artist-researchers' own disciplinary alignments (including where they situate their art, including their relationship to universities and other research agencies).

The university setting presents specific constraints as well as opportunities for artists, as Glen Lowry, chair of the Emily Carr University Art and Design Research Ethics Board, explained in an address to the annual conference of the Canadian Association of Research Ethics Boards (2015). Research by artists, when situated within universities, needs to be presented to the public as aligned with university-based research traditions and, as such, as reliant on the trust of a multitude of publics for both participation and funding. This is not to say that the benefits of research by artists need to be measured by epistemologically foreign measures (as with the TCPS2 expectation that research be structured around a research question and systematic evaluation of participant contributions). Instead, it challenges universities to situate ethics reviews of research by artists decidedly within disciplinary settings, so that not just the proposed methodologies but also the expectations of the various publics who are anticipated to receive the

work, whether they be institutional, arts practice-based, or otherwise, are considered.

Second, the resistance of artist-researchers to the instrumentalization of ethical principles for institutional risk management or other neoliberal agendas needs to be heard and incorporated into the practice of providing institutional ethics review services. Nina Möntmann quotes Simon Critchley in calling for "optimistic ethics of resistance" (2013, 17). "Ethics review sits at the precarious intersection of rapid changes to academic, institutional, and community cultures," write Adrian Guta, Stephanie Nixon, and Michael Wilson (2013, 303). Analysis and critique need to be both evidence and theory tested. Glen Lowry and Susan Cox, who both serve as ethics reviewers of art and design research in Canada, assert that "we need more stories about research ethics" in art contexts (2015). Published case studies, featuring analysis from researchers and practitioners from both inside and outside research institutions, could assist in developing dynamic ethical frameworks to inform artist-researchers, ethics educators, and reviewers. Integrating resources from non-academic art sources, like Möntmann's *Scandalous*, into ethics review may assist arts-based ethicists to support the public benefit of research by artists that presents a high degree of ethical demand or risk.

Finally, expertise is clearly available to situate emergent research by artists within a dynamic interdisciplinary discourse. For there not to be specific artist-research expertise available to direct the review of projects initiated by artist-researchers seems at this time indefensible. In reviewing responses of qualitative researchers to the implementation of research ethics review structures, it is apparent that in critically integrating ethics review frameworks into research by artists, the emphasis needs to be on moral agency. UK-based Sarah Banks, who initiated the European Social Ethics Project and who writes about ethics in social research and public policy, asserts that by virtue of the everyday issues faced by participatory research, "ethics as decision-making" needs to be emphasized over "ethics as regulation" (2013, 4). Both Banks and Adrian Guta (with Stephanie Nixon, Jacquie Gahgan, and Sarah Fielden) apply relational theoretical frameworks to the problems emerging from the existing institutional research ethics review structures in settings such as those of community-based participatory research (CBPR). For Banks, "everyday ethics" is inherent in the relational style of CBPR. In these settings of intense and sustained ethical demand, Banks asserts that researchers require relationship-based ethics review structures that follow "ethics of care" models

over the rights-based philosophies of principle-based ethics (2013, 14). Feminist relational ethics form a "critical counter discourse to normative ethics," in which ethics reviewers are seen to be allies as opposed to gatekeepers (Guta et al. 2012, 19, 22–23); the chapter by Cox in this collection extends this point.

Following the trajectory of an ethical turn in creative practices—including, of course, research by artists—the production of socially engaged artworks comprises an aesthetics of ethics that demands the critical and "everyday" engagement of not just its participants, who may be audiences, passersby, or highly invested stakeholders, but also the involvement of critics within the artists' disciplines, as well as critically informed and supportive ethics reviewers.

Notes

1. In *Infinitely Demanding: Ethics of Commitment, Politics of Resistance*, Critchley chooses to elaborate on how humor, instead of art, serves as an aesthetic form of sublimation, though he acknowledges Jacques Lacan's understanding of creative artistic activity as a sublimation strategy to reveal one's relation to death (2007, 72).
2. The "Tri-Council" of the country's national research funding agencies includes the Canadian Institutes of Health Research (CIHR), the Natural Science and Engineering Research Council of Canada (NSERC), and the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada (SSHRC). It administers and maintains research ethics guidelines through the aforementioned Secretariat.

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CHAPTER 19

From Adversaries to Allies: Ethical Review in the Context of Visual and Other Innovative Methods

Susan M. Cox

Out beyond ideas
of wrongdoing and rightdoing,
there is a field.
I'll meet you there.

—JELALUDDIN RUMI, 13th century

Introduction

The process of obtaining ethical approval is often seen by researchers as a bureaucratic hurdle that must be jumped before getting on with the real work of research. The process of institutional review may be lengthy and appear more concerned with minutia than with protecting research participants from serious risk. It may seem to impose inappropriate standards for social research, misconstrue the rigour of the chosen methods and impose problematic delays and/or otherwise obstruct important new studies (Haggerty 2004; Van Den Hoonard 2011). Moreover, such threats may have special significance when researchers propose innovative approaches to studying sensitive topics, adopt unusual methodological strategies or

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attempt to forge new kinds of working relationships with research participants. Or so the adversarial story goes.

Drawing upon exemplary institutional contexts as well as selected research findings from empirical studies of research ethics, this chapter identifies a range of strategies supporting an alternative paradigm for ethical review. This alternative paradigm is one in which research ethics committees, researchers and research participants engage in regular dialogue and exchange of ideas; in short, they become allies rather than adversaries in the process of ensuring that research is ethically as well as methodologically sound.

Systems of Human Research Protection

As a prelude to exploring the efforts being made to shift from an adversarial approach to a new kind of alliance between researchers and research ethics committees or boards, it is helpful to briefly consider the basis for our current systems of human research protection and, in consequence, how it is that ethical review processes are often adversarial.

Most countries in the developed world require that health and other research involving human participants is formally approved by a process of institutional review. In Canada, the body charged with this task is a research ethics board (REB); in the United States, it is an institutional review board (IRB); and in Australia and the United Kingdom, it is a research ethics committee (REC).[1] In Canada, the *Tri-Council Policy Statement* (2nd edition) sets out the conditions for and process of ethical oversight, the structure and composition of the REB and basic principles informing ethical research design and conduct. The United States follows *The Federal Policy for the Protection of Human Subjects* (or the "Common Rule") while Australia has the *National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research (NSECHR)*. In the United Kingdom, the *Research Governance Framework for Health and Social Care* applies to health research, while the Economic and Social Research Council (ESRC) has a parallel document, the *Research Ethics Framework* that applies to all social science research. Other nations have other documents and there are also international norms and conventions (such as the *Declaration of Helsinki* or the *CIOMS International Ethics Guidelines for Research Involving Human Subjects*) that provide an overarching framework and/or specific guidance in countries that have not yet developed their own national policies or ethical review mechanisms.

A common feature is that the systems of ethical oversight these documents describe operate primarily on a rule-compliance basis (McDonald and Cox 2009). In a compliance-oriented culture, it is the rules that are the ultimate basis for decisions. In contrast, an ethics oriented culture gives priority to the ethical beliefs and convictions which underlie rules or policies. Thus, it is important to interpret and apply rules or policies in relation to salient ethical values (such as honesty or responsibility) and cultural norms; in short, to honour the spirit of the rules as well as the letter.

As scholars of research ethics have argued, the rules guiding our systems of human research protection (as set out in many documents) are a direct response to the troubled history of the misuse and abuse of research subjects in biomedical and other research-related experimentation, especially during World War II. From the *Nuremberg Code* to the *Belmont Report*, such documents have respectively attempted to set out standards against which independent reviewers can assess the ethical conduct of researchers and offer a set of principles useful in resolving ethical problems that arise in research involving human subjects. Given the historical context within which these standards emerged, emphasis was placed on strict adherence to the letter of the law. There was no ethical wiggle room.

In Canada and elsewhere, the establishment of national systems of ethical oversight that apply to all research with human participants, regardless of discipline or topic, initially led to much dissension in non-biomedical fields (Van den Hoonard 2011; Chalmers and Pettit 1998). Some social science researchers argued that, as important as it was to create standards preventing the abuse of human subjects in biomedical experimentation, such standards are inappropriately applied in the context of non-biomedical research. For example, it became a familiar refrain that the survey or interview methods typically used in the social sciences do not expose subjects to significant levels of bodily risk; nor do they require consent to invasive physical and other regimens. Moreover, when such standards are applied in the context of a rule oriented institutional culture, they cause unnecessary bureaucratic delays, interfere with scholarly autonomy and intrude upon the ability of social researchers to get on with their research. Given that many ethics review bodies have not, until recently, had sufficient expertise in qualitative methods, it is not surprising that such complaints have historically been especially pronounced for qualitative researchers who adopt research designs, standards and approaches that fall outside the traditional scientific norms of quantitative, positivist and/or biomedical research.

Much ink has been spilled in debating what to do about tensions arising from ethical review of social science research. Accusations of bureaucratic overreach or "ethics creep," wherein our systems of ethical review have seemingly become empowered to expand their mission into inappropriate areas, such as the assessment of methodology, have been aired vociferously. In Canada, social researchers (Haggerty 2004; Van den Hoonard 2011) who decried the loss of scholarly productivity arising from the ethical review process also pointed to the negative influence of bureaucratic overreach on the scope of allowable research. Other social researchers have argued that such complaints themselves are an indication of both social researchers' passive withdrawal from the review process (Bosk and DeVries 2004) and the need for improved lines of communication between researchers and the research ethics review process (Hallowell and Lawton 2006; Ells 2011).

To summarize, there have been two main camps in these debates: researchers who have actively resisted the need for ethical review of social science research, and those who have, notwithstanding some complaints, identified that social researchers need to play a more active role in the system by educating members of the institutional review process, studying how the review processes work and getting involved with the process of ethical review. It is probably fair to say that the latter view has had considerable effect as social researchers in many countries have become much more extensively involved in working within systems of ethical oversight to review qualitative research, advise and educate on qualitative approaches and ensure that documents describing guidelines for ethical research are adapted to the particularities of qualitative and other non-traditional research methods. For instance, the second edition of the Canadian TCPS now contains an entire chapter on qualitative methods, while the Australian *NSECHR* contains a section describing ethical considerations specific to qualitative methods. Likewise, the last decade has witnessed a new emphasis in research on research ethics, including studies on the workings of ethical review bodies.[2] Perhaps, as a consequence of the insights of such studies, there is now some greater appreciation for the volume and scope of work undertaken by those who serve on these bodies.

To say that all is now smooth sailing would, however, be overstating the case. As this book on visual methods and ethics attests, the world of research methods continues to evolve, incorporating diverse technological advances and adopting new and innovative approaches to doing research

in and about the social world. Social researchers therefore remain concerned that innovative methodologies that are either poorly understood at the level of ethical review or raise challenging or unfamiliar ethical issues simply will not obtain ethical approval. Van de Hoonard (2011), for one, argues that ethics review bodies are, through their overzealous guardianship role, transforming the very nature of research methods by narrowing the acceptable range of approaches and fostering a kind of "pauperization" (p. 3). As creative practice and research-based artistic projects begin to fall within the scope of ethics review, artists also question whether their goals may be incommensurable with those of research ethics. As the Bolt chapter in this collection attests, art is often explicitly intended to make us uncomfortable and perhaps even upset. And, as the McLeod and Guillemin chapter indicates, the use of visual methods may generate potential harms for researchers who are unexpectedly affected by research processes. How then are the aims of visual art and visual research to be reconciled with ethical injunctions about minimizing harm?

Within a system that remains largely adversarial, there are "two interacting forces in tension: methodological development pushing forward ethical research practice and institutionalized research ethics practices pushing back methodological developments" (Nind et al. 2013: 256). Thus, we are at a critical juncture with respect to evolving a system of ethical review that is capable of appropriately evaluating the ethical implications of a diverse and rapidly expanding range of methodological innovations. The dynamics of an adversarial approach, in which the primary function of the ethics review body is conceptualized as negative (i.e., concern with prevention of unethical research, minimization of risk and avoidance of institutional liability) casts researchers as if they were potential offenders who are only interested in their own research goals while reviewers are protectors that seem to be the only ones interested in maintaining ethical standards. This sort of adversarial stance serves neither the interests of researchers nor the system of ethical review. It is, however, remediable if concerted attention is given to evolving effective ways and means for those involved in conducting ethical review to work with researchers and for both to attend more closely to the experiences of research participants.

From Adversaries to Allies

Drawing upon exemplary institutional contexts as well as selected projects employing visual and other innovative methods, this section identifies and

explores a range of strategies supporting an alternative paradigm for ethical review. This alternative paradigm is one in which ethics review bodies, researchers and research participants engage in dialogue and become allies in the process of ensuring that visual and other innovative approaches to research are ethically as well as methodologically sound. The intended scope for this alternative paradigm includes the full spectrum of visual, arts-based and other innovative methods of research, as well as more traditional qualitative and quantitative approaches.

What Are Ethics Review Bodies Doing to Create a Less Adversarial Climate for Ethical Review?

The most frequently echoed recommendations for creating a less adversarial climate for ethical review involve improved communication, openness and transparency between ethics review bodies and researchers. These recommendations pertain to research employing the full spectrum of methods, not just visual or innovative approaches. Of particular relevance to researchers using non-traditional methods are recommendations supporting the creation and use of appropriate forms and application processes for qualitative and arts-based research and the need to ensure relevant disciplinary and/or methodological expertise is present or available to assist ethics review bodies during review. Some also advocate increased researcher participation in the discussions and deliberations that inform the ethical review process, especially where mutual dialogue can address misunderstandings arising from poor communication or identify questions that if left unanswered might otherwise delay the approval process. Likewise, it may in some cases be relevant to encourage greater involvement of relevant communities in the ethics review process, either through an advisory role or through creation of an independent review body as, for example, in the case of the formation of community review panels that assess the feasibility of research with specific and often-times vulnerable populations.

Two examples of Canadian research-intensive institutions with a strong focus on programs in art and design offer valuable insights into how the process of ethical review can be made especially responsive to the needs and interests of researchers employing visual or other innovative methods. At Concordia University in Montréal, a “facilitative approach to ethical review” entails adherence to specific values and practices that support an ethics, rather than compliance, oriented culture (Connolly and Reid 2007). Four salient features of the organizational ethics culture underpin

this. The first is pro-research values. This involves an orientation towards facilitating rather than merely auditing research. The second is an inherent trust in researchers' knowledge and expertise as it is supported by the culture of various disciplines. The third is a commitment to resist "mission creep" by focusing on the ethics elements of each research protocol and allowing for scholarly peer review of the research methodology. Finally, there is an appreciation for methodological innovation and diverse research cultures. Especially in cases where there is a lack of established benefit associated with new and innovative methods, the principle of beneficence is invoked to ensure that the ethics review process does not impose needless constraints on worthwhile projects. In practice this means that when the research has undergone peer review and is deemed methodologically sound, risk/benefit analyses consider *potential* benefits of the research and do not insist on evidence of such benefits prior to approval.[3]

At Emily Carr University of Art and Design (ECUAD) in Vancouver, there is a comprehensive vision guiding the work of the research ethics board. The ECUAD Research Ethics Board considers itself to be "a learning board," wherein education about research ethics for all those involved in research is a core purpose of the board and a key aspect of its service. The vision is supported by practices that include fostering a climate of openness, trust and mutual respect through specific educational events and community outreach, a commitment to work closely with researchers and instructors to assist with preparation and revision of ethics applications prior to submission, rapid turnaround and timely approval wherever possible, and development of *in situ* responses to emerging ethical questions (e.g., clarifying the differences between creative practice and arts-based research in order to determine when ethics review is necessary). It is also important to note the ECUAD REB recognizes that the process of ethical review raises new and sometimes volatile issues when applied to artistic and creative practice. Thus, it is sometimes necessary to enlist outside expertise in designing procedures and policies that acknowledge disciplinary differences and support risk-taking in research utilizing new and innovative methods.

What Do Researchers Need in Order to Create a Less Adversarial Climate for Ethical Review?

Many innovative researchers are cautious as well as creative and are concerned to ensure that their research meets high ethical standards. Examining the relationship between methodological innovation and ethics in qualitative research, Nind et al. (2013) conclude that although there

are significant tensions, methodological innovation is often as much about managing risk as it about creating new risks.

From the standpoint of researchers, much rests on the pivotal issue of how the relationship between ethics and methods is conceptualized. The adversarial paradigm for ethical review tends to equate ethics with rules and procedures that researchers must comply with. The "methods is ethics" school of thought offers a more comprehensive view. As social scientists Hallowell and Lawton (2006) suggest, ethics is not only about informed consent and maintaining privacy. It pervades all aspects of research from design to dissemination. Further, as research is an inherently moral undertaking, researchers ought to be willing to examine and reflect upon all aspects of what they do as researchers (Hallowell et al. 2004).

This emphasis on the importance of "ethics in practice" as well as procedural ethics is reflected in Guillemin and Gillam's (2004) call for greater reflexivity on the part of researchers. As they suggest, "adopting a reflexive research process means a continuous process of critical scrutiny and interpretation, not just in relation to the research methods and the data but also to the researcher, participants, and the research context" (Guillemin and Gillam 2004: 275). This also entails sensitivity to "ethically important moments" in research practice and having or being able to develop a means of addressing and responding to ethical concerns if and when they arise in the research, including ways of preempting potential ethical problems (Guillemin and Gillam 2004: 276). As Harris as well as Burkholder and MacEntee identify in their respective chapters on the use of YouTube and other publicly accessible repositories of images, research that is not required to undergo ethical review may nonetheless place significant burdens on the researcher to identify and respond to salient ethical concerns. And, in the world of creative practice, the exemption from ethical review may, as Klassen asks in her chapter, devalue research-creation by implying that it operates through different or perhaps less rigorous epistemologies than more traditional empirical research.

With visual and other innovative approaches to research, it is sometimes difficult to isolate ethical issues arising in fieldwork from methodological and aesthetic matters (Cox and Boydell 2015). Moreover, some issues may require immediate resolution and the pragmatics of the research situation may not fit easily into more abstract conceptualizations of what is ethical. As researchers venture into this relatively uncharted territory (Cox et al. 2014), it would be enormously beneficial to share ongoing experiences with ethical challenges and their possible solutions. As Plummer (2001: 229) argues,

> We need stories and narratives of research ethics to help fashion our research lives, and to see the kind of broader principle…which they can then draw upon… By and large, researchers do not follow binding universal rules, their ethics may draw from such rules but it surely applies them in situated contexts.

Stories of research ethics are then a vital means of sharing the kind of situated ethics that arise in research employing visual and other innovative approaches. When published or archived and made available to the broader community, such stories also offer a source of guidance to other researchers seeking advice on what to anticipate when utilizing new methods or searching for solutions to existing ethical challenges, be they related to procedural ethics or ethics in practice. Members of ethics review bodies might also find that such stories are both informative and useful in shedding new light on the ethics review process as it is experienced by researchers.[4]

How Could the Experiences of Research Participants Inform Ethical Review?

Although protracted attention has, in many countries, been given to the development of systems of ethical oversight, very little corresponding attention has been given to understanding and documenting the experiences of research participants. Little is known about what research participation means to participants (Cox and McDonald 2013), why they decide to participate and how they experience the burdens and benefits of research. This is true of many types of research, not just those employing visual or other innovative methodologies. There is, therefore, an urgent need for evidence about what is occurring, especially with regard to how participants experience the benefits and burdens of research participation in the context of research that employs methods that are poorly understood by ethics review bodies and/or are seen as ethically more or less risky than they may actually be.

In the absence of evidence about participants' experiences of research and appropriate channels for systematic feedback of this knowledge to ethics review bodies, individual reviewers must try to put themselves in the position of research participants and imagine what the experience might be like (McDonald et al. 2013). Especially when assessing studies involving unfamiliar or innovative research methods, this need to rely on a process of "imaginative identification" means that reviewers may be

either overly or insufficiently protective in assessing possible risks as well as benefits to participants. Further, as Gillam et al. (2009: 8) found, only a small number of human research ethics committee members employing imaginative identification are aware that one pitfall is that "those using it might tend to bring along their own values, preferences and experiences when imagining what it would be like for the other person."

Asking research participants to reflect on their experiences of research participation is something that many researchers could incorporate into their research design with little or no additional cost and with potentially great benefit. Participants are often uniquely positioned to offer suggestions about what would improve their experience and/or remedy ethical or other tensions. They may even be able to identify aspects of the research or ethical issues that researchers are themselves unaware of (Townsend et al. 2014). For these and other reasons, it would be especially helpful for researchers utilizing visual and other innovative methods to document and share the experiences of participants, ensuring also that ethics review bodies are aware of how participants respond to new or unfamiliar methodologies.

Towards an Alternative Paradigm for Ethical Review

This chapter offers a contrast between the predominant compliance-based adversarial approach to ethical review and an emerging alternative paradigm that is facilitative and values based in its emphasis on supporting innovative and ethically sound research. It also upholds the importance of transparency, openness, trust, mutual respect, responsibility and respect for all parties.

This chapter has also offered examples and suggestions for how ethical review bodies, researchers and research participants could become allies in the process of ensuring that visual and other innovative research is ethically as well as methodologically sound. The relationship between being innovative and being a responsible and effective researcher is complicated, as ethics requires "more than the avoidance of harm prioritised in the regulatory approach, but a balance of risk, efficacy, justice and respect … and promotion of integrity, quality and transparency" (Nind et al. 2013: 651). Thus, there is, in short, a need to proceed with caution with innovative methods by showing how such methods are appropriate and safe and what the specific impacts are for participants from participant perspectives.

Notes

1. From here on, the generic term "ethics review bodies" will be used when referring to the REB, IRB and REC or other similar committees or boards.
2. See, for example, *Journal of Empirical Research on Human Research Ethics.*
3. The ethical review processes associated with two qualitative projects (using performance ethnography and visual methods) are described in detail in Connolly and Reid (2007).
4. See, for example, a case study on the institutional ethical review process as it unfolded in the context of ethnographic research involving injection drug users (Small et al. 2014).

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